

Into Action Group

A FACILITATOR'S GUIDE

Questions for the
Plain Language Big Book

Discussion Questions for Book Study Meetings

Foreword through Chapter 11

1725 Questions

*This guide is designed to be used alongside the
Plain Language Big Book of Alcoholics Anonymous.*

The Serenity Prayer

*God, grant me the serenity
to accept the things I cannot change,
courage to change the things I can,
and wisdom to know the difference.*

*Living one day at a time,
enjoying one moment at a time;
accepting hardships as the pathway to peace;
taking, as He did, this sinful world
as it is, not as I would have it;
trusting that He will make all things right
if I surrender to His Will;
so that I may be reasonably happy in this life
and supremely happy with Him
forever and ever in the next.*

Amen.

The Twelve Steps of Alcoholics Anonymous

- 1.** We admitted we were powerless over alcohol — that our lives had become unmanageable.
- 2.** Came to believe that a Power greater than ourselves could restore us to sanity.
- 3.** Made a decision to turn our will and our lives over to the care of God as we understood Him.
- 4.** Made a searching and fearless moral inventory of ourselves.
- 5.** Admitted to God, to ourselves, and to another human being the exact nature of our wrongs.
- 6.** Were entirely ready to have God remove all these defects of character.
- 7.** Humbly asked Him to remove our shortcomings.
- 8.** Made a list of all persons we had harmed, and became willing to make amends to them all.
- 9.** Made direct amends to such people wherever possible, except when to do so would injure them or others.
- 10.** Continued to take personal inventory and when we were wrong promptly admitted it.
- 11.** Sought through prayer and meditation to improve our conscious contact with God as we understood Him, praying only for knowledge of His will for us and the power to carry that out.
- 12.** Having had a spiritual awakening as the result of these steps, we tried to carry this message to alcoholics, and to practice these principles in all our affairs.

The Twelve Traditions of Alcoholics Anonymous

- 1.** Our common welfare should come first; personal recovery depends upon A.A. unity.
- 2.** For our group purpose there is but one ultimate authority — a loving God as He may express Himself in our group conscience. Our leaders are but trusted servants; they do not govern.
- 3.** The only requirement for A.A. membership is a desire to stop drinking.
- 4.** Each group should be autonomous except in matters affecting other groups or A.A. as a whole.
- 5.** Each group has but one primary purpose — to carry its message to the alcoholic who still suffers.
- 6.** An A.A. group ought never endorse, finance, or lend the A.A. name to any related facility or outside enterprise, lest problems of money, property, and prestige divert us from our primary purpose.
- 7.** Every A.A. group ought to be fully self-supporting, declining outside contributions.
- 8.** Alcoholics Anonymous should remain forever nonprofessional, but our service centers may employ special workers.
- 9.** A.A., as such, ought never be organized; but we may create service boards or committees directly responsible to those they serve.
- 10.** Alcoholics Anonymous has no opinion on outside issues; hence the A.A. name ought never be drawn into public controversy.
- 11.** Our public relations policy is based on attraction rather than promotion; we need always maintain personal anonymity at the level of press, radio, and films.
- 12.** Anonymity is the spiritual foundation of all our traditions, ever reminding us to place principles before personalities.

Just for Today

Just for today I will try to live through this day only, and not tackle my whole life problem at once. I can do something for twelve hours that would appal me if I felt that I had to keep it up for a lifetime.

Just for today I will be happy. Most folks are as happy as they make up their minds to be.

Just for today I will adjust myself to what is, and not try to adjust everything to my own desires. I will take my luck as it comes, and fit myself to it.

Just for today I will try to strengthen my mind. I will study. I will learn something useful. I will not be a mental loafer. I will read something that requires effort, thought and concentration.

Just for today I will exercise my soul in three ways: I will do somebody a good turn, and not get found out; if anybody knows of it, it will not count. I will do at least two things I don't want to do — just for exercise. I will not show anyone that my feelings are hurt; they may be hurt, but today I will not show it.

Just for today I will be agreeable. I will look as well as I can, dress becomingly, talk low, act courteously, criticise not one bit, not find fault with anything and not try to improve or regulate anybody except myself.

Just for today I will have a programme. I may not follow it exactly, but I will have it. I will save myself from two pests: hurry and indecision.

Just for today I will have a quiet half hour all by myself, and relax. During this half hour, sometime, I will try to get a better perspective of my life.

Just for today I will be unafraid. Especially I will not be afraid to enjoy what is beautiful, and to believe that as I give to the world, so the world will give to me.

How to Use This Guide

This guide was created for facilitators and participants of Big Book study meetings. It is organized to follow the Plain Language Big Book from the Foreword through Chapter 11, section by section.

Each section contains exactly 15 discussion questions. After the content sections, you will find three additional sections per chapter:

Closing Prompts bring the chapter's themes together and invite personal reflection on the material as a whole.

Principles in This Chapter identify the spiritual principles at work and ask how they are being practiced in daily life.

Putting It Into Practice offers concrete, actionable steps to carry the chapter's lessons into the week ahead.

The questions are designed to invite sharing of experience, strength, and hope. They are anchored directly to the text and ask how principles show up in real life. They examine behavior, not theory. They encourage ownership without shaming and point toward change, action, and spiritual growth.

This is a Big Book study meeting, not a classroom, not a debate, and not therapy. The tone is serious, clear, and grounded in practical spirituality.

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Foreword & The Doctor's Opinion

5 Sections • 75 Questions

Foreword

1. The Foreword tells the story of a New York businessman and an Akron doctor meeting for the first time in 1935. What does the simplicity of two alcoholics talking to each other say about how recovery actually begins?
2. The text says the businessman's drinking was destroying his life—his marriage and business were ruined, and he felt confused and scared all the time. Describe the moment in your own life when you realized that alcohol was destroying more than just your health.
3. The Foreword says the businessman had tried many different things to stop drinking and nothing seemed to work. What methods did you try before A.A., and what made this program different from everything else?
4. The text says Dr. Silkworth was one of the first doctors who saw alcoholism as a kind of disease, and before that many people believed alcoholics were weak or sinful or stupid. How did the way people talked about your drinking change when you or they began to see it as an illness?
5. The Foreword says the businessman felt less shame about his drinking when he thought of it as a disease. How has the concept of alcoholism as a sickness affected the shame you carry about your own behavior?
6. The text describes the Oxford Group's belief that selfishness and fear were the cause of all human problems. How does that idea land with you when you look at your own drinking career?
7. The Foreword says the Oxford Group asked members to apologize to people they had hurt, make lists of strengths and weaknesses, and help others. Which of these practices was hardest for you to begin when you entered the program?
8. The text says the businessman believed that only alcoholics could help other alcoholics stop drinking. Why is this idea so central to the way A.A. works, and how have you experienced it yourself?
9. The Foreword says the businessman was far from home, his business trip had gone badly, and he wanted to drink very much. Describe a time when distance from home, stress, or failure made you desperate to drink.
10. The text says the businessman needed to tell his story to another alcoholic as soon as possible, and believed that talking would keep him from drinking. Who was the first person you told your story to, and what happened when you did?
11. The Foreword says the businessman made a series of phone calls until someone suggested he talk to a doctor with a drinking problem. What does this desperation to find another alcoholic teach you about the urgency of connection in recovery?
12. The text says the two men got together and spoke for a long time about the things they had been through. How has a long honest conversation with another alcoholic changed the trajectory of your recovery?
13. The Foreword says it all started when two men decided to talk to each other, and their wisdom and self-sacrifice have saved more lives than we can ever count. What conversation in your own recovery has had the most lasting impact on your sobriety?
14. The text says reading and writing have helped the A.A. program grow and spread, and the Big Book has been translated into more than 70 languages. How has reading this book specifically helped you understand your own condition?

- 15.** The Foreword ends by saying if you are ready to begin your own A.A. journey right now, just turn the page. How ready are you to turn the page on your old life and start something new?

The Doctor's Opinion

- 1.** The text says A.A. members believe anyone who reads this book will want to know the opinions of medical doctors and will want evidence that the program works. How important was it to you to hear from a medical professional that A.A. could actually help?
- 2.** The chapter says you may want evidence that the program works from someone outside the organization before you commit to getting sober. What kind of proof did you need before you were willing to take the first step?
- 3.** The text says Dr. Silkworth ran a hospital for drug and alcohol addictions and one of his patients was Bill W., the co-founder of A.A. How does knowing that a doctor who treated thousands of alcoholics endorsed this program affect your confidence in it?
- 4.** The chapter says when A.A. was getting started, some alcoholics felt unsure about joining and wanted proof that the program could help them. What made you feel unsure about joining, and what eventually tipped you toward saying yes?
- 5.** The text says Dr. Silkworth wrote a letter saying he had seen the program work for many alcoholics, and the co-founders could show this letter to anyone who had doubts. What piece of evidence or testimony from another person first made you believe recovery was possible for you?
- 6.** The chapter says in Dr. Silkworth's second letter, he says he believes both the bodies and minds of alcoholics are affected by their alcoholism. How has understanding alcoholism as a physical and mental condition changed the way you think about your own drinking?
- 7.** The text says A.A. members are often told that we are unstable and running away from our real lives. How has being dismissed or judged by others affected your willingness to seek help?
- 8.** The chapter says we felt certain that our struggles weren't just mental but also physical—alcoholism was in our bodies too. What physical symptoms of your alcoholism convinced you that this was more than a thinking problem?
- 9.** The text says we are grateful to Dr. Silkworth for confirming that alcoholism affects both body and mind. How did hearing a doctor validate what you already suspected about yourself change the way you approached recovery?
- 10.** The chapter says the A.A. program helps alcoholics work through their problems with beliefs and spirituality. How has the combination of medical understanding and spiritual practice worked together in your own recovery?
- 11.** The text says anyone whose mind is still foggy from alcohol should consider spending time in the hospital before joining A.A., because being clear-headed helps alcoholics understand what is being taught. How clear was your mind when you first encountered the program, and how did that affect your ability to absorb it?
- 12.** The chapter describes an irresistible urge to drink and obsessive thoughts about alcohol that compel the drinker to keep drinking. How do you describe the craving to someone who has never experienced it?
- 13.** The text says Dr. Silkworth helped the co-founders by giving their program medical credibility. Who in your life outside of A.A. has validated your recovery in a way that helped you trust the process?
- 14.** The chapter says Dr. Silkworth saw alcoholism as a disease when most of the world saw it as a moral failure. What does it mean for your recovery that the medical profession now largely agrees with him?

- 15.** The text ends by saying we hope you will find your way to acceptance of your problem. How far along the road to full acceptance of your alcoholism are you right now?

Foreword & Doctor's Opinion Closing Prompts

- 1.** The Foreword describes the founding of A.A. as two desperate men talking to each other. How does this origin story affect the way you think about the value of a single honest conversation?
- 2.** Dr. Silkworth was one of the first people to call alcoholism a disease rather than a moral failure. How has your own shame about drinking been affected by the medical understanding of alcoholism?
- 3.** The Foreword says the businessman believed only alcoholics could help other alcoholics. How has this principle proven true in your own experience?
- 4.** The Doctor's Opinion says alcoholism is both a physical and mental condition. Which aspect of the disease—body or mind—do you struggle with more in your recovery?
- 5.** The Foreword describes the Oxford Group's practices of making lists, apologizing, and helping others. How do these same practices show up in the Twelve Steps you are working today?
- 6.** The text says the businessman was desperate to find another alcoholic to talk to before he picked up a drink. Who is the person you reach for when you are that desperate?
- 7.** Dr. Silkworth's letter gave medical credibility to a spiritual program. How does the combination of medicine and spirituality work in your own approach to recovery?
- 8.** The Foreword says this program has helped millions of people stop drinking and will help millions more. How does being part of something this large and this old affect the way you see your own recovery?
- 9.** The Doctor's Opinion says being clear-headed helps alcoholics understand and accept what is being taught. How clear is your mind today, and how does that clarity affect your ability to work the program?
- 10.** The Foreword says the Plain Language Big Book is not intended to replace the original but to make its ideas easier to access. How has reading the message in plain language changed your understanding of the program?
- 11.** Dr. Silkworth described the craving as an irresistible urge. What does your craving feel like when it shows up, and what do you do when it arrives?
- 12.** The Foreword says we hope that as you read, you will feel less alone. At what point in your reading of this book did you first feel less alone?
- 13.** The Doctor's Opinion confirms that alcoholism is not just in our heads and hearts but in our bodies too. How has this physical reality affected the way you take care of your body in recovery?
- 14.** The Foreword says the wisdom and self-sacrifice of the co-founders have saved more lives than we can count. What act of self-sacrifice for another alcoholic are you capable of today?
- 15.** The text ends by inviting you to begin your journey. What is the single most important thing you have learned from the Foreword and the Doctor's Opinion that you want to carry with you into Chapter 1?

Principles in These Sections

- 1. Honesty:** The Foreword describes two men who were completely honest with each other about their drinking. How are you practicing that same level of honesty with another person in your recovery?
- 2. Willingness:** The businessman was willing to make phone call after phone call until he found another alcoholic. How far are you willing to go to find help when you are in danger of drinking?
- 3. Humility:** Dr. Silkworth was one of the first doctors humble enough to admit that alcoholism was a disease rather than a character flaw. How has humility about your own condition helped you accept help?
- 4. Open-mindedness:** The businessman was willing to learn from the Oxford Group even though most of its members were not alcoholics. How are you being open-minded about sources of help you might not have expected?
- 5. Connection:** The entire Foreword is built on the principle that one alcoholic talking to another is the foundation of recovery. How are you building connection with other alcoholics this week?
- 6. Acceptance:** The Doctor's Opinion asks us to accept that alcoholism is both physical and mental. What part of your condition are you still struggling to accept?
- 7. Faith:** The businessman trusted that talking to a stranger in Akron could save him. What leap of faith has your recovery required from you?
- 8. Service:** The co-founders devoted their lives to helping other alcoholics. How is service to others becoming part of your daily routine?
- 9. Courage:** The businessman was desperate and scared but picked up the phone anyway. What courageous action has your recovery required when you felt most afraid?
- 10. Gratitude:** The Foreword says we are grateful to the co-founders whose wisdom and self-sacrifice saved lives. Who are you grateful to in your recovery, and have you told them?
- 11. Trust:** Dr. Silkworth's letter gave people reason to trust the program. Who or what helped you trust A.A. enough to try it?
- 12. Surrender:** The businessman arrived in Akron with a failed business trip and a desperate need to talk. How has surrendering to your situation opened the door to help you didn't expect?
- 13. Persistence:** The co-founders tried to help many alcoholics before the program took hold. How are you persisting in your recovery when progress feels slow?
- 14. Hope:** The Doctor's Opinion gave medical hope to people who felt hopeless. What gave you your first real hope that recovery was possible?
- 15. Unity:** A.A. started with two men and grew into a worldwide Fellowship. How are you contributing to the unity of your own group?

Putting It Into Practice

- 1.** Read the Foreword and the Doctor's Opinion out loud to yourself this week. Underline the sentences that feel most relevant to your own situation.
- 2.** Make a phone call to another alcoholic today, just as the businessman did in Akron. Tell them how you are doing and ask how they are.
- 3.** Write down what you tried before A.A. to stop drinking. Next to each attempt, write honestly why it failed.
- 4.** Ask your doctor or a medical professional to explain how alcohol has affected your body. Write down what they say and keep it where you can see it.
- 5.** Identify one person who validated your recovery early on—a doctor, a counselor, a friend, or a family member. Thank them this week for believing in you.
- 6.** Share the Foreword with someone who is curious about A.A. but hasn't committed to the program yet. Let the story do the talking.
- 7.** Write a short paragraph about the moment you first suspected your drinking was more than a bad habit. Share it with your sponsor.
- 8.** Spend ten minutes in silence this week thinking about the physical effects of alcohol on your body. Ask your Higher Power for help taking better care of yourself.
- 9.** Read Dr. Silkworth's description of the craving. Write your own version describing what the craving feels like for you personally.
- 10.** Attend a meeting this week and listen for someone who describes the same desperation the businessman felt in Akron. Introduce yourself afterward.
- 11.** Identify one practice from the Oxford Group—apologizing to someone you hurt, listing your strengths and weaknesses, or helping someone through a hard time—and do it this week.
- 12.** Write down the names of three people who have been part of your recovery journey so far. Next to each name, write what they gave you.
- 13.** If you have not yet read the original Big Book, find a copy and read the Doctor's Opinion in its original language. Compare it to the plain language version.
- 14.** Ask an old-timer in your group how the Foreword and Doctor's Opinion affected them when they first read it. Listen for what resonates with your own experience.
- 15.** Before bed tonight, ask your Higher Power to help you accept the full reality of your condition—body, mind, and spirit—without shame or resistance.

Chapter 1: Bill's Story

11 Sections • 165 Questions

Bill's Story

- 1.** Bill describes feeling like a leader after the war and believing success was guaranteed. Where in your own life has confidence crossed the line into arrogance, and what did it cost you?
- 2.** Early in his story, Bill ignores the warning on a gravestone about a soldier who died from drinking. Share a warning you received about your drinking that you chose to overlook.
- 3.** Bill says his family warned him not to drink. Identify a person in your life who tried to intervene early, and describe how you responded to their concern.
- 4.** Bill connects his drinking to loneliness during the war. How has loneliness played a role in your own relationship with alcohol?
- 5.** The editors note that Bill's story describes his struggles, his surrender, and his journey to recovery. Where are you in that sequence right now?
- 6.** Bill felt sure that his success as an officer meant he would succeed at everything. How has a past success blinded you to a present danger?
- 7.** Even before his career began, Bill's drinking made it hard for him to study. Describe an early sign of your alcoholism that you explained away at the time.
- 8.** Bill's wife tried to be patient even though she knew he was making bad choices. Who in your life has shown you that kind of patience, and how did you repay it?
- 9.** Bill says his drinking habits and false beliefs put him on a path to failure and unhappiness. Identify one false belief about yourself that kept you drinking longer than you should have.
- 10.** Bill describes feeling like two different people—the promising young man and the drunk. How does your drinking self differ from the person you want to be?
- 11.** Bill admits the last honest hard work he did was on a farm before his Wall Street career began. When was the last time you did honest work that wasn't connected to managing your drinking?
- 12.** The chapter opens during wartime, a period of chaos and celebration. How has a chaotic season of your own life given you permission to drink?
- 13.** Bill's wife quit her job to support his ambitions. Share a sacrifice someone made for you that your drinking eventually destroyed.
- 14.** Bill's story is told from his own point of view, not from the outside looking in. What would your story sound like if you told it with that same level of honesty?
- 15.** Bill describes himself at the start as eager to show the world how successful and important he could become. How has the desire to be seen as important fueled your drinking or your denial?

My early career as a stock market investor

- 1.** Bill describes being drawn to Wall Street by excitement and the promise of quick wealth. What was the exciting promise that kept you chasing alcohol even when it stopped delivering?
- 2.** Bill was too drunk to complete a law exam. Share a time your drinking directly interfered with a goal you were working toward.
- 3.** Bill convinced himself that the world's great geniuses did their best work while drunk. What lie did you tell yourself to justify your drinking?
- 4.** Bill admits he wasn't meant to be a lawyer but wanted the prestige of Wall Street. How has chasing status or approval kept you from addressing your real problem?
- 5.** Bill and his wife saved a thousand dollars and rode off on a motorcycle with reference books. Describe a time your ambition looked like courage to you but looked like madness to everyone else.
- 6.** Bill says his broker friends wouldn't pay for him to travel, so he quit his job and did it himself. How has stubbornness disguised itself as determination in your life?
- 7.** Bill worked on a farm to avoid spending his small earnings. When have you gone to extreme lengths to protect your ability to keep drinking?
- 8.** Bill's early investments succeeded just enough to keep him going. How has occasional success in your life masked the damage your drinking was doing underneath?
- 9.** Bill describes his wife as patient but worried. What does the worry on the face of someone who loves you look like, and how have you responded to it?
- 10.** Bill believed that most people lost money in stocks because they didn't do their research. What version of this excuse have you used to explain why your drinking was different from other alcoholics?
- 11.** Bill's early career was built on the belief that he was smarter than everyone else. How has intellectual pride prevented you from asking for help?
- 12.** Bill was given an expense account, which gave him access to money he hadn't earned. How has access to money, resources, or privilege enabled your drinking?
- 13.** Bill says he succeeded and earned large bonuses during this time. Describe a period when your life looked good on the outside while your drinking was getting worse on the inside.
- 14.** Bill's wife knew he was making bad choices even when his career was going well. Who in your life sees the truth about you even when you are performing well?
- 15.** Bill describes this period as the beginning of a path to failure. Looking back, when did your own path to failure begin, even if you didn't know it at the time?

Wealth, success, and lots of liquor

- 1.** Bill describes jazz clubs filled with loud talkers and big spenders, people he thought were his friends. How many of your drinking friends would still be in your life if you stopped drinking?
- 2.** Bill says drinking was an important and exciting part of his life during this time. When did drinking shift from something you enjoyed to something you needed?
- 3.** Bill started drinking non-stop all day and almost every night. Describe the progression of your own drinking from occasional to constant.
- 4.** Bill says his friends begged him to stop, so he started drinking alone. How has isolation become part of your drinking pattern?
- 5.** Bill describes fighting with his wife inside their beautiful apartment. What does the contrast between the appearance of your life and the reality inside your home look like?
- 6.** Bill says being drunk all the time kept him from cheating on his wife. How have you used your drinking as an excuse for avoiding a different kind of wrong?
- 7.** Bill became obsessed with golf partly because he could drink while playing. What activity in your life has become a cover for your drinking?
- 8.** Bill describes morning jitters, a sign of delirium tremens. What physical symptoms has your body given you that you chose to ignore or manage with more alcohol?
- 9.** The stock market crashed and all the money Bill made was suddenly gone. Describe a moment when something you built was destroyed by forces connected to your drinking.
- 10.** Bill says men were jumping out of bank windows, but he would not jump. He went back to the bar instead. How has alcohol been your alternative to facing reality?
- 11.** Bill believed he was living out his destiny as a successful leader. How has a story you told yourself about your own destiny kept you from seeing the truth?
- 12.** Bill was spending money almost as fast as he could earn it. How has your drinking affected your financial life?
- 13.** Bill describes the urge to be a successful businessman coming back to him even after the crash. How does your ambition or ego reassert itself even after a disaster?
- 14.** Bill says he felt sure he would make it through the crisis somehow. Describe the version of this false confidence that kept you drinking when the evidence said you should stop.
- 15.** Bill's drinking became even more serious around the time his external life looked most impressive. How has a period of outward success been your most dangerous time?

A new start in Canada

- 1.** Bill moved to Canada believing a fresh start would fix everything. Describe a geographic change or fresh start you used to avoid dealing with your alcoholism.
- 2.** Bill's generous friend eventually had to fire him. Share a time someone who cared about you had to cut you off because of your drinking.
- 3.** Bill describes five years without a steady job, drunk almost all the time, while his wife worked to pay the bills. Who has carried your financial burden while you were drinking?
- 4.** Bill says liquor became something he needed rather than something he wanted. When did that shift happen for you?
- 5.** Bill made bathtub gin and drank it constantly. What lengths have you gone to in order to keep drinking when the supply was running low?
- 6.** Bill describes waking up shaking violently and needing gin and six bottles of beer before breakfast. What did your morning routine look like at your worst?
- 7.** Bill says there were a few short periods of sobriety that made his wife feel hopeful. How have your periods of sobriety given false hope to the people around you?
- 8.** Bill lost a major business opportunity because he went on a bender right before the deal closed. Share a time your drinking destroyed a specific opportunity.
- 9.** Bill says that experience made him see he was in a terrible situation. What specific event forced you to see the truth about your own drinking?
- 10.** Bill decided he was done drinking forever and his wife believed him. How many times have you made that promise, and what happened each time?
- 11.** Bill came home drunk without even trying to resist. Someone pushed a drink his way and he took it. Describe a moment when your decision to stay sober evaporated without a fight.
- 12.** Bill began to wonder if he was crazy since he had no control over his own actions. When did the idea that you might be insane first enter your mind?
- 13.** Bill's house was taken by the bank, his mother-in-law died, and his family became sick. How has your drinking coincided with or worsened a family crisis?
- 14.** Bill admits he would steal money from his wife's purse to buy more liquor. What is the most shameful thing you did to keep drinking?
- 15.** Bill dragged a mattress to a lower floor in case he jumped through the window. Describe the closest you have come to a point of complete desperation.

Stopping and starting again

- 1.** Bill felt confident he could quit for good, then found himself beating his fists on the bar wondering what happened. Describe a relapse that caught you completely off guard.
- 2.** Bill says he promised himself he would do better next time but figured he might as well get good and drunk right then. How does the cycle of promising and failing play out in your life?
- 3.** Bill describes the guilt and hopelessness he felt the next morning. What does the morning after look like for you emotionally?
- 4.** Bill drank twelve beers as fast as he could just to calm his nerves. When has alcohol become your only method of managing physical withdrawal?
- 5.** Bill looked at the morning paper and saw the stock market had crashed again. He felt like he had crashed his life. What was your personal stock market crash?
- 6.** Bill wondered if he should kill himself but thought no, not now. How close has despair brought you to giving up entirely?
- 7.** Bill decided that drinking gin would clear up his hazy mind, so he drank two bottles and forgot everything. When has alcohol been your tool for erasing reality?
- 8.** Bill says his mind and body kept him alive somehow even though he spent two years drinking as much as he possibly could. What has kept you alive through your worst periods?
- 9.** Bill describes the combination of sedatives and gin nearly killing him. How has mixing substances or escalating your intake put your life in danger?
- 10.** Bill says he was forty pounds underweight. What has alcoholism done to your physical body?
- 11.** Bill tried to stop drinking again and felt confident that he was finally strong enough. How has false confidence in your own willpower set you up for failure?
- 12.** Bill walked into a cafe to use the phone and very soon found himself drunk at the bar. What seemingly harmless situation has triggered a relapse for you?
- 13.** Bill says his choices made him feel full of shame but he couldn't stop himself. Describe the gap between what you know is right and what you actually do when it comes to drinking.
- 14.** Bill's wife and father-in-law became sick while Bill was still drinking. How has your alcoholism continued during a period when people around you needed you most?
- 15.** Bill says he was powerless and believed that alcohol would always control him. When did you first truly feel that powerlessness?

Learning about alcoholism at the hospital

- 1.** A doctor told Bill that his behavior had been selfish and foolish, but he was also very sick. How did it change your thinking when you first heard alcoholism described as an illness?
- 2.** Bill says it was a relief to hear that most alcoholics have a hard time resisting drinking. How did learning you were not alone in your struggle affect your sense of shame?
- 3.** Bill felt strong enough to get sober after gaining new knowledge about alcoholism. When has knowledge about your condition given you false confidence?
- 4.** Bill says for three or four months everything went well, and then the day came when he drank again. Describe a period of sobriety that ended despite your best efforts.
- 5.** The doctors told Bill's wife he was at risk for a heart attack or permanent brain damage. What medical reality have you or your loved ones been told about your drinking?
- 6.** Bill says he welcomed the idea of dying. How has your drinking brought you to a place where death seemed acceptable or even preferable?
- 7.** Bill remembered coming home from the war feeling sure he would be a huge success and felt deep shame. What version of your former self do you grieve for?
- 8.** Bill says he felt trapped in a corner with no way to escape. Describe the moment you realized your options had run out.
- 9.** Bill couldn't find words to describe his loneliness and despair. What is the loneliest you have ever felt because of your drinking?
- 10.** Bill says he felt like a broken man when he left the hospital. What does it feel like to be broken by alcohol?
- 11.** Bill stayed sober for a while out of fear but took a single drink and was back to his old habits. How has fear kept you sober temporarily, and what happened when the fear wore off?
- 12.** Bill says he had no idea that in a few short weeks he would be introduced to a whole new way of living. What would you say to yourself at your lowest if you could speak from where you are now?
- 13.** Bill describes the darkest hours that come right before the dawn. Are you in those dark hours right now, and what gives you reason to believe dawn is coming?
- 14.** Bill wished he could apologize and make things better with his wife but felt it was too late. Who do you owe an apology to that you believe may not want to hear it?
- 15.** Bill calls the new way of living the fourth dimension of existence. What does freedom from alcohol look like to you, even if you haven't experienced it yet?

A visit from a friend

- 1.** Bill's first thought when his sober friend called was that they could drink together. How has your alcoholic mind twisted a good situation into a drinking opportunity?
- 2.** Bill says his friend looked healthy and happy but seemed very different. Who in your life has shown you what recovery looks like by their own transformation?
- 3.** Bill pushed a drink across the table and his friend refused it. Describe a moment when someone's refusal to drink with you made you uncomfortable or curious.
- 4.** Bill's friend said he had got religion and Bill assumed he was crazy. What was your first reaction when someone told you that faith or spirituality had helped them get sober?
- 5.** Bill's friend told him that two men had a simple religious idea and a practical program of action. What part of the A.A. program first sounded practical enough to try?
- 6.** Bill says his grandfather believed in a great mystical force but didn't want anyone telling him what it was. How does your own family history with religion affect your willingness to accept a Higher Power?
- 7.** Bill had always believed in a Power greater than himself but had not made himself think about that Power's ability to help him. What has prevented you from asking your Higher Power for help?
- 8.** Bill says he knew wars had been fought over religion and people had been killed for their beliefs. How has the bad behavior of religious people made it harder for you to trust a spiritual solution?
- 9.** Bill's friend told him honestly that God had helped him when he could not help himself. Who has told you the same thing, and how did you receive that message?
- 10.** Bill's friend suggested that he create his own idea of who or what God is, and Bill says that simple question changed everything. What would happen if you gave yourself permission to define God on your own terms?
- 11.** Bill says all of his fear and doubt melted away in that moment. Have you experienced a moment of sudden clarity or relief, even briefly?
- 12.** Bill realized he didn't need to suddenly become a churchgoer with total faith. He just had to be willing to believe. What is the smallest step toward faith you are willing to take today?
- 13.** Bill remembered standing in the Winchester Cathedral and needing God but then letting go of that connection. Describe a time you felt close to a Higher Power and then drifted away.
- 14.** Bill says he let himself get distracted by the activity of daily life and lost his connection with God. What distracts you from your spiritual growth?
- 15.** Bill felt determined to connect with God again, this time for good. What would connecting with a Higher Power for good look like in your daily life?

The long road to recovery

- 1.** Bill made a silent agreement with God asking for care and promising to listen for direction. What does your agreement with your Higher Power sound like?
- 2.** Bill thought long and hard about all of the hurtful decisions he had made and asked God to forgive him. What specific decisions weigh heaviest on you when you think about forgiveness?
- 3.** Bill says he had never been able to forgive himself, but when he made this agreement with God he finally felt forgiven. What would it take for you to forgive yourself?
- 4.** Bill says he has not had a single drink since that day. What is the longest you have gone without a drink, and what made the difference?
- 5.** Bill and his friend made a list of people he had hurt and people who had made him angry. How far along are you in making your own list?
- 6.** Bill promised he wouldn't blame or criticize the people on his list during conversations with them. How difficult is it for you to take responsibility without pointing fingers?
- 7.** Bill's friend suggested he silently explore his new relationship with God. How much time do you spend in silence with your Higher Power?
- 8.** Bill was told not to pray for himself unless asking for wisdom to help other people. How does your prayer life compare to this instruction?
- 9.** Bill says practicing trust in a Higher Power and being less self-centered would keep him sober. Which of those two things is harder for you?
- 10.** Bill describes feeling like he had won a long and difficult battle and then felt a deep sense of inner peace. Have you experienced any moments of peace in your recovery?
- 11.** Bill says God comes to some people slowly but his own experience was sudden and powerful. How has your Higher Power shown up in your life—gradually, suddenly, or not yet?
- 12.** Bill called his doctor into the room because he was scared by what was happening to him. Who do you turn to when a spiritual experience feels overwhelming or confusing?
- 13.** The doctor told Bill that something had happened that he didn't understand, but Bill should hang on to it. What has someone said to you about your recovery that you are holding on to?
- 14.** Bill says he felt like he was standing at the top of a mountain with a strong clean wind blowing through him. Describe the best moment of clarity you have experienced so far.
- 15.** Bill describes the feeling of being reborn. What part of your old self are you ready to leave behind?

Bringing a message of recovery to more alcoholics

- 1.** Bill imagined a network of alcoholics connecting with one another, spreading help and hope. How are you currently connected to other alcoholics in recovery?
- 2.** Bill was told that sharing experience, strength, and hope with other alcoholics was the only way to survive recovery. How are you sharing your experience with others?
- 3.** Bill says alcoholics who don't help other alcoholics will eventually drink again. Do you believe this is true, and how does it affect your willingness to serve?
- 4.** Bill and his wife decided to spend all of their time working with other alcoholics. What percentage of your time is currently devoted to recovery work?
- 5.** Bill couldn't get a job for about a year and a half. How are you handling the practical challenges of rebuilding your life while staying sober?
- 6.** Bill admits he felt sorry for himself and sometimes felt frustrated with his new life. Where does self-pity still show up in your recovery?
- 7.** Bill says that whenever he came close to taking a drink, he would find another alcoholic to talk with. Who is the person you call when you are closest to picking up a drink?
- 8.** Bill says helping others get sober helped him stay sober. Describe a time when being of service to someone else strengthened your own recovery.
- 9.** Bill describes building a community of people who understand what he's been through. What does fellowship mean to you right now?
- 10.** Bill says an alcoholic who is actively drinking is a difficult person to love. How are you practicing love toward someone who is still in active addiction?
- 11.** Bill mentions that one man committed suicide in his home because he could not or would not see their way of life. How do you handle the grief of watching someone refuse the solution?
- 12.** Bill says the humor keeps them sane and underneath it is a strong dedication to healing. How does laughter play a role in your recovery?
- 13.** Bill says they must have faith all day every day or they will never survive. What does all-day faith look like in practice for you?
- 14.** Bill says alcoholics across the world are having talks like the one that took place in his kitchen. Who needs you to have that kitchen-table conversation with them?
- 15.** Bill describes a widening circle of peace, acceptance, and healing. What is your part in making that circle wider?

Principles in This Chapter

- 1. Honesty:** Bill spent years lying to himself about his ability to control his drinking. Share a lie you told yourself that you have now replaced with the truth.
- 2. Willingness:** Bill's friend suggested he create his own idea of God, and Bill was willing to try. What spiritual step are you willing to take today that you were not willing to take before?
- 3. Humility:** Bill went from believing he could run the world to admitting he was powerless over alcohol. Describe a moment when your pride finally cracked.
- 4. Surrender:** Bill made a silent agreement with God and asked for help. What does surrender look like in your life today?
- 5. Hope:** Bill says the darkest hours come right before the dawn. Share a source of hope you are clinging to right now.
- 6. Faith:** Bill didn't need total faith to begin. He just needed to be willing to believe. How are you practicing willingness to believe today?
- 7. Courage:** Bill went back to every person he had hurt and admitted he was wrong. What act of courage does your recovery require from you this week?
- 8. Connection:** Bill says helping other alcoholics was the key to his own sobriety. How are you connecting with other alcoholics right now?
- 9. Gratitude:** Bill describes feeling like he was reborn. What are you grateful for today that did not exist before you entered recovery?
- 10. Responsibility:** Bill promised not to blame others during his amends. How are you taking responsibility for your own actions without pointing fingers?
- 11. Perseverance:** Bill failed many times before he found sobriety. How are you keeping going after your own failures?
- 12. Service:** Bill says spending time with newcomers is the bright spot of his life. How are you being useful to another person today?
- 13. Openness:** Bill had to let go of his resistance to religion before he could recover. What resistance are you still carrying that needs to be released?
- 14. Trust:** Bill was told to trust in a Higher Power and practice being less self-centered. Which of these is harder for you to practice, and why?
- 15. Transformation:** Bill describes his entire being changing, not just his thoughts. What change in yourself would prove to you that transformation is real?

Putting It Into Practice

- 1.** Read Bill's story out loud to yourself this week. Underline the sentences that sound like your own experience.
- 2.** Write down three warnings about your drinking that you ignored. Share them with your sponsor or a trusted friend.
- 3.** Identify one person in your life who has shown you the patience Bill's wife showed him. Thank that person this week.
- 4.** Sit quietly for ten minutes and ask your Higher Power one question. Write down whatever comes to mind.
- 5.** Make a list of the promises you have broken because of your drinking. Choose one and begin to make it right.
- 6.** Contact another alcoholic today and ask how they are doing. Listen more than you speak.
- 7.** Write a short version of your own story using Bill's framework: what you were like, what happened, and what you are like now.
- 8.** Identify one area of your life where you are still playing director. Practice letting go of control in that area for one day.
- 9.** Attend a meeting this week with the specific goal of listening for similarities between your story and someone else's.
- 10.** Write down your own definition of a Higher Power. It does not need to be perfect. It just needs to be honest.
- 11.** Choose one act of service you can perform this week that has nothing to do with your own recovery.
- 12.** Ask someone who has been sober longer than you what the hardest part of their first year was. Compare it to your own experience.
- 13.** Before bed tonight, review your day using Bill's framework: Were you selfish? Were you dishonest? Were you afraid? Write down the answers.
- 14.** Identify one person you owe an amends to and write down what you would say to them. Do not send it yet.
- 15.** Tomorrow morning, before you do anything else, ask your Higher Power to show you how to be useful to someone today.

Chapter 2: There Is a Solution

10 Sections • 150 Questions

There Is a Solution

- 1.** The chapter says we are like passengers rescued from a sinking boat. Describe the moment you realized your own boat was going down.
- 2.** A.A. members come from many countries, jobs, and backgrounds, people who normally would not spend time together. Who in your group is someone you would never have met outside of recovery?
- 3.** The text says our joy lasts long after we've left behind our drinking days. What kind of lasting joy have you experienced since you stopped drinking, or what kind do you hope for?
- 4.** A.A. calls itself a Fellowship of people connected by shared experience. How is that different from the friendships you had while you were drinking?
- 5.** The chapter says alcoholism causes pain for everyone who knows and loves us. Name a specific relationship that has been damaged by your drinking and describe how.
- 6.** The text compares alcoholism to cancer but says no one gets angry at a cancer patient. How has the anger of people around you made your alcoholism harder to face?
- 7.** The chapter says the tremendous fact is that A.A. has found a way to recover that all members agree on. What part of the A.A. program do you agree with most strongly right now?
- 8.** A.A. believes alcoholism is a sickness. How does thinking of it as a sickness change the way you see yourself?
- 9.** The text says we feel connected because of what we have all experienced. Describe a moment in a meeting when you felt truly understood by a stranger.
- 10.** The chapter opens by saying nearly all hopeless people have learned to live in sobriety. What would need to change in your life for you to believe that includes you?
- 11.** The text says we feel joy because we are so relieved that our lives are no longer in danger. Do you feel that relief yet, or are you still in danger?
- 12.** The chapter mentions that alcoholism makes friends and employers feel frustrated and disappointed. Share a specific instance where your drinking disappointed someone who depended on you.
- 13.** The text says when we are together, none of our differences matter. How has the Fellowship taught you to look past the surface of another person?
- 14.** The chapter says this book was created so that anyone who suffers can learn about the Fellowship. What brought this book into your hands?
- 15.** The text says alcoholism affects children, partners, and parents. Who in your family has paid the highest price for your drinking?

Alcoholics who help each other feel understood

- 1.** The text says many excellent doctors have trouble getting alcoholics to talk. What made it so hard for you to be honest with professionals about your drinking?
- 2.** Recovering alcoholics can gain the trust of other alcoholics very quickly. Share a time when another recovering person earned your trust faster than a doctor or counselor could.
- 3.** The chapter says without the connection between recovering and active alcoholics, very little will work. How important has that person-to-person connection been in your own recovery?
- 4.** The text says newcomers worry there might be a catch like long lectures, fees, or lots of rules. What were you suspicious about when you first encountered A.A.?
- 5.** The chapter says A.A. conversations are just honest sharing of stories. How is that different from the conversations you were used to having about your drinking?
- 6.** The text says newcomers quickly realize that talking with an A.A. member is safe. What made you feel safe enough to open up in the program?
- 7.** The chapter says partners, parents, and close friends have an even harder time talking to alcoholics about their drinking. Why is it sometimes easier to hear the truth from a stranger than from someone who loves you?
- 8.** The text says recovering alcoholics understand how alcoholism works from the inside. Share a moment when someone in the program described your experience more accurately than you could have yourself.
- 9.** The chapter says the only goal of A.A. members is to help. How does a person with no agenda change the way you receive their message?
- 10.** The text says most alcoholics don't want to describe their feelings or struggles even to people who care about them. What feeling or struggle are you still holding back from sharing?
- 11.** The chapter says it is an open and welcoming conversation between recovering and active alcoholics. What made your first conversation with a sober alcoholic different from what you expected?
- 12.** The text says newcomers feel at home very quickly in A.A. Describe the first time you felt at home in a meeting or a conversation with a member.
- 13.** The chapter says recovering alcoholics have experienced the same pains and seen the same situations go wrong. Which shared pain has connected you most strongly to another person in recovery?
- 14.** The text says ex-problem drinkers are often able to help alcoholics who are still drinking to open up and start talking. Who opened you up, and what did they say that got through?
- 15.** The chapter says in A.A., newcomers don't feel judged or pressured. How has the absence of judgment changed the way you think about yourself?

Why was the Big Book created?

- 1.** The text says when an alcoholic stops drinking, that is just the beginning of recovery. How far past the beginning do you feel you are right now?
- 2.** The chapter says the rest of the recovery journey involves living by A.A.'s principles each day at home and at work. Which principle is the hardest for you to live by in your daily routine?
- 3.** The text says all of us are on that journey no matter how long we have been members. How does knowing that even old-timers are still working on recovery affect your attitude?
- 4.** The chapter says A.A. members are not paid to help each other. What does it mean to you that the people helping you have nothing to gain from it?
- 5.** The text says the book was created to reach and help more alcoholics than person-to-person work could reach alone. How has reading this book helped you in ways that meetings alone have not?
- 6.** The chapter says A.A. members combined their experiences and knowledge to write about what they created. What experience from your own life would you contribute if you were writing this book?
- 7.** The text says the book needed to talk about medical, psychiatric, social, and religious issues without skipping over them. Which of these topics is hardest for you to discuss honestly?
- 8.** The chapter says members are more helpful when they can disagree respectfully. How are you practicing tolerance for views that differ from your own inside the program?
- 9.** The text says being useful to other alcoholics is absolutely essential to being in recovery. How are you being useful to another alcoholic right now?
- 10.** The chapter says learning to see things from multiple angles makes us more accepting and tolerant. What angle on your own drinking have you only recently been able to see?
- 11.** The text says A.A. wanted the book to feel welcoming to anyone regardless of their background or views. What about the program felt welcoming to you when you first arrived?
- 12.** The chapter says at first everything was done person to person, which worked very well. How has a one-on-one conversation been more powerful for you than a group meeting?
- 13.** The text says A.A. did not skip over upsetting and controversial topics. Which topic in your recovery do you tend to avoid discussing, and why?
- 14.** The chapter says living by guiding principles is absolutely essential to recovery. Which guiding principle has had the most visible impact on your daily behavior?
- 15.** The text says A.A. wanted to find ways to spread their ideas beyond person-to-person work. How are you helping to spread the message of recovery in your own community?

Understanding types of drinkers

- 1.** The chapter lists common things people say to alcoholics like I'm sure he could stop if he wanted to. Which of these statements have you heard most often, and how did it make you feel?
- 2.** The text says these opinions are all based on misunderstandings about alcoholism. What is the biggest misunderstanding about your drinking that people in your life still hold?
- 3.** The chapter says average drinkers can usually give up liquor if they have a good reason. What good reasons did you have that still were not enough to make you stop?
- 4.** The text describes hard drinkers who can still reverse their habits with enough motivation like serious sickness or falling in love. At what point did you cross the line from hard drinker to chronic alcoholic?
- 5.** The chapter says chronic alcoholics form a drinking habit that is almost impossible to break and it can seem like we crossed an invisible line. Looking back, when did you cross that line?
- 6.** The text says alcoholics can seem like two different people living in one body, happy and normal until a drinking day. Describe the two versions of yourself that people around you see.
- 7.** The chapter says we may be reasonable about everything except liquor, and when it comes to drinking we become dishonest and selfish. In what area of your life are you completely reasonable, and how does that contrast with your behavior around alcohol?
- 8.** The text describes hiding alcohol all over the house so no one can pour the supply down the toilet. What lengths have you gone to in order to hide or protect your drinking?
- 9.** The chapter says some chronic alcoholics are talented people who seem to have promising careers ahead of them, but all that hope is destroyed by drinking sprees. How has your talent or potential been threatened or destroyed by your drinking?
- 10.** The text says alcoholic behaviors seem downright strange to non-drinkers. What behavior of yours makes the least sense to someone who does not understand alcoholism?
- 11.** The chapter says we may go to bed extremely drunk, wake up very hungover, and still look for more liquor in the morning. How does this cycle show up in your own life?
- 12.** The text says few doctors understand how to help chronic alcoholics. What was your experience with medical professionals when you sought help for your drinking?
- 13.** The chapter says non-alcoholics are extremely confused watching chronic alcoholics live their lives. Who in your life has been most confused by your behavior, and how did you explain it?
- 14.** The text says our behaviors vary and so do our lives, but some of what you've read will probably sound familiar. Which part of this section sounded most familiar to you?
- 15.** The chapter says we often do strange and destructive things while drinking including things we would never do while sober. Share one action you took while drinking that the sober you would never have considered.

Why can't alcoholics just stop drinking?

- 1.** The text says there are no easy answers to why alcoholics react differently to liquor. How do you explain your own inability to stop to someone who does not understand?
- 2.** The chapter says a single drink is enough to affect our behavior in very serious ways regardless of how long we have been sober. Describe what happens to you after the first drink.
- 3.** The text says the alcoholic's main problem lives within the mind. How does your thinking change in the hours or minutes before you pick up the first drink?
- 4.** The chapter compares alcoholics to people who deal with headaches by hitting themselves with a hammer. What is the version of this insanity that shows up in your drinking pattern?
- 5.** The text says once in a while alcoholics tell the truth, and the truth is we have absolutely no idea why we take that first drink. Can you identify the honest reason you last picked up, or is it a mystery?
- 6.** The chapter says many of us believe that someday we will find a way to trick ourselves into getting sober. What trick or scheme have you tried that failed?
- 7.** The text says we know that drinking will make a mess of our lives, but knowing that won't keep us from getting drunk. How has knowledge alone failed to protect you?
- 8.** The chapter says we may tell ourselves that this time will be different and we will handle ourselves better, but we know it is a lie. When was the last time you believed that lie?
- 9.** The text says when alcohol is involved, many alcoholics feel like we aren't able to think at all and our brains seem to switch off completely. Describe what happens to your ability to reason once you start drinking.
- 10.** The chapter describes pounding on the bar in surprise after realizing you've had four or five drinks. Share a moment when you lost count and were shocked at how far you had gone.
- 11.** The text says alcoholics have lost the power to make our own choices when it comes to drinking and have zero willpower around alcohol. How does this loss of power affect the rest of your life?
- 12.** The chapter says throughout history millions of alcoholics have drunk themselves into terrible sickness or early graves. How real is that threat in your own life today?
- 13.** The text says when alcoholics begin to think this way we need immediate medical help or we may end up mentally ill, brain damaged, or dead. What kind of help are you currently receiving?
- 14.** The chapter says no one knows exactly why alcoholics have no willpower when it comes to drinking. How do you make peace with not fully understanding your own condition?
- 15.** The text says the sad truth is that alcoholics are often lost and cannot control their drinking even though we want to stop more than anything. When did you first admit to yourself that you were lost?

Alcoholism is a life and death situation

- 1.** The text says there is a solution, a kind of spiritual toolkit collected from the experiences of recovered alcoholics. What tools from the program have you actually picked up and used so far?
- 2.** The chapter says we have had deeply spiritual experiences that changed our attitudes toward life. Describe a moment when your attitude about something shifted because of your recovery work.
- 3.** The text says there is no middle-of-the-road solution, no halfway, and no compromise. Where are you still trying to find a compromise with your alcoholism?
- 4.** The chapter says alcoholics have two options: continue drinking to death or accept spiritual help. How did you feel when you first understood there were only two choices?
- 5.** The text mentions actions like apologizing, listing strengths and weaknesses, and helping others as part of the spiritual toolkit. Which of these actions has been most meaningful in your own recovery?
- 6.** The chapter says by helping us become sober, God has done for us things we could never do alone. What specific thing has your Higher Power done for you that you could not do for yourself?
- 7.** The text says certain actions helped other alcoholics stay sober and A.A. adopted them. What action in the program has helped you the most?
- 8.** The chapter says we found true happiness and a miraculous new way to be in the world. What does true happiness look like to you in sobriety, even if you have only glimpsed it?
- 9.** The text says God has entered our hearts and lives in the most miraculous way. How has your Higher Power shown up in your life, even in small or unexpected ways?
- 10.** The chapter says we believe all of us in A.A. feel this way about our spiritual experiences. How does hearing that others share your experience strengthen your own commitment?
- 11.** The text calls alcoholism a life and death situation with no exaggeration. How close to death did your drinking bring you?
- 12.** The chapter says the solution involves a spiritual toolkit. What tool are you avoiding that you know you need to pick up?
- 13.** The text says we saw that certain actions helped and adopted them into the program. What action are you ready to adopt that you have been putting off?
- 14.** The chapter says we could never have gotten sober alone. Who has been essential to your recovery that you did not expect to need?
- 15.** The text says the other option is to continue drinking until we eventually die bitter and alone. How real and present is that alternative to you right now?

Why alcoholics must connect with a Higher Power

- 1.** The text tells the story of a Rhode Island businessman who went to a famous European psychiatrist and still couldn't stop drinking. What treatment or approach have you tried that failed despite your confidence in it?
- 2.** The chapter says the doctor told the businessman he was totally hopeless and would never stop drinking on his own. How did being told your situation was hopeless affect your willingness to try something you had never tried before?
- 3.** The text says the only way for the businessman to stay alive would be to lock himself away forever or hire a bodyguard. What extreme measures have you or your family considered to control your drinking?
- 4.** The chapter says the businessman found freedom through a spiritual transformation, not through locking himself away. What does the idea of spiritual transformation mean to you right now?
- 5.** The text says the businessman's self-knowledge from psychiatry was not enough to prevent him from drinking. Where has self-knowledge alone failed you in your own recovery?
- 6.** The chapter quotes the doctor saying he had never seen anyone in this state of mind get sober without a vital spiritual experience. How does that statement apply to your own condition?
- 7.** The text describes a vital spiritual experience as a huge emotional event that completely transforms an alcoholic's attitudes. Have you had any experience that comes close to this description?
- 8.** The chapter says the doctor had been trying to trigger this kind of experience but had not succeeded with someone this ill. How sick were you before you became willing to try a spiritual solution?
- 9.** The text says religious belief alone was not the same thing as a vital spiritual experience. How is the spiritual experience described here different from simply attending church or following religious rules?
- 10.** The chapter says hearing he was hopeless felt like the gates of hell closed on the businessman with a clang. Describe the moment when your own situation felt permanently sealed.
- 11.** The text says the businessman asked if there were any exceptions and the doctor said yes, through vital spiritual experiences. How does knowing exceptions exist change the way you see your own chances?
- 12.** The chapter says afterward the alcoholic may finally feel like they belong in this world. How has your drinking made you feel like you do not belong?
- 13.** The text says the businessman found his way to the profound transformation he needed and it made him a free man. What does freedom from alcoholism look like in your imagination?
- 14.** The chapter says incorporating a Higher Power into recovery is critically important. How are you incorporating your Higher Power into your daily routine right now?
- 15.** The text says before you decide you can do this without spiritual help, consider the rest of the story. What hesitation do you still have about the spiritual aspect of recovery?

God, as you understand God

- 1.** The text says when we fully accepted the love and guidance of God, we were finally able to pull ourselves out of suffering. What part of God's guidance are you currently accepting, and what part are you resisting?
- 2.** The chapter says in A.A. we respect all faiths, spiritual practices, and ways of thinking about God. How has this openness made it easier for you to explore your own relationship with a Higher Power?
- 3.** The text says we are not interested in telling others what or how to believe. How does that approach differ from your previous experiences with religion or religious people?
- 4.** The chapter says those who do not practice any specific religion are just as welcome in the Fellowship. How has this inclusiveness affected your comfort level in the program?
- 5.** The text says attending religious ceremonies or visiting sacred places is a personal choice for each member. What spiritual practice, if any, have you adopted since entering recovery?
- 6.** The chapter says there is no conflict between members about what we believe. How does the absence of religious argument affect your ability to focus on your recovery?
- 7.** The text says doubts about God don't prevent people from having vital spiritual experiences. What doubt are you carrying that you fear will hold you back from connecting with a Higher Power?
- 8.** The chapter says many people who once doubted God's existence are now A.A. members in recovery. How has your thinking about God changed since you began the program?
- 9.** The text says you may read the stories in this book and say yes, I am one of them too. When did you first identify yourself as an alcoholic without any reservation?
- 10.** The chapter says all human beings can connect with a Power greater than themselves if they are willing to try. What is your current level of willingness to make that connection?
- 11.** The text says we were given new lives and given a new way to live them. What part of your new life is most different from the life alcohol gave you?
- 12.** The chapter says members may feel more comfortable saying a Higher Power or a Power greater than ourselves rather than the word God. What language do you use when you talk about your spiritual life, and why?
- 13.** The text says we believe connecting with a Higher Power can be simple and rewarding. How has your experience of spirituality in recovery been simpler than you expected?
- 14.** The chapter says nothing in the A.A. program will interfere with existing religious beliefs. How has the program supported rather than replaced your existing faith or spiritual practice?
- 15.** The text says for as long as humans have walked on the earth we have connected with God in many different ways. What is your way, and how is it taking shape in your recovery?

Principles in This Chapter

- 1. Fellowship:** The chapter says we are connected by shared experience like survivors of a shipwreck. Share a time this week when the Fellowship gave you something you could not get on your own.
- 2. Honesty:** The text says alcoholics struggle to be honest with themselves and others. Identify one area of your life where you are practicing honesty for the first time since entering recovery.
- 3. Willingness:** The chapter says the desire to connect with a Higher Power must come from within. How are you cultivating your own willingness today?
- 4. Understanding:** The text explains that people misunderstand alcoholism because they compare us to other types of drinkers. How has your own understanding of the disease changed since you began recovery?
- 5. Acceptance:** The chapter says the first step is to completely accept that we are alcoholics. Where are you in the process of full acceptance?
- 6. Open-mindedness:** The text says being open to spiritual discussion was important even when we resisted the idea of God. What are you being open-minded about this week?
- 7. Hope:** The chapter says nearly all hopeless people have learned to live in sobriety through A.A. What gives you hope for your own recovery today?
- 8. Compassion:** The text says when someone has cancer people feel sorry for them but alcoholism produces anger instead. How are you practicing compassion for yourself as a person with a real sickness?
- 9. Tolerance:** The chapter says A.A. members are more helpful when they can disagree respectfully about difficult topics. How are you practicing tolerance for someone whose views differ from yours?
- 10. Trust:** The text says newcomers quickly realize that talking with an A.A. member is safe and free of judgment. Who do you trust most in your recovery, and what did they do to earn that trust?
- 11. Service:** The chapter says being useful to other alcoholics is absolutely essential to recovery. How were you useful to someone else this week?
- 12. Humility:** The text says the only goal of A.A. members is to help, not to lecture or judge. How are you putting the desire to help above the desire to be right?
- 13. Faith:** The chapter says connecting with a Higher Power is critically important to lasting recovery. What step of faith are you taking this week?
- 14. Courage:** The text says we must accept spiritual help to survive our alcoholism. What does it take for you to accept help you once would have refused?
- 15. Gratitude:** The chapter says our joy lasts long after we leave behind our drinking days. What lasting joy or relief are you grateful for today?

Putting It Into Practice

- 1.** Read the descriptions of average drinkers, hard drinkers, and chronic alcoholics to someone close to you. Ask them which description sounds most like your behavior.
- 2.** Write down three things people have said to you about your drinking that were based on misunderstandings. Next to each one, write the actual truth about your condition.
- 3.** Contact someone in the Fellowship you do not know well and ask to hear their story over coffee this week.
- 4.** Write a paragraph describing what your life looked like at its worst. Then write a paragraph describing what you hope your life will look like in one year of sobriety.
- 5.** Identify one person outside of A.A. who needs to understand that alcoholism is a sickness, not a choice. Find a gentle way to share that information with them this week.
- 6.** Attend a meeting this week specifically to listen for the moment when someone describes a feeling you have never been able to put into words yourself.
- 7.** Write down your own definition of a vital spiritual experience. It does not need to match anyone else's definition.
- 8.** Choose one misunderstanding about your drinking that you have allowed to continue uncorrected. Correct it this week with honesty.
- 9.** Spend ten minutes in silence this week asking your Higher Power which spiritual tool you should pick up next.
- 10.** Make a list of the people who have been hurt by your alcoholism. Do not take any action yet. Just write the names and sit with what you see.
- 11.** Ask your sponsor or a trusted member to describe how they first came to believe in a Power greater than themselves. Listen without arguing.
- 12.** Identify one area of your recovery where you are still trying to find a halfway solution. Commit to going all the way this week.
- 13.** Write a short letter to the version of yourself that is still in active addiction. Tell that person what you know now that you wish you had known then.
- 14.** Read the section on why alcoholics can't just stop drinking before your next meeting. Share one sentence from it that hit you the hardest.
- 15.** Before bed tonight, ask your Higher Power to show you one thing you can do tomorrow to help another alcoholic.

Chapter 3: More About Alcoholism

8 Sections • 120 Questions

More About Alcoholism

- 1.** The chapter says most of us struggle to admit that we are real alcoholics. What part of the label alcoholic is hardest for you to accept?
- 2.** The text says we want to be normal regular people, so we spend a lot of time and energy trying to prove we can drink like them. How much of your life has gone into proving you are not an alcoholic?
- 3.** The chapter says some of us keep trying to prove we are not alcoholics until we lose our minds or die. Where on that continuum are you right now?
- 4.** The text says the first step in recovery is to completely accept that we are alcoholics. Describe the difference between knowing you have a problem and fully accepting it.
- 5.** The chapter says the false belief that we are like other drinkers must be smashed. What is the most stubborn version of this belief still alive in your own mind?
- 6.** The text says there may be short periods when we feel like we have taken control, and then we relapse and lose control completely. Describe one of those cycles in your own life.
- 7.** The chapter says whenever we relapse, we feel like we have failed completely and may never be worthy again. How does the shame of relapse affect your willingness to try again?
- 8.** The text says we are convinced we have an illness that only gets worse and never better. How does this idea affect your urgency about working the program?
- 9.** The chapter says there is no treatment, program, or medication that will make alcoholics the same as normal drinkers. How long did you search for that treatment before accepting it didn't exist?
- 10.** The text says doctors who treat alcoholics also agree it is impossible to turn an alcoholic into a normal drinker. What did a medical professional tell you about your drinking that you refused to believe at the time?
- 11.** The chapter says some alcoholics stubbornly believe they can still control their drinking and will experiment and argue to prove they are in charge. What experiment did you try to prove you could drink normally?
- 12.** The text lists many ways A.A. members tried to prove they could drink normally including drinking beer only, never drinking alone, and swearing never to drink again. Which of these methods did you try, and how long did it last?
- 13.** The chapter says none of these experiments has changed us into normal drinkers. How many experiments did you run before you were willing to accept the results?
- 14.** The text says few alcoholics truly want to stop while they have any chance at success. What was the last thing that had to go wrong before you wanted to stop?
- 15.** The chapter says we have lost the ability to control our drinking permanently. What does the word permanently do to your thinking when you sit with it honestly?

Once an alcoholic, always an alcoholic

- 1.** The text tells the story of a 30-year-old man who stopped drinking for 25 years through willpower alone, then started again with devastating results and died four years later. How does this story affect your confidence in white-knuckle sobriety?
- 2.** The chapter says the man began to believe that his long period of abstinence meant he could drink like a normal person. When have you told yourself a similar lie after a stretch of not drinking?
- 3.** The text says after just two months of experimenting with drinking he was in the hospital, feeling confused and humiliated. How quickly did your last relapse escalate once you took the first drink?
- 4.** The chapter says once an alcoholic always an alcoholic and A.A. members have seen this come true again and again. What feelings does that statement produce in you when you read it slowly?
- 5.** The text says if we plan to stop drinking we need to do it knowing we will not be able to experiment with drinking ever again. How willing are you to accept that drinking is permanently off the table for you?
- 6.** The chapter describes a dry drunk as someone who has stopped drinking but hasn't changed the way they think or feel in any positive way. Are there areas of your life where you are dry but not actually recovering?
- 7.** The text says younger people may feel hopeful hearing the man used willpower for 25 years and think they can do the same. What is dangerous about believing willpower alone will be enough for you?
- 8.** The chapter says most young people who try willpower alone don't truly want to stop drinking. How honest are you about whether you truly want to stop, or whether you just want the consequences to stop?
- 9.** The text says you don't have to drink for a long time or drink huge amounts of alcohol to be a serious alcoholic. How has comparing the severity of your drinking to others been used as an excuse to avoid the truth?
- 10.** The chapter says dry drunks often relapse and still show many of the same behaviors as when they were drinking. What drinking-era behaviors do you still carry even when you are sober?
- 11.** The text says even if you can stop for years you may still be an alcoholic. How does knowing this push you toward a spiritual solution rather than relying on willpower alone?
- 12.** The chapter says we at A.A. are familiar with the symptoms of alcoholism and see potential new alcoholics everywhere, especially among young people. Who in your life shows early signs of alcoholism that concern you?
- 13.** The text challenges readers to stop drinking for a whole year and says if you are an alcoholic it is very likely you will fail. If you tried this challenge, what happened?
- 14.** The chapter says being able to stop for a long period of time isn't enough. What else is needed beyond just not drinking to keep you alive and sane?
- 15.** The text says the man who stopped for 25 years died just four years after he started drinking again. How does the speed of his decline compare to what you have seen in your own life or in the lives of people you know?

How to tell if you are an alcoholic

- 1.** The text says alcoholism affects all alcoholics equally regardless of willpower, character, or background. How has this leveling reality humbled your view of yourself?
- 2.** The chapter says the quickest way to know if you are an alcoholic is to go to a bar and try to control your drinking. What happened the last time you tried to control how much you drank in a single sitting?
- 3.** The text tells Jim's story: he ran a successful car dealership, had a lovely wife and family, and seemed quite normal except for a nervous personality. What did your own version of normal look like before your drinking became serious?
- 4.** The chapter says Jim didn't try to connect with a Higher Power, which meant he wasn't fully committed to A.A. Where are you holding back from full commitment to the program right now?
- 5.** The text says Jim was surprised and upset each time he got drunk again and spoke with A.A. members to figure out what went wrong. How do you process it when you relapse or come close to relapsing?
- 6.** Jim stopped at a restaurant where he had been going for years during his sober months and ordered a sandwich and milk. What familiar place or routine has become a trigger for your own drinking?
- 7.** Jim told himself that an ounce of whiskey in his milk on a full stomach couldn't hurt him. What version of this rationalization has your own mind produced to justify the first drink?
- 8.** The chapter says Jim had plenty of knowledge about himself as an alcoholic and ignored it all when he decided it would be safe to drink. How has self-knowledge alone failed to protect you from the first drink?
- 9.** The text says Jim went from ordering a sandwich and milk to ending up in a psychiatric ward. Describe how fast a single drink has escalated for you in your own experience.
- 10.** The chapter says if you read these stories and recognize yourself in them, then that is all you need—you are one of us. Which story in this chapter do you recognize yourself in most clearly?
- 11.** The text says Jim didn't start drinking until he was 35 but his drinking became serious very quickly. How quickly did your own drinking escalate once it crossed the line from casual to compulsive?
- 12.** The chapter says Jim lost his car dealership within a few years of heavy drinking. What have you lost to your drinking that took you years to build?
- 13.** The text says Jim started to become uncontrollably violent when he got drunk. How has your behavior while drinking shocked or frightened even you?
- 14.** The chapter says A.A. members have learned to see and understand the signs of a relapse before it happens. What signs in your own thinking tell you that you are getting dangerously close to a drink?
- 15.** The text says we know how alcoholics think and how they feel when they want to stop and cannot do it. Describe that feeling in your own words.

The mind of an alcoholic

- 1.** The text says Jim's story is not extreme to anyone in the Fellowship because it shows the same kind of thinking all of us have experienced. How has being around other alcoholics changed your definition of extreme?
- 2.** The chapter says the way our minds work is tricky: we could imagine the awful things that would happen after drinking but could always find an excuse to take the first drink. What was your most creative excuse for picking up?
- 3.** The text compares the alcoholic mind to a person obsessed with jaywalking who keeps getting hit by cars and cannot stop crossing the street. How does this image describe your own relationship with alcohol?
- 4.** The chapter says trying to reason with ourselves never worked for long and the unreasonable need to drink always won. Describe the last argument you lost with yourself about whether it was safe to drink.
- 5.** The text says there are times when we go out to get drunk on purpose using the excuse of feeling nervous, angry, worried, depressed, or jealous. What emotion most often gives you permission to drink?
- 6.** The chapter says when we began to drink regularly instead of casually, we almost never thought about the consequences of our actions. How have consequences become invisible to you in the moments before you pick up a drink?
- 7.** The text says some people will read this and think it doesn't apply to them because they haven't gone to the same extremes. What part of this chapter are you tempted to dismiss as not your problem?
- 8.** The chapter says actual alcoholics will be absolutely unable to stop drinking no matter what, and learning they are alcoholics will not help them. How many times has this statement proven true in your own experience?
- 9.** The text says the jaywalking woman says she will keep off the streets altogether but is back at it within a few weeks. What promise to stay away from alcohol have you broken despite full intention to keep it?
- 10.** The chapter says if we swap alcoholism for jaywalking the story fits us exactly, and even if we are smart and sensible in all other areas of life, when alcohol is involved we seem almost insane. What smart decision have you made in one area of life while making an insane one about drinking at the same time?
- 11.** The text says we feel as though we have lost our sanity when it comes to alcohol. When was the moment you first seriously suspected your sanity was gone?
- 12.** The chapter says alcoholics are able to ignore the ways that first drink might impact our lives, and this is both strange and puzzling. How do you explain this blind spot to yourself?
- 13.** The text says we will make this point over and over again so it is sure to sink in. Has the point sunk in for you, or are you still holding out hope that you are somehow different?
- 14.** The chapter says some people who aren't alcoholics can stop or control their drinking because their brains and bodies are not affected by alcohol the same way. What proof do you still cling to that you might be one of those people?
- 15.** The text says actual alcoholics will be absolutely unable to stop drinking just because they want to. How does sitting with this sentence change what you plan to do today?

Drinking without thinking

- 1.** Fred's story describes a partner at a well-respected accounting firm with a good income, a nice home, a happy marriage, and kids heading to college. How does Fred's outward success compare to your own life before drinking took over?
- 2.** The text says Fred went to the hospital with a bad case of jitters and felt ashamed, and he was not ready to admit he was an alcoholic. What physical symptom first made you feel ashamed of your drinking?
- 3.** Fred told himself he came to the hospital to rest his nerves instead of admitting the real reason. What cover story have you used to avoid admitting the truth about your drinking problem?
- 4.** The text says Fred wouldn't accept that he was an alcoholic and believed he could stop if he just put his mind to it. How long did you hold onto the same belief about yourself?
- 5.** Fred says he had no trouble saying no to drinks at first and began to wonder if he was making a big deal about nothing. When has a successful stretch of sobriety made you doubt that you were really an alcoholic?
- 6.** The text says Fred ordered a cocktail at dinner in Washington without any struggle or premeditation, like it was as harmless as ginger ale. Describe a time you started drinking without any conscious decision to do so.
- 7.** Fred says he realized he had an alcoholic mind and that willpower and self-knowledge would not help him during those strange times when his brain turned itself off. When did you make the same realization about your own mind?
- 8.** The text says Fred felt crushed when he understood that his thinking could not be trusted around alcohol. What did it feel like when you realized your own mind was working against you?
- 9.** Fred was told the alcoholic mentality was a hopeless condition he could not beat on his own. How did hearing this kind of statement affect your willingness to seek help outside of yourself?
- 10.** The text says Fred felt the actions he would need to take as part of the program made sense but also sounded hard. Which action in the A.A. program sounds hardest to you right now?
- 11.** Fred says as soon as he decided to join the program he had a strange feeling he would find relief soon, and it turned out to be true. Have you experienced any early relief or sense of hope since beginning the program?
- 12.** The text says Fred discovered that connecting with a Higher Power was the missing piece in his recovery. What have you tried that almost worked but was missing the spiritual component?
- 13.** Fred says he wouldn't trade the best moments of his old life for the worst moments of his new one. Can you imagine feeling that way, and if not, what stands between you and that feeling?
- 14.** The chapter quotes a doctor saying he had no doubt the A.A. founders would have been one hundred percent hopeless if they had not connected to a Higher Power. How does a doctor's confirmation of the spiritual solution affect your own willingness to try it?
- 15.** The text says at certain times alcoholics have no mental defense against the first drink and the only way to stop is to create a meaningful relationship with a Higher Power. What is your current relationship with your Higher Power, and how are you building it?

Chapter 3 Closing Prompts

- 1.** Which story in this chapter—the man who stopped for 25 years, Jim, or Fred—sounds most like your own experience, and why?
- 2.** How has reading this chapter changed your understanding of what happens inside your mind before you take the first drink?
- 3.** The chapter says actual alcoholics will be absolutely unable to stop no matter what. Do you fully accept this about yourself today?
- 4.** What experiment with controlled drinking are you still secretly tempted to try?
- 5.** How does the jaywalking analogy help you see your own drinking behavior from the outside?
- 6.** The chapter says the false belief that we can drink like normal people must be smashed. Has it been smashed for you, or is it cracked but still holding together?
- 7.** What physical symptom of your alcoholism did you ignore the longest before you could not ignore it anymore?
- 8.** How has the chapter's description of the alcoholic mind changed the way you think about the mechanics of relapse?
- 9.** The text says connecting with a Higher Power is the only defense against the first drink. How are you building that defense in your life today?
- 10.** What part of this chapter would you want to read out loud to a family member who doesn't understand why you can't just stop?
- 11.** How has your definition of insanity changed since reading this chapter?
- 12.** The chapter says some people will read this and think it doesn't apply to them. What part of you still thinks that about yourself?
- 13.** What is the most important difference between a hard drinker and a real alcoholic that you learned from this chapter?
- 14.** How does knowing that doctors agree alcoholics cannot become normal drinkers affect your commitment to recovery and to the program?
- 15.** What is the single sentence from this chapter that you need to remember the next time your mind tells you it is safe to take a drink?

Principles in This Chapter

- 1. Acceptance:** The text says the first step is to completely accept that we are alcoholics and the false belief that we are like other drinkers must be smashed. How far along are you in this acceptance today?
- 2. Honesty:** The chapter says we spent time and energy trying to prove we could drink normally. What lie about your drinking are you finally ready to stop telling yourself and others?
- 3. Humility:** The text says alcoholism doesn't care who you are, what you've done, or how strong your willpower is. How has this disease humbled your view of yourself?
- 4. Surrender:** The chapter says we have lost the ability to control our drinking permanently. What does surrendering to this reality look like in your daily life?
- 5. Willingness:** The text says the desire to connect with a Higher Power must come from within. What is your current level of willingness to seek spiritual help?
- 6. Open-mindedness:** The chapter says alcoholics stubbornly believe they can control their drinking despite all evidence. Where is stubbornness still blocking your recovery right now?
- 7. Vigilance:** The text says A.A. members have learned to see and understand the signs of relapse. What warning sign are you watching for in your own thinking this week?
- 8. Courage:** The chapter says we must face the truth about our condition. What truth about your alcoholism requires the most courage to face?
- 9. Trust:** The text says the only defense against the first drink is a meaningful relationship with a Higher Power. How are you building trust with your Higher Power today?
- 10. Patience:** The chapter describes recovery as a process, not a single event. Where do you need to practice more patience with yourself?
- 11. Self-awareness:** The text describes the alcoholic mind turning itself off before the first drink. What have you learned about the way your own mind works this week?
- 12. Gratitude:** The chapter says people in the program have found a way to recover from a hopeless condition. What are you grateful for about your recovery today?
- 13. Responsibility:** The text says we cannot blame our condition on anyone else or fix it through experiments. What aspect of your alcoholism are you taking full responsibility for?
- 14. Perseverance:** The chapter says the illness only gets worse and never better. How does this truth motivate you to keep working the program one day at a time?
- 15. Faith:** The text says at certain times we have no mental defense against the first drink except our Higher Power. How is your faith filling that gap when your thinking cannot be trusted?

Putting It Into Practice

- 1.** Write down every method you have used to try to drink normally. Next to each one, write honestly what actually happened.
- 2.** Read Jim's story out loud to your sponsor or a trusted friend this week. Ask them which parts of it sound most like your own behavior.
- 3.** Identify the last time you drank without thinking and write down every detail you can remember about what happened in the hours and minutes before you picked up the drink.
- 4.** Make a list of the warning signs that appear in your thinking before a relapse. Share this list with your sponsor and ask them to hold you accountable.
- 5.** Ask a medical professional to explain what alcohol is currently doing to your body. Write down what they say and keep it where you can read it when you feel tempted.
- 6.** Attend a meeting this week and listen specifically for someone who describes the same mental trick your mind plays on you right before you decide to drink.
- 7.** Write down the strongest argument your mind currently makes for why you should be able to drink again. Then write the truth next to it and compare them.
- 8.** Spend ten minutes each morning this week asking your Higher Power to protect you from the insanity of the first drink.
- 9.** Read the jaywalking analogy to someone who does not understand your alcoholism. Ask them if it helps them see what you have been trying to explain.
- 10.** Write a letter to your alcoholic mind. Tell it what you now know about its tricks and what you plan to do differently from this point forward.
- 11.** Identify one emotion that has historically given you permission to drink. Practice a different response to that emotion every time it appears this week.
- 12.** Call another alcoholic and ask them to describe a time they drank without thinking or planning to. Compare their experience to your own.
- 13.** Before you go to sleep tonight, review your day for any moment when your mind suggested drinking was an option. Write it down no matter how small it seemed.
- 14.** Schedule a conversation with your doctor about the physical effects of your drinking. Do not minimize or exaggerate when you describe your history.
- 15.** Tomorrow morning, before anything else, say out loud: I am an alcoholic and I cannot safely take the first drink. Say it like you mean it.

Chapter 4: We Agnostics

9 Sections • 135 Questions

We Agnostics

- 1.** The chapter says if you have tried your hardest to stop drinking and couldn't do it, you are probably an alcoholic. How many times did you try your hardest before you were ready to accept that truth?
- 2.** The text says the only way to permanently control your drinking is to create a personal connection with a Higher Power. What is your honest, unfiltered reaction to that statement?
- 3.** The chapter says choosing between dying an alcoholic death and finding a way to live a spiritual life is not an easy choice. Why is something that sounds so simple proving so hard for you to do?
- 4.** The text says nearly half of the original A.A. members were atheists or agnostics when they first formed the Fellowship. How does knowing this affect your willingness to try the spiritual path?
- 5.** The chapter says many of those early members tried to avoid the issue of spirituality at first and eventually realized it was the only way. How long have you been trying to avoid it?
- 6.** The text says if changing a few behaviors or thinking more positively could cure alcoholism, many of us would have recovered a long time ago. What self-improvement approach did you try that turned out to be not enough?
- 7.** The chapter says relying only on ourselves and our willpower always completely failed. How many times has your own willpower failed you before you started looking for something outside yourself?
- 8.** The text says as alcoholics we are powerless against our alcoholism, which means we need to connect with power outside of ourselves. How does it feel to admit you need help from a source you cannot see or fully understand?
- 9.** The chapter says this book was written to help you find a Power greater than yourself that will solve your problem. What are you hoping to find in these pages?
- 10.** The text says if you are an agnostic or atheist this may worry you. What specifically worries you about the spiritual aspect of recovery?
- 11.** The chapter says plenty of new A.A. members have doubts about spirituality at first, and their faces fall when God is mentioned. What doubts are you carrying into the program right now?
- 12.** The text says newcomers often look eager and hopeful as A.A. is explained and then their expressions change when spirituality comes up. What was your face doing the first time someone mentioned the God part of the program?
- 13.** The chapter says some of us connect the word God to ideas we were forced to accept during our childhoods. What childhood experience with religion are you still reacting to when someone says the word God?
- 14.** The text says we saw war, destruction, and pain in the world and found it hard to believe God would let these things happen. What event or experience in your own life made it hardest for you to believe in a Higher Power?
- 15.** The chapter says at other times, when we stopped to enjoy the magical beauty of nature, we felt like a Higher Power must exist. When have you felt that sense of something greater than yourself?

Define "God" on your own terms

- 1.** The text says we didn't have to immediately accept that God or any Higher Power exists—we just needed to keep an open mind about spirituality and faith. How open is your mind right now, honestly?
- 2.** The chapter says some of us slowly became more spiritual over time and others had very sudden and unexpected experiences of faith. Which path do you think you are on?
- 3.** The text says as soon as we allowed ourselves to believe in a Power greater than ourselves, we could change. What was the first change you noticed once you opened the door even a crack?
- 4.** The chapter says we didn't need to accept someone else's ideas about God—our own ideas and feelings were all we needed to begin. What are your own ideas about a Higher Power right now?
- 5.** The text says we found spirituality to be a big, friendly, welcoming space that is open to all people. How does this description compare to your previous experiences with organized religion?
- 6.** The chapter says when we use the word God in this book, we mean your own ideas of God and no one else's. How does this permission change the way you react when you see the word God on the page?
- 7.** The text says we just needed to ask ourselves one question: Am I willing to believe that there is a Power greater than myself? What is your answer to that question today?
- 8.** The chapter says as soon as you can say you are willing to believe, you are on the right track. What is the smallest honest belief you are currently willing to hold?
- 9.** The text says again and again we have seen open-mindedness change people for the better. How has being open-minded about one thing in recovery already started to change something else in your life?
- 10.** The chapter says at the beginning, all that was needed from us was openness. How is openness different from full belief, and why does that distinction matter to you?
- 11.** The text says many of us wished we could feel the way other members felt about their faith and thought it would work if only we believed the same way. What aspect of another member's faith do you wish you had?
- 12.** The chapter says we were relieved to learn we could begin our relationship with God at a simpler level than we expected. What does a simple relationship with a Higher Power look like to you?
- 13.** The text says we found that God didn't make it hard for people to connect or get spiritual help. What has made it hard for you, and how much of that is your own resistance?
- 14.** The chapter says all growth must start somewhere, so we started with our own ideas about God, no matter how simple or small they seemed. Where is your starting point?
- 15.** The text says we just needed to find and embrace a version of faith that felt true and powerful to us. What version of faith, even a rough sketch of one, feels true to you right now?

Let go of resistance to faith

- 1.** The text says we often felt stubbornness and prejudice against religion, and whenever someone brought up spirituality we would get angry or defensive. What is your strongest prejudice against religion or the idea of God?
- 2.** The chapter says we had to learn to let go of the habit of getting angry when spirituality was mentioned. What happens inside you right now when someone in a meeting talks about God?
- 3.** The text says we saw that we might be destroyed by our alcoholism if we didn't create a relationship with God, and decided that changing our thinking was better than the alternative. How real is the threat of destruction in your own life today?
- 4.** The chapter compares belief in God to belief in electricity—we accept theories about electricity because they explain what we see and use. How does this comparison affect the way you think about faith?
- 5.** The text says we happily accept what scientists tell us about gravity and other laws without visible proof. Why is accepting the possibility of a Higher Power harder for you than accepting the laws of physics?
- 6.** The chapter says those of us who believe we are in total control might ask ourselves if that sounds a little arrogant. Does it sound arrogant when you apply that question to yourself?
- 7.** The text says even imperfect faiths have given hope and meaning to millions of people all over the world. What imperfect faith or imperfect idea of God might still be enough to help you?
- 8.** The chapter says we used to look down on spiritual people and make fun of their beliefs to amuse ourselves. How has looking down on faith or mocking it kept you from finding your own?
- 9.** The text says we accused faithful people of being intolerant and prejudiced when we were being intolerant and prejudiced ourselves. Where are you still being intolerant of ideas about God or spirituality?
- 10.** The chapter says we saw a few bad people who claimed to be godly and assumed all godly people were just as bad. How has one bad experience with a religious person colored your entire view of faith?
- 11.** The text says we have let go of our prejudices about faith and learned to accept that there is a Power greater than ourselves. What prejudice are you ready to release today?
- 12.** The chapter says we don't need to believe the same things as other people in the program. How does knowing this take the pressure off your search for a Higher Power?
- 13.** The text says if connecting with a Higher Power could help us solve even a few of our problems, wasn't that worth exploring. Which problem in your life do you most want a Higher Power's help solving?
- 14.** The chapter says our own ideas about how to fix our lives did not work, but the God idea did. How many of your own ideas have you exhausted before arriving at this chapter?
- 15.** The text says A.A. is trying to show that faith is reasonable. What would it take for you to see faith as a reasonable response to your situation?

Where we all agree

- 1.** The text says there is one thing all A.A. members agree on: we now believe in a Power greater than ourselves, and that belief has helped us recover. What is the strongest evidence of this you have witnessed in another person?
- 2.** The chapter says when they felt despair and faced total failure, their own minds and feelings were not enough to change their situations. When were your own mind and feelings not enough to save you?
- 3.** The text says because of their faith, they found that a new power, peace, happiness, and sense of direction flowed into them. Which of these four things do you need most urgently right now?
- 4.** The chapter says before finding faith, they felt life was pointless even when they weren't drinking or drunk. How did the pointlessness of a dry life push you back toward alcohol?
- 5.** The text compares closed-minded people about faith to those who didn't believe the earth was round in Columbus's time. What commonly accepted truth about recovery are you still refusing to accept?
- 6.** The chapter uses the Wright brothers as an example of people whose strong belief kept them going despite expert opposition. How might believing in your recovery help you succeed despite your own doubts?
- 7.** The text says we agnostics and atheists hung onto the idea that our own power would solve all of our problems, including our drinking. How has your own power performed so far at solving the drinking problem?
- 8.** The chapter says logic is great stuff and we still like it, but we should rethink our prejudices about faith. Where has logic alone left you stuck in your recovery?
- 9.** The text says A.A. is trying to show that it is more sane and logical to believe in God than not to believe. What is your honest reaction to this argument?
- 10.** The chapter says many people at the time of Columbus did not believe the earth was round, and their minds were full of outdated ideas. What outdated idea about God or religion are you still carrying?
- 11.** The text says the Wright brothers' strong belief that they could build a flying machine was the reason they kept trying and succeeded. What belief is keeping you in recovery right now, even on hard days?
- 12.** The chapter says just 30 years after the first flight, airplanes were everywhere and minds that were once closed were forced open. How quickly has your own thinking about spirituality changed since entering the program?
- 13.** The text says the time we live in is more open to change and we are comfortable replacing old ideas with new ones. How open to replacing your old ideas about God are you today?
- 14.** The chapter says we were having trouble with relationships, emotions, jobs, our sense of purpose, and our health. Which of these areas needs the most help from a Higher Power in your life?
- 15.** The text says we saw other people solve their difficult problems by finding their own connection to spirituality, and then we knew we had to stop doubting. Who in your life or your group showed you this was possible?

The question of faith

- 1.** The text says we could no longer avoid the question of faith—is God everything or nothing—and asks how we were to choose. How are you answering that question for yourself today?
- 2.** The chapter describes people who had already crossed the bridge to faith, standing on the far shore waving at the rest of us. Who is standing on the far shore waving at you?
- 3.** The text says we began to cross toward accepting that a Power greater than ourselves truly existed. How far across the bridge have you come since you started the program?
- 4.** The chapter says our love of logic and reason held us back from stepping ashore into faith. What logical argument are you still using to avoid taking the final step?
- 5.** The text says we made ourselves think more closely about faith and realized we had always been faithful to a God of Reason. How is faith in your own reason similar to the faith A.A. asks you to have in a Higher Power?
- 6.** The chapter says we were also worshippers all along, worshipping people, feelings, things, money, and ourselves. What have you worshipped in place of a Higher Power?
- 7.** The text says love is a kind of worship and is not based in logic or reason. How does the experience of loving someone show you that faith is already part of your life?
- 8.** The chapter says it became impossible to say we were unable to feel faith, love, or worship because we had been doing all three our entire lives. How does recognizing this change your resistance to the spiritual program?
- 9.** The text says reason can't always be trusted, even when it comes from brilliant thinkers, because brilliant mathematicians proved humans would never fly. Where has your own brilliant reasoning been dead wrong?
- 10.** The chapter says deep down in every person is the simple and powerful idea of God, and it may be hidden by personal problems or worship of other things but it is still there. What does that buried idea look like for you when you are completely honest?
- 11.** The text says faith in some kind of God was as natural as the warm feelings we felt for our friends or partners. How natural does faith feel to you today compared to when you started the program?
- 12.** The chapter says some of us had to search long and hard but we always found our faith eventually. How long have you been searching, and what have you found so far?
- 13.** The text says God's existence was as clear and true as our own existence, and we connected with God deep inside of ourselves. Have you experienced any moment of this kind of clarity, even briefly?
- 14.** The chapter says people freed from alcoholism through faith told us God made it possible, and we only smiled at them. When did you stop smiling and start listening?
- 15.** The text says we finally saw that faith in some kind of God was as natural as any other feeling we had ever had. What would it mean for you to stop fighting faith and let it be as natural as it wants to be?

God is within you already

- 1.** The text tells the story of a minister's son who rebelled against his religious education and spent his life bitter and depressed until he fell to his knees and felt God's presence. What part of your own rebellion against faith might be keeping you from a breakthrough?
- 2.** The chapter says the man asked himself, Is it possible that all the religious people I have known are wrong? Have you ever asked yourself this same question with genuine curiosity instead of contempt?
- 3.** The text says the thought Who are you to say there is no God? appeared in his mind like a flash and swept away every other thought. What thought has appeared in your own mind about God that you have tried to push away?
- 4.** The chapter says the man fell out of bed onto his knees and was overwhelmed by a feeling that God was present in the room with him. Describe the most powerful spiritual moment you have experienced, even if it was small and fleeting.
- 5.** The text says on that very night his alcoholism disappeared, and except for a few moments of temptation, his desire to drink never returned. How does this story affect your hope for your own recovery?
- 6.** The chapter says whenever the man felt tempted, he also felt very strongly that drinking would be a huge mistake, and the idea of drinking made him sick to his stomach. How do you experience the pull of temptation and the pull of recovery at the same time?
- 7.** The text says God had restored his sanity. What would restored sanity look like in your daily life if it actually happened?
- 8.** The chapter says the elements of his story are simple: events in his life made him willing to believe, he humbly offered himself to God, and after that he was changed forever. Which of these three steps is the hardest for you to take?
- 9.** The text says some of us connect with God suddenly and in a flash, as this man did, and some of us grow into it more slowly. Which path do you expect for yourself, and which do you secretly hope for?
- 10.** The chapter says God has come to all who have honestly sought a connection with a Power greater than themselves. How honestly are you seeking right now, on a scale from going through the motions to fully committed?
- 11.** The text says when we allowed ourselves to become closer to God, we found God. What is preventing you from allowing yourself to become closer?
- 12.** The chapter says the mental barriers the man had built against faith were swept away on that night. What mental barrier of yours is still standing between you and a relationship with a Higher Power?
- 13.** The text says the elements of his healing are so simple: willingness, humility, and offering himself to God. Which of these elements do you currently have, and which one do you still need?
- 14.** The chapter says we hope these thoughts will help you think honestly and look inside yourself for your own faith. What do you actually find when you look inside yourself with honesty?
- 15.** The text ends this section by saying if you want to, you can join us on our journey toward recovery. What is your answer to that invitation today?

Chapter 4 Closing Prompts

- 1.** Which part of this chapter spoke directly to your specific resistance to spirituality?
- 2.** How has your working definition of God changed from the beginning of this chapter to the end?
- 3.** The chapter says nearly half of A.A.'s earliest members were atheists or agnostics. How does that fact change the way you see the program's spiritual foundation?
- 4.** What prejudice about religion or God did you recognize in yourself while reading this chapter that you had not seen clearly before?
- 5.** How has the comparison between faith in God and faith in electricity, gravity, and the Wright brothers affected the way you think about what is reasonable to believe?
- 6.** The chapter says all that was needed was openness, not total belief. What are you now open to that you were closed to before you read these pages?
- 7.** What is the strongest argument against faith that you are still carrying, and what would it take for you to set it down?
- 8.** How has the story of the minister's son affected your willingness to look inside yourself for a faith you may have been suppressing?
- 9.** The chapter says we don't need anyone else's spirituality as a model. What does your own model of a Higher Power look like, even as a rough draft?
- 10.** What specific experience in your life has hinted that a Power greater than yourself might actually exist?
- 11.** How willing are you today to say the words I believe there is a Power greater than myself out loud and mean them?
- 12.** What shifted in the way you think about God between the first page of this chapter and the last page?
- 13.** How has your experience in A.A. so far demonstrated the reality of a Higher Power, even if you cannot explain the mechanism?
- 14.** The chapter ends by inviting you to join the journey toward recovery. What is your honest response to that invitation right now?
- 15.** What is one thing you are willing to do differently this week as a direct result of reading this chapter?

Principles in This Chapter

- 1. Open-mindedness:** The chapter asks you to keep an open mind about spirituality and faith. What are you opening your mind to today that was closed yesterday?
- 2. Willingness:** The text says willingness to believe is the starting point for everything that follows. How are you practicing willingness this week in a concrete way?
- 3. Humility:** The chapter suggests that believing we are in total control of everything is a form of arrogance. How are you practicing humility about the limits of your own power and understanding?
- 4. Honesty:** The text says we need to ask ourselves honestly what God means to us. What is your most honest answer to that question right now?
- 5. Courage:** The chapter says choosing a spiritual life over an alcoholic death takes real courage. What courageous spiritual step are you taking or considering?
- 6. Faith:** The text says faith has been part of our lives longer than we realized, through love, worship, and trust in reason. Where do you already practice faith without calling it by that name?
- 7. Tolerance:** The chapter says we were intolerant of spiritual people while accusing them of intolerance. Where are you still being intolerant of someone else's ideas about God?
- 8. Surrender:** The text says our own ideas about fixing our lives did not work. What idea or plan are you ready to surrender to a Higher Power?
- 9. Trust:** The chapter says we can decide for ourselves how we want to think about the Power that guides us. How are you building trust in your own developing spiritual understanding?
- 10. Acceptance:** The text says accepting the idea that God may exist is all you need to start. What are you accepting today that you were fighting against last month?
- 11. Persistence:** The chapter says some of us had to search long and hard for our faith. How are you persisting in your search even when progress feels invisible?
- 12. Gratitude:** The text says connecting with a Higher Power was both simple and rewarding. What reward of even a small amount of faith are you grateful for?
- 13. Growth:** The chapter says all growth must start somewhere, no matter how small. Where is your spiritual growth actually starting this week?
- 14. Freedom:** The text says finding God made the man in the story a free man for the first time in his life. What does spiritual freedom mean to you, even if you haven't fully experienced it?
- 15. Hope:** The chapter says God has come to all who have honestly sought a connection with a Power greater than themselves. How does this promise give you hope for your own journey?

Putting It Into Practice

- 1.** Write down your current definition of a Higher Power in your own words. Put it somewhere you will see it. Revisit it in 30 days and note what has changed.
- 2.** Identify one specific prejudice you hold against religion or spirituality. Ask someone in the program who had the same prejudice how they worked through it.
- 3.** Spend five minutes each morning this week sitting in silence with your mind open to a Higher Power. Write down anything that comes to you, even if it seems meaningless.
- 4.** Find one thing in nature this week that makes you feel like something greater than yourself must exist. Return to it when doubt creeps in.
- 5.** Read this chapter with someone who shares your doubts about God. Discuss what you each found challenging and what you each found unexpectedly helpful.
- 6.** Write a letter to the version of yourself that was most resistant to spirituality. Tell that person what you are beginning to understand now.
- 7.** Ask three different people in the program what their Higher Power looks like to them. Listen without judging or comparing.
- 8.** Identify one area of your life where you are still trying to be in total control. Practice releasing that control to your Higher Power for one full day and notice what happens.
- 9.** Before bed tonight, ask whatever Higher Power you can imagine one honest question. Be quiet and listen for any response, even if it comes as a feeling rather than words.
- 10.** Make a list of all the things you already believe in that you cannot see with your eyes, such as love, gravity, or loyalty. Add a Higher Power to the list and sit with how that feels.
- 11.** Attend a meeting this week and listen specifically for how other people describe their personal relationship with God or a Higher Power. Take notes on what resonates.
- 12.** Write down the strongest logical argument against faith that you hold. Then write the strongest argument you can make in favor of it. Compare the two honestly.
- 13.** Choose one prayer or statement from any tradition that feels even slightly true to you. Say it every morning this week and notice if anything shifts.
- 14.** Tell someone in the program that you are struggling with the spiritual aspect of recovery. Ask them for help without defensiveness.
- 15.** Walk outside for fifteen minutes this week with no phone, no earbuds, and no destination. Pay attention to what you notice about the world and about yourself.

Chapter 5: How It Works

12 Sections • 180 Questions

How It Works

- 1.** The chapter opens by saying it is very rare for someone to completely commit to the A.A. program and still fail. In what ways are you prepared to fully commit, and where do you feel yourself holding back?
- 2.** The text says people who do not recover are the ones who can't or won't be honest with themselves. How are you practicing honesty with yourself at this stage of your recovery?
- 3.** The chapter says some of us thought we could find an easier way, but we could not. Share a time you tried to find an easier, softer way to deal with your drinking and what happened when the shortcut failed.
- 4.** The text says some of us tried to keep our old ideas and they just held us back. What old idea or attitude have you had to let go of in order to start making progress in recovery?
- 5.** The chapter says alcoholism is a confusing and powerful condition that seems to control and punish people who are addicted to it. When did you first feel controlled and punished by alcohol rather than comforted by it?
- 6.** The text says without help, beating alcoholism is too much for one person to handle. How have you been reminded that you cannot manage life or sobriety by your own willpower alone?
- 7.** The chapter says we stand at a turning point and ask for God's protection and care with all the honesty we have. What does standing at a turning point feel like in your life right now?
- 8.** The text says we share stories about what we used to be like, what happened to us, and what our lives are like now. If you reflect on your own journey, what are the key points of your story in those three parts?
- 9.** The chapter says we are asking you to be fearless and thorough from the start. How do you plan to apply fearlessness and thoroughness in working the steps, and where have you caught yourself wanting to hold back?
- 10.** The text says the Twelve Steps are suggested as a program of recovery and that no one has ever followed them perfectly. What does spiritual progress, not spiritual perfection mean to you after reading this section?
- 11.** The chapter says three simple ideas form the foundation of the program: we are alcoholics and cannot manage our own lives, no human power could stop our alcoholism, and God could help us if we tried to find God. Which of these three is hardest for you to accept?
- 12.** The text says half measures availed us nothing. Where do you catch yourself taking half measures in your recovery or in your life right now?
- 13.** The chapter says the cunning and baffling nature of alcoholism means we cannot do this alone. Share an example of a time alcohol or your own thinking tricked you and reminded you why you need help.
- 14.** The text describes the Twelve Steps in full. Looking at all twelve, which step scares you and which one are you most eager to work on?
- 15.** The chapter says until we let go of our old ideas, we were unable to make progress. What old idea are you still clinging to that may be blocking the next step in your recovery?

The Twelve Steps

- 1.** Step One says we admitted we were powerless over alcohol and that our lives had become unmanageable. Describe a specific moment when you truly felt powerless over alcohol.
- 2.** Step Two says we came to believe that a Power greater than ourselves could restore us to sanity. How has your understanding of a Higher Power evolved since you began this journey?
- 3.** Step Three says we made a decision to turn our will and our lives over to the care of God as we understood Him. What does turning it over look like for you in practice, and where do you struggle to let go?
- 4.** The chapter includes a prayer that says God, I offer myself to You, to partner with me and guide me as You think best. What part of this prayer is easiest for you to say with honesty, and what part catches in your throat?
- 5.** The text says connecting with your Higher Power with someone who might misunderstand will be more difficult than doing it alone. Who in your life would you trust to take this spiritual step with you?
- 6.** Step Four calls for a searching and fearless moral inventory. What feelings come up when you think about writing down your flaws, mistakes, and painful memories?
- 7.** Step Five asks us to admit the exact nature of our wrongs to God, to ourselves, and to another human being. What makes sharing your wrongs with another person feel different from just admitting them to yourself?
- 8.** Steps Six and Seven ask us to be entirely ready to have God remove our defects and to humbly ask for their removal. Is there a defect you secretly feel reluctant to let go of because it feels protective or familiar?
- 9.** Steps Eight and Nine deal with making a list of people we have harmed and making direct amends to them. How does thinking about those names make you feel right now—guilty, motivated, afraid, or something else?
- 10.** Step Ten says we continued to take personal inventory and promptly admitted when we were wrong. How would practicing a daily review of your behavior change the way you live?
- 11.** Step Eleven asks us to improve our conscious contact with God through prayer and meditation. Do you currently have any routine for prayer or meditation, and if not, what would you be willing to try?
- 12.** Step Twelve says having had a spiritual awakening, we tried to carry this message to other alcoholics. How do you feel about the idea that helping others is not optional but essential to your own survival?
- 13.** The text says no one has ever followed these principles perfectly and the goal is spiritual progress, not perfection. How can applying the idea of progress instead of perfection make you more patient with yourself?
- 14.** The chapter says the wording of the Step Three prayer is just a suggestion, and you can choose other words that express the same idea. What words would you use if you were writing your own version of this prayer?
- 15.** The text says if you say the words of dedication honestly and humbly, the power of your new understanding will fill you. Have you experienced any moment where honest words produced a feeling of power or relief?

Stop playing God

1. The text says the very first thing we needed to understand was that following our own self-centered plans would never work in the long run. Describe one situation where you acted like the director of everything and how things turned out.
2. The chapter compares self-centered people to actors who want to run the whole show, arranging the spotlights and telling everyone what to do. How do you tend to react when life doesn't go according to your script?
3. The text says while trying to control everything, we may seem kind, patient, and generous at times, and mean, selfish, and dishonest at other times. In what ways have you shown these mixed traits while trying to manage your life?
4. The chapter says when people put themselves in charge, the show doesn't go well, and they become even more controlling in response. Where in your life are you still doubling down on control after it has already failed?
5. The text says these unfortunate people blame others for their troubles and struggles. Describe a time you were convinced someone else was to blame for a problem, but later realized your own actions set it in motion.
6. The chapter says quit playing God is the essential message. What does that phrase mean to you personally, and how can you practice letting go of control today?
7. The text says people who run their lives this way act kind to others only when it benefits them. Share a time you were generous or helpful but your real motive was to get your own way.
8. The chapter says self-centered people make others feel bullied, which causes those people to bully them back. How have your attempts to control people in your life caused them to push back against you?
9. The text describes a cycle where what we want doesn't match up to what we do, creating confusion instead of peace. Think of a time when others didn't follow the script you had in mind for them and describe how you handled it.
10. The chapter says if we're being truly honest, we all act like the director of our own show sometimes. Identify one area of your life today where you are still playing the director.
11. The text says these people create confusion instead of peace in their own lives and in the lives of others. What fears are underneath your need to control everything—fear of being judged, getting hurt, or things falling apart?
12. The chapter asks us to consider letting God be the director of the drama called life. How does it make you feel to consider letting a Higher Power or the recovery process take charge—relief, fear, resistance, or hope?
13. The text says when we truly accepted that God was in charge, all sorts of amazing things began to happen. Describe a time when you let go of control over a situation and trusted your Higher Power or the natural course of events.
14. The chapter says we became less interested in ourselves and more interested in how we could help other people. When have you felt a new sense of purpose by focusing on helping others rather than running your own schemes?
15. The text says we enjoyed peace of mind and discovered we could face life successfully. Have you noticed a difference in your stress or anxiety levels when you manage to let go compared to when you are clinging tightly to control?

How selfishness hurts us

- 1.** The text says selfishness is the root of our troubles, and we allow fear and self-pity to rule our lives, ending up hurting or angering the people around us. Share an example where your own selfish action caused pain for yourself or someone else.
- 2.** The chapter says if we think carefully about how we've acted, we always seem to find that we did something selfish first, and that put us in a position to be hurt later. Describe a time you blamed someone else but later realized your own behavior started the chain of events.
- 3.** The text says alcoholics are even more self-centered than most people, though we never seem to realize this. How have fear or self-pity led you to act selfishly—perhaps avoiding responsibility, lashing out, or isolating?
- 4.** The chapter says the root of our troubles is self-centeredness. How have you seen selfishness play out as a pattern in your major problems or recurring conflicts?
- 5.** The text says our Higher Power makes it possible for us to change our selfishness, and there may be no other way. What does it feel like to consider putting God in charge of your life rather than yourself—comfort, anxiety, or resistance?
- 6.** The chapter says it took some time to understand that we had to quit playing God because doing that just wasn't working for us. Can you recall a turning point from selfishness toward faith or selflessness, a moment when you chose the right thing for someone else's benefit?
- 7.** The text says we decided that God was going to be our director, and this decision changed everything for us. Have you experienced any peace or freedom from practicing this decision, even briefly?
- 8.** The chapter says when we truly accepted that God was in charge, we felt a new sense of purpose and everything we needed came to us. What fears do you have about relying on a Higher Power to take care of your life and problems?
- 9.** The text says we stopped worrying about our little plans and schemes and were interested in how we could contribute to life and help other people. When have you felt a shift from selfish aims to helping someone, and what did it feel like inside?
- 10.** The chapter says we felt a new kind of power flow in, we enjoyed peace of mind, and we stopped feeling afraid of both the present and the future. In what ways has humility begun to replace self-will in your life?
- 11.** The text says we felt like we had been reborn. How do tolerance and patience start to grow when you let go of selfishness? Share a recent time you practiced patience instead of acting on a selfish impulse.
- 12.** The chapter says the Step Three prayer asks God to take away the prison of self that we have lived in. Why can it be hard to recognize your own selfishness, and have you ever thought you were acting nobly only to discover selfish motives underneath?
- 13.** The text says saying the prayer honestly and humbly is only the beginning. How do you try to contribute to life rather than just take from it now that you are in recovery?
- 14.** The chapter says many A.A. members found it helpful to take the Step Three spiritual step with an understanding person. How have you been asking for help in your recovery, and who has made a difference?

- 15.** The text says this idea was simply beautiful and became extremely important to the journey toward freedom. Now that you are working on stopping playing God, what is one specific action you can take to step back and allow events to unfold without your interference?

Taking inventory and responsibility

- 1.** The chapter says after committing to Step Three, we started a personal house cleaning because putting ourselves in God's hands needed to be followed by action. What does the phrase personal house cleaning mean to you?
- 2.** The text says drinking was just a symptom of a larger disease and we had to understand its causes and conditions. What underlying issues do you suspect have fueled your alcoholism—insecurity, resentments, trauma, fear?
- 3.** The chapter says we started our personal inventories, lists of all the things in our lives that held us back. Have you ever tried to examine your own behavior or motives before, and how does that compare to the Step Four process?
- 4.** The text compares the inventory to what businesses do when they count every item on their shelves and get rid of damaged goods. What feelings come up when you think about writing down your flaws, mistakes, and painful memories?
- 5.** The chapter says we need to understand ourselves, know what's inside of us, and be willing to throw out harmful ideas and behaviors. What are some old attitudes or behaviors you have identified as destructive that you are now willing to get rid of?
- 6.** The text says we thought long and hard about the traits and actions related to selfishness, and found that resentment is the worst offender. In what ways have anger or grudges affected your drinking and your happiness?
- 7.** The chapter says resentment destroys more alcoholics than anything else. How has holding onto anger consumed your time, energy, or peace of mind?
- 8.** The text says we are not only mentally and physically ill, we are spiritually ill, and resentment is the source of many forms of spiritual disease. How can facing the truth about your thoughts and actions—even the ugly parts—help you get better?
- 9.** The chapter says the inventory process requires being both thorough and completely honest. Why is it important not to fool yourself about what's really on your internal shelves?
- 10.** The text says to fully recover we need to cure our spiritual illness, and better mental and physical health will follow. What is one positive quality about yourself that you have discovered or remembered during this process?
- 11.** The chapter says we took stock honestly and searched out the flaws in our personalities that caused our struggles. How do you feel about listing the people you have hurt—does it bring up guilt, sadness, or motivation to make things right?
- 12.** The text says this is a searching and fearless moral inventory. What does taking responsibility for your own mistakes mean to you now, compared to how you handled mistakes before recovery?
- 13.** The chapter says we already believed that selfishness was what had hurt us most, so we began there. Share any small sense of freedom or relief you have gotten from beginning this inventory process.
- 14.** The text says businesses that don't take inventory regularly don't understand themselves and may go broke. How is writing an inventory an act of courage and self-care rather than self-punishment?
- 15.** The chapter says after listing our mistakes we felt willing to make them right. How do you see the principle of responsibility coming to life as you engage in this step?

Dealing with resentment

1. The text says we listed people, groups, or ideas we were angry at and then asked ourselves why. If you've started listing your resentments, what have you learned from seeing them on paper?
2. The chapter says in most cases our anger came from feeling that our confidence, bank accounts, ambitions, or personal relationships were hurt or threatened. What feelings usually lie underneath your anger—hurt, fear, or a bruised ego?
3. The text provides an example inventory with columns for who we resent, why we resent them, and what part of our lives was affected. How has holding onto anger or a grudge consumed your time, energy, or peace of mind?
4. The chapter says a life full of resentment can only create unhappiness, and for alcoholics it can be fatal because it makes us want to live alone in darkness. Have your resentments ever led you back toward drinking or risky behavior?
5. The text says holding on to our grudges can be fatal because the craving for alcohol returns and we drink again. What have been the personal consequences of resentment in your life—relationships lost, opportunities missed, damage to your health?
6. The chapter says we turned back to our inventory and decided to look at it from a different angle, and saw that our feelings of anger were shaping our lives. How did your perspective shift when you began to see your own part in a resentment?
7. The text says we realized the people who wronged us might be spiritually sick too, and accepting they were ill helped us feel less angry. Have you experienced a moment where you realized someone you resented was also struggling or sick in their own way?
8. The chapter says we asked God to help us show the same compassion and patience we would show to sick friends. What does forgiveness mean to you today, and is there someone you are working on forgiving to free yourself?
9. The text says we stopped ourselves from arguing or fighting back because we would not treat sick people that way. How can you use gratitude or helping others as a tool when you feel resentment creeping in?
10. The chapter says instead of looking for the wrongs others had done, we looked for our own mistakes and asked where we were selfish, dishonest, and afraid. Many of us are not just angry at others but angry at ourselves. Are you carrying resentment toward yourself?
11. The text says resentments shut us off from the warm sunlight of spirituality. In your experience, how does being resentful affect your spiritual condition or sense of peace?
12. The chapter says we tried to focus on how we had been wrong in those situations and wrote our faults down in black and white. What actions are you taking now when a new resentment pops up in everyday life—calling your sponsor, writing about it, praying for the person?
13. The text says resentment is feeling anger about being treated unfairly and holding a grudge for a long period of time. How does letting go of even one resentment, even temporarily, make you feel lighter or more free?
14. The chapter says our inventory was ours, not the other person's. Resentments often come from unmet expectations. Identify one expectation you had of someone that led to anger, and how adjusting that expectation might prevent the resentment.

- 15.** The text says when we were finished we re-read our lists very carefully and saw that we believed the world had treated us very badly. How does seeing the pattern of your resentments on paper change the story you have been telling yourself about how unfair life has been?

Fear hides everywhere

- 1.** The text says the word fear sat next to every complaint on the example inventory, like an evil and destructive thread woven through the fabric of our existence. Think of a resentment you listed—can you identify how fear was connected to that anger?
- 2.** The chapter says so often our fears were the real cause of our resentments, and fear caused events that created pain we felt we didn't deserve. What are some of your biggest fears—rejection, failure, being alone—and how have they influenced your behavior and decisions?
- 3.** The text says we reviewed our fears thoroughly and put them on paper, even if they weren't connected to resentments. Describe a time when you let fear drive your decisions, and what happened as a result.
- 4.** The chapter asks whether our fears came from believing we could do everything and know everything, and then finding out we were wrong. When you reflect on your life, in what areas do you see fear woven into your experiences—relationships, work, self-esteem?
- 5.** The text says some of us had felt very confident at times, but our confidence never took away our fears, and when it made us cocky, it was worse. Has there been a time when your overconfidence was actually a cover for fear underneath?
- 6.** The chapter says we needed to find a better way to deal with our fears, and we found it in trusting and relying on a Higher Power. How does trusting a Higher Power help you handle your fears differently than trying to manage everything alone?
- 7.** The text says we learned to trust God rather than trying to understand, manage, and do everything in our lives alone. Share an example where you turned a fear over to God and found courage or calm as a result.
- 8.** The chapter says faith is a kind of courage, just as trusting a Higher Power is a kind of courage. Describe a time in recovery when having faith gave you the courage to do something you were afraid to do.
- 9.** The text says when we ask God to remove our fears and help us focus on better things, we can begin to outgrow our fears. Identify one fear you have been able to let go of or lessen since getting sober, even a little bit.
- 10.** The chapter says we are not ashamed of relying on God or of needing God, and our faith and trust are a sign of strength. How is it different facing life now knowing you don't have to do it all alone?
- 11.** The text says by putting trust in God, we are able to get through our darkest, most difficult, and most fearful times. What can you do on a daily basis to practice faith over fear when a specific fear arises?
- 12.** The chapter says we put our fears on paper even if they weren't connected to resentments. If you've listed your fears, what did you notice about them? If you haven't, what do you suspect might happen if you wrote them all down?
- 13.** The text says our fears were often the real cause of our resentments and created trouble we felt we didn't deserve. Could you admit that your own fears had caused that trouble in the first place?
- 14.** The chapter says we believed we could do everything and know everything, then found out we were wrong. Imagine what your life could be like if you were no longer ruled by fear—what changes do you envision?

- 15.** The text says when we ask God to help us focus on better, more important things, we can begin to outgrow our fears. What do you think it means to outgrow a fear, and are there fears that used to paralyze you that now feel smaller?

How to inventory your sex life

1. The text says A.A. does not want to judge anyone's sex life and we all have sex problems because we wouldn't be human if we didn't. As you review your past relationships, where do you recognize that you were selfish or dishonest?
2. The chapter says we reviewed our own actions and asked where we had been selfish, dishonest, or inconsiderate, and whom we had hurt. Why is it important to examine your sexual conduct without shame or harsh judgment, treating it like any other problem area?
3. The text says we tried to imagine a smart and fair way to run our sex lives in the future and asked God to help us create ideals. What kind of person do you want to be in your relationships going forward, and what values would you like to guide your behavior?
4. The chapter says we looked at each sexual relationship and asked did I act selfishly here or not. Can you recall a time when your actions in a relationship made someone feel jealous, hurt, or distrustful, and what could you have done differently?
5. The text says we remembered that sex is natural, which means it is basically good, and we shouldn't be greedy about it or feel disgusted by it. What fears or insecurities have driven some of your unhealthy relationship behaviors in the past?
6. The chapter says we ask God what we should do, and the right answer comes if we want it. How does it feel to take an honest look at your sex life and relationship history—uncomfortable, surprising, relieving?
7. The text says we wanted ideals for our sex lives and help living up to them. What do you think your Higher Power would want a healthy relationship to look like for you, and how is that different from how you behaved in the past?
8. The chapter says we wouldn't be human if we didn't have sex problems. How does knowing that everyone has flaws in this area make you feel about examining your own?
9. The text says making changes in your sex life means being willing to make amends whenever you're wrong. Is there someone from a past relationship whom you feel you may owe an apology or amends?
10. The chapter says if we are sorry and truly want our Higher Power to point us toward better things, we can be forgiven. Have you started to practice any of your new relationship ideals, and what difference has it made?
11. The text says if we are not sorry and our choices continue to harm other people, we will drink, and there is no maybe about it. What does forgiveness look like for you in terms of your sex life and relationships—forgiving yourself or forgiving someone who hurt you?
12. The chapter warns us not to drift into guilt or remorse over sex conduct because that could lead us to drink. How do you plan to balance honest accountability with self-compassion as you face the harms you caused?
13. The text says if your relationships are messy and difficult, you can focus your energy on helping other people, which takes you out of yourself. How could helping someone else when you are stressed about a relationship actually help you too?
14. The chapter says sex is natural and basically good, cautioning against extreme views. How has your attitude about sex or intimacy been extreme or unhealthy in the past, and how can embracing a balanced view help your recovery?

- 15.** The text says we ask God what we should do and the right answer comes if we want it. Identify one pattern in your relationships that you recognize as harmful, and what is one concrete step you can take to begin changing it?

Faith helps us when we cannot help ourselves

- 1.** The text says if you are thorough about your inventory, you will write a very long list of resentments and begin to see how pointless and dangerous they are. What new insights have you gained about how your resentments, fears, and selfish behaviors have affected your life?
- 2.** The chapter says you have begun to learn tolerance, patience, and good will toward all people, including your enemies. How have your feelings toward the people you were angry at begun to change as you work through your inventory?
- 3.** The text says you now think of your enemies as sick people who need and deserve your help. What does tolerance or goodwill toward someone you used to dislike feel like—have you experienced even a small amount of kindness toward a former enemy?
- 4.** The chapter says you have listed the people you have hurt and you are willing to straighten out the past if you can. Why is being willing to make amends so important for your recovery, and how do you think doing so will free you from guilt?
- 5.** The text says faith helped us when we couldn't help ourselves. Can you recount a time in your recovery when you felt completely stuck or helpless and relying on your Higher Power got you through it?
- 6.** The chapter says if you have already made a decision and an inventory of your mistakes, you have taken important steps. Now that you have faced some hard truths, do you feel more hopeful about the future?
- 7.** The text says you have swallowed and digested some big chunks of truth about yourself and you are on your way toward a better and brighter life. What is one big truth about yourself that was hard to admit but that you have come to accept?
- 8.** The chapter says a Higher Power can remove whatever barriers kept you from finding your faith in the past. What inner barriers or character defects have you identified that used to block you from peace—pride, resentment, fear?
- 9.** The text says we hope you are convinced now that a Higher Power can help. In what ways do you feel you are already on your way to a better life, even if the changes are small?
- 10.** The chapter says faith helped us when we couldn't help ourselves, and this is said again and again throughout the book. How accepting uncomfortable truths about your past or character has actually given you strength rather than weakness?
- 11.** The text says you are on your way toward a better and brighter life already. Think about who you were before starting recovery and who you are now—in what ways are you different?
- 12.** The chapter says you have begun to learn tolerance, patience, and good will toward all people. What role has faith or a Higher Power played in helping you complete your inventory and face your past?
- 13.** The text says the inventory process reveals how pointless and deadly resentments are. How do you see the relationship between your own action and God's help in recovery—both your effort and your Higher Power's guidance working together?
- 14.** The chapter says you are on your way. As you finish this chapter, how will you continue to use faith and honesty moving forward in the next phases of your recovery?
- 15.** The text says we hope you are convinced that a Higher Power can remove whatever barriers kept you from finding faith. What positive changes or possibilities do you now see for yourself as a result of confronting your past and working on your character?

Chapter 5 Closing Prompts

- 1.** Having reviewed the process of a searching and fearless moral inventory, what is your biggest fear or hesitation about completing one for yourself?
- 2.** Which part of this chapter's message resonated with you the most—the insight about honesty, the description of selfishness, or the importance of willingness—and how does it relate to your experience?
- 3.** What concept or section from this chapter did you find most challenging to accept or understand, and what about it was difficult for you?
- 4.** How has reading *How It Works* changed your perspective on what is required to recover from alcoholism?
- 5.** In working through this chapter, what personal growth or progress have you noticed in yourself—more honest, more open to help, more committed?
- 6.** After learning about self-will run riot and the need to quit playing God, how do you feel about taking Step Three? Are you more willing now, and what changed?
- 7.** What is one old idea about yourself, your addiction, or recovery that you have let go of or started to question as a result of this chapter?
- 8.** The chapter asks us to be fearless from the very start. Can you identify an area in your recovery where you have decided to practice courage instead of avoidance?
- 9.** The text says our goal is spiritual progress, not spiritual perfection. How can this idea help you be more patient with yourself as you continue working the steps?
- 10.** Half measures availed us nothing. Looking at your efforts so far, are there areas where you recognize you were holding back, and what can you do to go all in?
- 11.** Of all the Twelve Steps, which one are you most eager to work on and which one do you find most intimidating?
- 12.** How do you plan to apply the tools from this chapter in everyday life—a nightly inventory, pausing to ask your Higher Power for guidance, or something else?
- 13.** What emotions did you experience while reading this chapter—hope, fear, resistance, relief? Pick one and discuss what caused it and what it tells you about where you are.
- 14.** If you were to summarize the key message of *How It Works* to a newcomer, what would you say about the importance of honesty, willingness, and thoroughness?
- 15.** As you complete this chapter, how do you feel about moving forward to Chapter 6 and the action steps? What aspect of the upcoming work are you looking forward to or dreading?

Principles in This Chapter

- 1. Honesty:** Where in your life do you need to practice more rigorous honesty with yourself? Identify a situation or feeling you've been in denial about and what it would look like to face it with courage.
- 2. Courage:** What fears make it hard for you to look at yourself truthfully? How can drawing on courage through prayer or the support of others help you walk through those fears and be honest?
- 3. Honesty:** Share a time when being completely truthful with yourself or someone else was very difficult but ultimately freeing. What did you learn about the value of honesty in your recovery?
- 4. Courage:** How does having the courage to face your character flaws or mistakes actually help you grow? Describe how confronting something uncomfortable about yourself led to positive change.
- 5. Responsibility:** What does taking responsibility for your past actions mean to you now, and how is this different from how you handled things when you were drinking?
- 6. Responsibility:** Why is it important to focus on your own part in conflicts instead of fixating on what others did wrong? How are you practicing personal responsibility today?
- 7. Responsibility:** Describe a situation in sobriety where you chose to be accountable for your behavior rather than hide it or rationalize it. What was the outcome?
- 8. Responsibility:** In doing your inventory, what is one thing you have discovered about yourself—a defect or a positive trait—and how does acknowledging it represent taking ownership of who you are?
- 9. Humility:** How do you understand the principle of humility as taught in this chapter? What does accepting your human limits and not being the center of the universe mean in your daily life?
- 10. Humility:** Where have you seen your own self-centeredness cause trouble or pain? How does admitting you need help demonstrate humility?
- 11. Humility:** Have you had a moment in recovery that truly humbled you—realizing you were wrong, or seeing that you needed forgiveness? What did it teach you about being right-sized?
- 12. Humility:** In what ways can practicing humility instead of selfish pride improve your relationships? How might approaching someone with humility go better than approaching them with ego?
- 13. Surrender:** What does surrendering your will to your Higher Power mean to you personally? Is there a specific area you are still holding onto tightly and need to let go of?
- 14. Surrender:** How has making a decision to trust the care of a Higher Power impacted your life so far? Do you feel any more peace or relief as a result of turning it over?
- 15. Surrender:** What fears do you still have about turning your life over to the care of God as you understand God? How can you address those fears and find more willingness to surrender?

Putting It Into Practice

- 1.** This chapter introduced the idea of writing a personal inventory. What is one small action you can take this week to begin or continue that process—even if it is just setting aside twenty minutes to write down one resentment and its causes?
- 2.** How will you make sure you approach your inventory with honesty and thoroughness? What practical steps can you take—finding a quiet space, praying for guidance, or reviewing the inventory format?
- 3.** Who can you reach out to for support as you work on these steps? Identify a person—your sponsor, a trusted friend in recovery, or a mentor—and how they might help.
- 4.** When and how can you fit this work into your routine? Set aside a regular time—mornings, evenings, or a lunch break—dedicated to prayer, reading, or writing inventory so it becomes a habit.
- 5.** Think of an old idea or habit from your drinking days that still lingers. What is one thing you will do differently this week when that old behavior or thought shows up?
- 6.** Identify a current situation where you've been trying to control the outcome. How can you practice letting go and letting God in this situation—what is one action of releasing control you will take?
- 7.** Choose one fear that tends to disturb you regularly. When that fear crops up this week, what healthy action will you take—saying the Serenity Prayer, calling a friend, or writing in a journal?
- 8.** Think of a person, institution, or idea you feel resentful toward. What is one step you can take this week toward releasing that resentment—praying for them, writing an unsent letter, or actively practicing gratitude?
- 9.** How will you use the fellowship or meetings as you put these principles into practice? Can you commit to sharing about your step work progress or asking someone who has done it before for guidance?
- 10.** What is a simple daily practice you can start to improve your conscious contact with your Higher Power? Pick one—a morning prayer, a few minutes of meditation, or reading a page of recovery literature—and commit to it this week.
- 11.** If you start feeling overwhelmed or anxious about your inventory or future amends, what will you do instead of picking up a drink? Identify a specific plan—calling your sponsor, going for a walk, attending a meeting.
- 12.** Working on yourself can be intense. How will you take care of yourself as you do this work? List one way you will practice self-care—getting enough sleep, taking breaks, or rewarding yourself after step work.
- 13.** Willingness is key in this chapter. What is one thing you can do in the next few days to demonstrate willingness—approaching someone you've been avoiding, or trying your Higher Power's will in a situation rather than your own?
- 14.** Negative self-talk can creep in when we face our faults. What strategy will you use to combat self-criticism or shame—reminding yourself you are doing this to heal, or sharing those feelings with a sponsor instead of dwelling on them?
- 15.** How will you acknowledge the progress you are making? List one way to mark your efforts—telling yourself good job, treating yourself to something small after a tough writing session, or noting in a journal something you did today for your recovery.

Chapter 6: Into Action

11 Sections • 165 Questions

Into Action

- 1.** The chapter opens by asking now that you have made your personal inventory, what should you do about it? How did you feel when you realized that making the list was only the beginning and more action was required?
- 2.** The text says before you made your inventory, you started trying to find your spirituality and connect with a Higher Power, and part of that process was figuring out if anything was blocking you. What obstacles did your inventory reveal between you and your Higher Power?
- 3.** The chapter says making your inventory helped you find those obstacles and name them, and you began to see where you were selfish and wrong. What was the hardest thing to see about yourself when you read your own inventory?
- 4.** The text says your mistakes and weaknesses are going to be removed from you, but to make this possible you must take action. How do you react to the idea that removal requires action on your part, not just willingness?
- 5.** The chapter says you must take the Fifth Step: Admitted to God, to ourselves, and to another human being the exact nature of our wrongs. Why do you think admitting your wrongs to another person is necessary when you have already admitted them to yourself?
- 6.** The text says discussing our mistakes and weaknesses with another person is very difficult, but it's also very important. What makes this step feel more difficult than the ones that came before it?
- 7.** The chapter says if we skip this vital step, we may not be able to stop drinking. How does knowing that your sobriety depends on completing this step change your willingness to do it?
- 8.** The text says we may think we did enough by trying to be honest with ourselves while we made our inventory, but making this list by ourselves is not enough. Where in your recovery have you tried to do just enough rather than going all the way?
- 9.** The chapter says we must go further and talk about our inventory with someone else. What fears come up when you think about telling your whole story to another human being?
- 10.** The text says the most important reason for sharing your inventory is this: if we skip this vital step, we may not be able to stop drinking. How does the life-and-death weight of this statement compare to the discomfort of sharing?
- 11.** The chapter says now that you have your inventory, what comes next is action. How has the program taught you that insight without action produces no lasting change?
- 12.** The text says making your inventory helped you see how you were keeping yourself from connecting with your Higher Power. What specific behavior or attitude from your inventory was blocking your spiritual connection?
- 13.** The chapter says your mistakes and weaknesses are going to be removed from you. Do you believe that removal is possible, or does part of you doubt that these things can actually be taken away?
- 14.** The text says before you made your inventory you started trying to find your spirituality. How has your spiritual life changed between the beginning of Step Four and now?
- 15.** The chapter frames everything that follows as action steps. What is the difference between understanding the program and actually working it?

Finish your house cleaning

- 1.** The text says many new people wanted to keep their lives secret and avoid discussing the truth with anyone, and almost all of them struggled to stay sober. What part of your life are you most tempted to keep secret, even from people in the program?
- 2.** The chapter says these people did everything else in A.A. but never completed their house cleaning, and at some point they got drunk. How does knowing that incomplete honesty leads to relapse affect the way you approach this step?
- 3.** The text says they thought they had gotten rid of their selfishness and fear, but they had not, because they had not told someone else their complete life story. What is the difference between thinking you have dealt with a defect and actually dealing with it through sharing?
- 4.** The chapter says many alcoholics lead double lives, acting like characters on stage and pretending to be people we are not. Describe the character you have been performing for the world and how that performance differs from who you really are.
- 5.** The text says leading a double life becomes harder when we go on drinking sprees, and realizing someone may have seen us act that way is very upsetting. What memory of your behavior while drinking do you push deepest inside yourself?
- 6.** The chapter says these memories are like nightmares, and pushing them deep inside makes us feel constantly afraid and tense, which can lead to more drinking. How has the weight of your secrets affected your stress level and your temptation to drink?
- 7.** The text says many of us have spent thousands of dollars working with psychologists and never felt able to tell them the whole truth. What has prevented you from being fully honest with the professionals in your life?
- 8.** The chapter says we couldn't be honest with our psychologists or anyone else, and no wonder so many doctors believe alcoholics can't recover. How has your inability to be honest with others reinforced the belief that you cannot get well?
- 9.** The text says they started to take inventory but didn't finish the process. Where in your own step work have you started something important and then stalled before completing it?
- 10.** The chapter says one reason it's hard for alcoholics to know when we have told our entire life stories is that we are like actors showing people the version of ourselves we want them to see. What version of yourself have you been showing to your A.A. group that isn't the whole truth?
- 11.** The text says feeling afraid and tense can lead to more drinking. What specific secret or unshared truth is creating tension in you right now?
- 12.** The chapter says even if they did everything else in the program and followed all of the other eleven steps, these people almost always struggled to stay sober. How does this statement affect the priority you give to completing your Fifth Step?
- 13.** The text says we think the reason they couldn't stay sober is that they never completed their house cleaning. What does a completed house cleaning look like to you—how will you know when you have been thorough enough?
- 14.** The chapter says they thought they had learned to be humble, but they had not. How is sharing your complete story with another person an act of humility that you cannot achieve alone?
- 15.** The text says the consequences of keeping secrets include constant fear, tension, and eventually drinking. Imagine the feeling of having no more secrets—how do you think that freedom might affect your sobriety?

Find the right person

- 1.** The text says we must all find a way to be entirely honest with somebody if we want to live long or happily. Who do you trust enough to hear your entire life story without judging you?
- 2.** The chapter says those who belong to religions that require confession might want to talk with their faith leaders, and even those without religious connections may feel comfortable with them. What qualities in a person make you feel safe enough to share your worst truths?
- 3.** The text says it might be one of our own family members, but we cannot share anything with our spouses or parents that will hurt them and make them unhappy. How will you balance being honest about your past with not causing unnecessary harm to a loved one?
- 4.** The chapter says the rule is we must be hard on ourselves, but always considerate of others. How does this principle guide your decision about who should hear your Fifth Step?
- 5.** The text says the right person will be able to keep a secret and will understand why we need to do this and never try to stop us from sharing. What are your biggest worries about the person you choose—that they will judge you, be shocked, or break your confidence?
- 6.** The chapter says being unable to find the right person cannot become an excuse to skip this step. If you catch yourself delaying, what do you suspect is the real reason—fear of the process itself or fear of what you will have to reveal?
- 7.** The text says when we have decided on a person, we should make a plan to tell our story immediately. Do you have a plan for completing your Fifth Step, and if not, what is stopping you from making one this week?
- 8.** The chapter says most people who are told how important they are to our recovery feel honored and are glad to help. How does knowing this change your reluctance to ask someone to listen?
- 9.** The text says we must swallow our pride and start telling our story, sharing all the ugliest parts of our personalities. Picture yourself after you have shared everything—what feelings do you expect, and which ones do you look forward to?
- 10.** The chapter says once we have told our complete, unedited stories, we feel happy and relieved and can look the world in the eye. If you have already done your Fifth Step, describe how you felt afterward. If you haven't, what relief are you hoping for?
- 11.** The text says our fears fall away from us and we may start to feel closer to our Higher Power. How important is it to you that the person hearing your story has similar experiences or understands addiction from the inside?
- 12.** The chapter says before this we may have had spiritual beliefs, but now we start to have a spiritual experience. What do you think the connection is between telling the truth about yourself and experiencing a spiritual shift?
- 13.** The text says it feels like walking down a wide, open road hand in hand with the Spirit of the Universe. What has someone said to you about the Fifth Step experience that makes you either more hopeful or more nervous?
- 14.** The chapter says after sharing our whole story, we go home, find a quiet place, and think back over what we have done. What can you do to prepare yourself before meeting to share your inventory—prayer, reviewing your notes, or practicing with smaller truths first?
- 15.** The text says taking this step with our written inventory is like building an arch toward freedom, and we need to check if all the stones are in the right place. Knowing that completing this step is vital to your freedom from alcohol, how does that motivate you to overcome your fear of sharing?

Let go of defects

1. The text says Step Six asks if we are entirely ready to have God remove all our defects of character, and that willingness is especially important now. Take a look at your character defects—is there one you secretly feel reluctant to let go of because it feels protective or comfortable?
2. The chapter says we must ask ourselves if we are ready to let our Higher Power remove all of our problems and struggles, and asks can God really take them all away, every single one? What does being entirely ready mean to you, and how can you tell if you are truly ready?
3. The text says if it turns out there is something we can't let go, we can ask God to help us release it. How do you feel about the idea that a Higher Power can remove your shortcomings—skeptical, hopeful, or confused?
4. The chapter says when we feel ready, we have completed Step Six. Which defect of character causes you the most trouble in sobriety right now, and how might your life change if it were dramatically reduced?
5. The text includes the Step Seven prayer asking the Creator to remove every single defect of character which stands in the way of usefulness. Be honest—do you believe there are any defects or negative behaviors you still need in some way, like selfishness to protect yourself or control to prevent chaos?
6. The chapter says the principle of Step Six is willingness. How do you practice being willing to change rather than simply trying to force change through your own willpower?
7. The text says Step Seven is about humility—humbly asking for removal of shortcomings. What does humility mean to you in this context, and why is being humble rather than demanding important when asking for help?
8. The chapter says when you feel ready you say the prayer and then you have completed Step Seven. Have you attempted in the past to fix your character defects on your own through willpower or self-help, and how did that work out?
9. The text says the prayer asks God to grant strength as I go out from here to do your bidding. How is surrendering your defects to a Higher Power different from making a New Year's resolution to be a better person?
10. The chapter says we must ask ourselves if we are ready to let our Higher Power remove all of our problems. Looking at your defects, which one most interferes with you being helpful or available to other people?
11. The text says if there is something we can't let go, we can ask God to help us release it. Are you comfortable with the idea of praying for the removal of your shortcomings, or is prayer still new and awkward for you?
12. The chapter says being willing and open to spiritual change is especially important at this point. How do your defects show up in your daily life right now—pick one and describe a recent situation where it appeared.
13. The text says this step is about having God remove these defects. What do you think it will look like in practice when a defect is being removed—will you never feel it again, or will you simply be able to walk through it more easily?
14. The chapter says willingness is the key to Steps Six and Seven. When you notice a defect cropping up, what practical action can you take in that moment to let go rather than give in—pause and pray, call someone, make an amends on the spot?

- 15.** The text says after saying the Step Seven prayer, we have completed that step and are ready for more action. How will you measure progress on your defects—what signs will tell you that a shortcoming is being lifted?

Be willing, make amends

- 1.** The text says Step Eight asks us to make a list of all persons we had harmed and become willing to make amends to them all. Have you compiled your amends list yet, and how did you feel seeing those names written down?
- 2.** The chapter says we made this list or most of it when we took inventory. What does it mean to you to be willing to make amends to them all—are there people on your list you feel unwilling or not ready to face?
- 3.** The text says Step Nine is where we reach out to people we've hurt to fix the damage we did in the past. How do you think making amends will benefit you internally, independent of how the other person responds?
- 4.** The chapter says if we don't feel ready, we work with our Higher Power until we are ready, because we agreed at the beginning to do whatever it took. Do you have fears about facing someone you hurt—that they will yell, reject you, or bring up things you're ashamed of?
- 5.** The text says the Ninth Step cautions us to make direct amends except when to do so would injure them or others. Why is it important to consider other people's wellbeing before rushing to apologize, and can you think of an example where full disclosure might cause harm?
- 6.** The chapter says amends can take many forms, and we use guidelines to make this step effective. Think of one person on your list—what might a meaningful amends look like beyond just saying I'm sorry?
- 7.** The text says no matter what happens, we cannot criticize the other person or argue with them during amends. How will you demonstrate honesty and humility when you meet someone to make things right—your tone, your words, your willingness to listen without defending yourself?
- 8.** The chapter says we just tell them we won't be able to stay sober until we have done our best to straighten out the past. Reflect on the saying faith without works is dead—why is actually making amends necessary rather than just feeling sorry?
- 9.** The text says to make amends to an enemy we must find a way to push through our discomfort, and we grow more by making amends to an enemy than to a friend. Which amends on your list do you expect to be the hardest, and what support do you need to face it?
- 10.** The chapter says we focus on changing ourselves and never tell others what to do with their lives. If someone has ever made an amends to you, how did it make you feel toward that person, and how does that memory influence your approach now?
- 11.** The text says when we are making amends we don't talk about the faults of the other person—we stick to our own. Some amends might not be possible to make in person. Is there an amend on your list that can't be done directly, and how could you make amends in spirit?
- 12.** The chapter says if we stay calm, are honest, and remain open, we will be happy with the results. How will you handle it if a person you approach is not receptive or is still angry despite your genuine attempt?
- 13.** The text says we may feel worried about talking to coworkers and friends about our spiritual experience, but we don't have to talk about God right away. As you became willing to make amends, did you start to see your past actions in a new light?
- 14.** The chapter says they will be more interested in our good will than hearing about our spiritual discoveries. How will you show people through your behavior that you have changed, rather than just telling them?

- 15.** The text says clearing away the clutter and mess we've made is what Step Nine is about. As you think about completing your amends, what freedom do you anticipate feeling when the wreckage of the past is cleared?

Expect the unexpected when making amends

- 1.** The text says most of the time when we make amends, unexpected things happen—sometimes the person admits they are wrong too, and bad feelings that lingered for years vanish in an instant. When you imagine making amends, what outcomes do you hope for and what outcomes do you fear?
- 2.** The chapter says sometimes our former enemies praise what we are doing and wish us well, and sometimes they offer to help us. How would you respond if someone you expected to be angry reacted with kindness or forgiveness instead?
- 3.** The text says however, it shouldn't matter if the person decides to throw us out of their office—we still need to do our part. Why is it important to make your amends regardless of the outcome?
- 4.** The chapter says we owe them an honest attempt to make things right, and we cannot deny them what we owe. How will you handle it if someone reacts negatively—still hurt, still angry, or unwilling to hear your apology?
- 5.** The text says when we tell them what we are trying to do, we don't try to hide anything about our drinking because they usually know about it anyway. Have you experienced a time when you expected someone to be unforgiving but they ended up being understanding?
- 6.** The chapter says we cannot worry about how long it has taken us to make these amends because our drinking has made us slow to understand what needs doing. If during an amends the other person brings up things you hadn't remembered or realized, how will you remain open and not defensive?
- 7.** The text says we must put aside our fear of being judged because we might drink if we are afraid to face our enemies. What will you do if you catch yourself starting to justify or explain your past behavior instead of simply owning it?
- 8.** The chapter tells the story of a man who owed alimony and wrote his first wife admitting his faults and asking forgiveness, and she did not insist on jail. How does this story of an unexpected positive outcome give you courage for your own difficult amends?
- 9.** The text says before taking any action that might affect other people, we need to ask for their consent and consult with others. Some amends may involve practical actions like repaying a debt—if the person refuses your repayment or demands more than you can give, how will you respond?
- 10.** The chapter tells the story of a man who borrowed money and denied it, then used his own wrongdoing to destroy the lender's reputation. What personal benefit do you most look forward to from completing your amends—feeling lighter, self-respect, sleeping better, or no longer dreading seeing that person?
- 11.** The text says this man decided it was better to take the risks of making amends than to stand before God feeling guilty, and he saw that he had to trust God or he would start drinking again. How can discussing your specific worries about an amend with your sponsor help you prepare for any outcome?
- 12.** The chapter says he quietly got up and told his story to his church congregation and today is one of the most trusted citizens in his town. Have you planned what you will say during a particular amend—is it simple, clear, and focused on your responsibility?
- 13.** The text says we remind ourselves that we are committed to finding a spiritual experience, and we ask to be given strength and direction to do the right thing. How does trusting your Higher Power factor into making amends with unpredictable outcomes?

- 14.** The chapter says we may lose our jobs, ruin our reputations, or even go to jail, but we are willing because we must not run away from anything. What is the amends you are most tempted to postpone, and what might you risk if you keep putting it off?
- 15.** The text says however, making amends involves other people, and we must be careful not to hurt them as we work to save ourselves. How do you balance the urgency of making things right with the caution not to cause more damage in the process?

Infidelity and amends at home

- 1.** The text says many of us have cheated on our partners, and drinking complicates our sexual relationships. If you have deeply hurt a partner or family member, what feelings arise when you think about making amends to them?
- 2.** The chapter says if we are sure our spouse does not know about an affair, we should not always tell them, and if they know generally we need to admit we've been wrong without necessarily sharing all details. How can you balance being honest about the fact that you were wrong with not causing additional pain through unnecessary confessions?
- 3.** The text says we have no right to go further than admitting we were wrong and saying we won't do it again, and we should avoid naming the other person if possible. Rebuilding trust at home takes a long time—what actions are you taking or plan to take to show your family you have truly changed?
- 4.** The chapter says when it comes to being unfaithful we are dealing with one of the worst human emotions: jealousy. How can understanding the pain of jealousy help you be patient and compassionate when working through amends with your partner?
- 5.** The text says just staying sober means we are still a long way from making amends to our spouses or parents who stood by us. If your family members are still angry or distant, how can you show through actions rather than words that you are serious about change?
- 6.** The chapter says it is almost impossible to understand the patience of partners and parents who stood by us, and many of us would have had nowhere to go if they had left. Besides not drinking, what do you owe your family in terms of daily behavior and amends?
- 7.** The text says an alcoholic is like a tornado roaring through the lives of others—hearts are broken, sweet relationships are dead, affection is destroyed. Reflect on how your drinking and behavior impacted your partner or family—what specific incident shows how much they endured?
- 8.** The chapter says alcoholics who say stopping drinking is enough are like farmers who come up from the basement after a tornado and say don't see anything wrong here. When you make amends to your spouse or partner, how can you show that you truly understand the hurt you caused rather than just focusing on your own regret?
- 9.** The text says we need to sit down with the family and talk honestly about the past, being very careful not to criticize them for their part in it. If you have children, what are some ways you might make amends to them for not being the parent they needed?
- 10.** The chapter says their defects may be obvious but it's likely that actions we took are also responsible, so we clean house with the family. During your drinking days or in sobriety, did you blame your partner or family for your unhappiness, and how are you taking responsibility now?
- 11.** The text says spiritual life is not a theory and we have to live it, but unless our families tell us they also want to live using spiritual principles, we shouldn't force them. Trust is easily broken and slowly rebuilt—what do you think it will take to regain the trust of your loved ones?
- 12.** The chapter says seeing our behavior change will convince them more than words ever could. What positive changes have you already made in how you interact with your family since getting sober?
- 13.** The text says there may be some wrongs we can never fully right, but as long as we can honestly say we would right them if we could, we don't need to worry. Sensitive amends at home might benefit from professional or spiritual counsel—who can you seek guidance from?

- 14.** The chapter says when we do speak with people about amends, we need to be polite, considerate, and humble without being dramatic or overly apologetic—we don't need to crawl, we can stand on our own two feet. When you approach your family to make amends, they may express anger or bring up old wounds—how will you practice listening without becoming defensive?
- 15.** The text says we don't delay amends unless it's truly necessary. If your family does eventually forgive you, how will you honor that forgiveness? And if they are not ready, how will you practice acceptance and continue living your amends through changed behavior?

Finding serenity

- 1.** The text says if we are painstaking about Step Nine, we will be amazed before we have made amends to half our list—we will find new freedom and new happiness. Have you started to experience any of this freedom or happiness as a result of working the steps so far?
- 2.** The chapter says we will not regret the past or wish we could forget about it. What would it mean for you to no longer regret your past—are you beginning to see how even your mistakes can have value?
- 3.** The text says we will understand the word serenity and we will know peace. How do you define serenity for yourself at this moment in recovery, and have you felt even small moments of it?
- 4.** The chapter lists promises: freedom, happiness, no fear of the past, knowing peace, feeling useful, losing self-pity, interest in others, and God doing for us what we could not do for ourselves. Which promise resonates with you most deeply and gives you the most hope?
- 5.** The text says these promises come true among A.A. members every day, sometimes quickly and sometimes slowly, and they will always come into our lives if we work for them. Do any of these promises seem unbelievable to you right now, and are there any you have already seen come true in small ways?
- 6.** The chapter says Step Ten means we continue to take personal inventory and promptly admit when we are wrong. How do you plan to practice a daily inventory—a nightly review, quick amends when you slip up, or something else?
- 7.** The text says we keep watching for selfishness, dishonesty, resentment, and fear, and when they show up we ask God to remove them and talk about them with someone immediately. In what ways has your attitude or outlook on life already started to change as you've progressed through these steps?
- 8.** The chapter says love and tolerance of others is our way of life, and at this point we have stopped fighting anything or anyone, even alcohol. What does it feel like to stop fighting—have you experienced any moments where the obsession with alcohol simply wasn't there?
- 9.** The text says Step Eleven asks us to improve our conscious contact with God through prayer and meditation. Do you currently have a routine for prayer or meditation, and if not, what type of practice would you be willing to try?
- 10.** The chapter says we will suddenly realize that God is doing for us what we could not do for ourselves. Have you had any moments in recovery where you felt your Higher Power helped you overcome something you couldn't have managed alone?
- 11.** The text says fear of people and of money worries will leave us. Have you noticed any decrease in your social fears or financial anxiety as you have gotten sober and made changes?
- 12.** The chapter says our whole attitude and outlook upon life will change. How would you describe your mental and emotional state now compared to when you were drinking or when you first came into the program?
- 13.** The text says we will lose interest in selfish things and gain interest in our fellows, and the feeling of uselessness will disappear. Do you find yourself becoming more interested in others and wanting to help?
- 14.** The chapter says every day is a day when we must bring the vision of God's will into everything we do. What does the idea of a spiritual awakening mean to you—do you feel you have had one, or that you are in the process?

- 15.** The text says the next chapter is all about Step Twelve, carrying the message. How do you feel about the prospect of helping others with what you've learned—excited, nervous, or unsure?

Chapter 6 Closing Prompts

- 1.** The Ninth Step Promises say that our experience can benefit others. How might the most difficult parts of your story end up helping someone else who is still suffering?
- 2.** After focusing on cleaning up your past and working on yourself through Steps Five through Nine, how do you feel about turning outward and helping another alcoholic?
- 3.** What fears or insecurities do you have about the idea of becoming a sponsor or guiding someone else in recovery someday?
- 4.** How has completing the action steps in this chapter—admitting your faults, asking for defect removal, making amends—changed you as a person?
- 5.** What was the most significant insight or breakthrough you had during this phase of your step work?
- 6.** Of the steps covered in this chapter—Five through Eleven—which one was most challenging for you, and which came more naturally?
- 7.** How has your relationship with your Higher Power evolved throughout the process of Steps Five through Nine?
- 8.** The A.A. program speaks of a spiritual awakening as a result of these steps. Do you feel you have started to experience one, and how would you describe it?
- 9.** In making your amends and clearing away the past, what positive emotions or changes have you noticed in yourself—feeling lighter, more self-respect, calmer, less angry?
- 10.** Is there any part of this chapter's process that you feel is unfinished or needs more attention—amends still to make or defects to keep focusing on?
- 11.** What is your strategy for continuing to practice these principles daily so you don't slip back into old behaviors?
- 12.** Now that you have done the internal work, the next step is carrying the message. What are you looking forward to about sharing what you've learned or giving back?
- 13.** How do you handle life differently now compared to before you did these steps? Describe a recent situation where you reacted in a healthier way than you would have in the past.
- 14.** If a newcomer asked you about the experience of doing Steps Five through Nine, what message of hope would you share with them?
- 15.** As you prepare to move into Chapter 7 and Step Twelve, what is one commitment you will maintain to ensure you continue growing?

Principles in This Chapter

- 1. Action:** The theme of this chapter is that recovery requires action, not just belief. What does faith without works is dead mean to you now, and can you give an example of how taking concrete action has improved your sobriety?
- 2. Action:** How has actually working the steps—sharing your inventory, praying, making amends—changed you in ways that merely understanding the steps never could?
- 3. Action:** Think of one practical recovery action you plan to continue doing regularly now that you have built momentum. Why is this action important for maintaining your sobriety?
- 4. Humility:** In Step Five, you shared your wrongs with another person. How did that experience teach you humility, and what was it like to honestly admit your faults out loud?
- 5. Humility:** Step Seven asks us to humbly ask for our defects to be removed. What did humility feel like when you acknowledged your need for your Higher Power's help instead of trying to fix yourself alone?
- 6. Humility:** Making amends often requires swallowing pride. How did you practice humility when you approached someone you had harmed, and was it challenging not to justify yourself?
- 7. Humility:** Of all the actions you took in this chapter, which one required the most humility from you personally?
- 8. Willingness:** Identify something you have done in the past few weeks that shows willingness to grow or change. What made you willing to do it?
- 9. Willingness:** How did your willingness evolve when it came to facing a particular defect or making a certain amends you initially didn't want to make?
- 10. Willingness:** Steps Six and Eight were about being ready and willing. Where did you feel the most resistance, and how did you convert it into willingness?
- 11. Willingness:** How do you practice maintaining an attitude of willingness in daily life? Give an example of choosing to be open-minded where in the past you would have been stubborn.
- 12. Forgiveness:** Making amends isn't just about seeking forgiveness—it often leads to forgiving others and ourselves. Has the process of making amends helped you forgive yourself?
- 13. Forgiveness:** Have you begun to forgive someone else as a result of working these steps? Has understanding your own flaws given you compassion for the flaws of others?
- 14. Forgiveness:** Why is forgiving yourself important as you move forward? What do you do when feelings of guilt resurface after you have already made your amends?
- 15. Forgiveness:** Not everyone you approached may be ready to forgive you. How are you dealing with a situation where you apologized but the other person is still distant? How do acceptance and patience help you find peace even without the other person's forgiveness?

Putting It Into Practice

- 1.** If you haven't completed your Fifth Step yet, what is one concrete step you will take this week to set it up—calling your sponsor to schedule a time, or choosing the person who will hear your story?
- 2.** Identify one character defect that still pops up regularly. What is one thing you can do this week to practice the opposite trait or chip away at that defect?
- 3.** Choose one person from your amends list you haven't reached out to yet. Write down when, where, and how you will approach them, and discuss the plan with your sponsor.
- 4.** How will you implement Step Ten's daily personal inventory? Decide on a method—journaling each night, a morning review, or a quick check-in with your sponsor—and commit to it this week.
- 5.** What can you do to strengthen your Step Eleven practice of prayer and meditation? Set a specific time and commit to even five minutes of quiet contact with your Higher Power each day.
- 6.** For those closest to you, what is one living amend—an ongoing positive change in behavior—that you will carry out consistently starting today?
- 7.** If there is an amend you cannot make immediately, what will you do in the meantime—write a detailed letter you don't send, pray for the person daily, or do something charitable in their honor?
- 8.** Pick a personal habit tied to one of your defects. What specific change will you practice this week to form a healthier pattern—counting to ten before reacting in anger, or answering one difficult call instead of avoiding it?
- 9.** If resentment or regret creeps back in, what will you do to practice forgiveness in the moment? Decide now—pray for the person's wellbeing, call a friend, or write about it instead of dwelling.
- 10.** Plan a way to acknowledge your completion of these tough steps in a healthy manner—a quiet day of reflection, a letter to yourself noting how far you've come, or sharing your gratitude at a meeting.
- 11.** Find one opportunity to be of service to someone else in the coming week—chairing a meeting, giving a newcomer a ride, or calling another member to check in. Put it on your calendar.
- 12.** What is one piece of recovery literature or practice you want to explore to deepen your understanding? Commit to reading a chapter, attending a workshop, or starting a daily reflection book.
- 13.** Identify a warning sign or trigger that could endanger your sobriety. Write down your action plan for when you notice that warning sign—going to a meeting, calling your sponsor, or removing yourself from the situation.
- 14.** Who will help hold you accountable for continuing to practice these steps? Plan a regular check-in with your sponsor or a recovery friend where you update them on your Step Ten and Eleven practices.
- 15.** Set one tangible short-term goal for your recovery in the next month—finishing all family amends, practicing meditation every morning, or taking a newcomer to coffee. Write it down and share it with someone.

Chapter 7: Working With Others

10 Sections • 150 Questions

Working With Others

- 1.** The chapter opens by saying working with other alcoholics is the most effective way to keep from drinking, and it works when everything else fails. How has helping another person in recovery kept you sober when nothing else could?
- 2.** The text says the Twelfth Step asks us to carry this message to alcoholics and to practice these principles in all our affairs. What does carrying the message mean to you in practical, daily terms?
- 3.** The chapter says we can help other alcoholics when no one else can because we know what they have gone through and they will trust us when they cannot trust anyone else. Share a time when another alcoholic's trust in you felt like a responsibility you took seriously.
- 4.** The text says watching other people recover, watching them help others, and seeing their loneliness disappear is an amazing experience. Describe a moment when you witnessed someone else's recovery and how it affected your own.
- 5.** The chapter says spending time with newcomers and with each other is the bright spot of our lives. How has working with newcomers changed the way you see your own story?
- 6.** The text says you can find people who are ready to get sober by asking doctors, faith leaders, or hospitals. How did you first connect with someone who needed help, or how do you plan to?
- 7.** The chapter says when we first start talking with newcomers, we try not to be preachy or judgmental because many people are uncomfortable with God talk. How do you bring up the spiritual side of recovery without pushing someone away?
- 8.** The text says it's your own drinking experience that will make you most useful to other alcoholics. What part of your drinking story do you think is most useful to someone who is still suffering?
- 9.** The chapter says our only goal is to cooperate, never criticize, and be helpful. How does approaching another alcoholic with no agenda other than being helpful change the dynamic of the conversation?
- 10.** The text says if someone does not want to stop drinking, don't waste time trying to convince them, and this advice should also be given to their family. How hard is it for you to walk away from someone who isn't ready?
- 11.** The chapter says you need to find out about the newcomer's behaviors, problems, and background, and think about standing in their shoes. How does understanding someone else's situation before you speak to them change the way you approach them?
- 12.** The text says sometimes it works best to wait until the individual goes on a drinking binge before approaching them. How does waiting for the right moment show more wisdom than rushing in to help?
- 13.** The chapter says the family should describe you as a person who has recovered, part of a fellowship of people who try to help others stop drinking. How do you want to be introduced to someone who needs help?
- 14.** The text says if the individual does not want to see you, don't force them, and urge family members to be as calm as they can. What happens when you force help on someone who isn't ready to receive it?
- 15.** The chapter says usually the family should not try to tell your story, and it is better to meet a problem drinker through a doctor or treatment center than through their family. Why is it more

effective for a recovering alcoholic to carry the message than for a desperate family member to do it?

The first conversation

- 1.** The text says to visit the problem drinker while they are still jittery because they may be more open to A.A.'s ideas when still feeling unwell. How does physical discomfort create an opening that comfort does not?
- 2.** The chapter says to speak to the problem drinker alone if you can and start with general conversation before talking about drinking. Why is it important to leave the family out of the first discussion?
- 3.** The text says to tell the newcomer enough about your own drinking habits, symptoms, and experiences to encourage them to talk about theirs. How much of your own story do you share before you stop and listen?
- 4.** The chapter says if the person decides to talk, let them, because doing this will help you know how to keep the conversation going. What happens when you listen more than you speak during a Twelfth Step call?
- 5.** The text says when the problem drinker understands that you know all about drinking, start to describe yourself as an alcoholic and tell them how confused you were and how you finally learned you were sick. How does naming yourself as an alcoholic first change the power dynamic in the conversation?
- 6.** The chapter says to show them the mental tricks alcoholics play on themselves that lead to the first drink of a spree. Which mental trick from your own experience is most useful to describe to someone who doesn't understand why they keep drinking?
- 7.** The text says if the individual is alcoholic, they will understand you immediately and see that some of your thinking doesn't make sense, and then see that sometimes their thinking doesn't either. Describe a conversation where you watched recognition appear on another alcoholic's face.
- 8.** The chapter says to talk about the hopelessness of alcoholism from your own experience and show them how hard it is to live life drunk. How do you share the hopelessness of your story without leaving the person feeling hopeless themselves?
- 9.** The text says be careful not to label them as an alcoholic and let them decide that for themselves. Why is it more effective to let someone reach their own conclusion about their alcoholism than to diagnose them?
- 10.** The chapter says insist that if they are too sick, they probably cannot recover by themselves. How do you deliver this hard truth in a way that opens a door rather than slams one shut?
- 11.** The text says you will soon have your friend admitting they have many if not all of the traits of the alcoholic. What signals tell you that the person you're talking with is beginning to identify?
- 12.** The chapter says to tell them funny stories of your experiences if their mood is light. How does humor serve a purpose in a Twelfth Step conversation that seriousness alone cannot?
- 13.** The text says be careful not to scold or lecture. What is the difference between sharing your experience and lecturing someone about theirs?
- 14.** The chapter says to keep the person's attention focused on your personal experience. How does staying anchored in your own story prevent you from becoming preachy or judgmental?
- 15.** The text says say that many alcoholics destroy their lives without realizing what they're doing, and doctors are reluctant to tell patients the whole truth unless they're certain it will help. What gives you the right to tell an alcoholic the truth that their doctor may be holding back?

Helpful strategies

1. The text says even though the person may not have accepted their own alcoholism, they will become curious and want to know how you got well. How do you recognize the moment when curiosity replaces defensiveness in the person you are helping?
2. The chapter says to be sure to talk about the spiritual aspect of A.A. but if your friend is agnostic or atheist, be very clear that they do not have to agree with your ideas about God. How do you present the spiritual solution without making it sound like religion?
3. The text says the main thing is to be willing to believe in a Power greater than themselves and live by spiritual principles. How do you convey that willingness is the starting point, not total faith?
4. The chapter says to use everyday language to describe spiritual principles because you don't want to make them feel defensive about religion. What everyday language do you use when talking about your Higher Power with someone who is uncomfortable with the word God?
5. The text says your problem drinker may already be a religious person whose faith is deeper than yours but who hasn't applied it. How do you help someone see that deep religious knowledge that hasn't been put into action is not the same as working a spiritual program?
6. The chapter says faith must be paired with self-sacrifice and unselfish helpful action. How has your own experience shown you that belief without action produces no lasting change?
7. The text says we practice no particular religion and only deal with the general principles that most religions are built on. How does this distinction help you work with someone whose religious background is very different from your own?
8. The chapter says to explain how you made your inventory, straightened out your past, and why you are now trying to be helpful to them as a problem drinker. How do you describe the inventory process to someone who has never heard of it in a way that doesn't scare them off?
9. The text says it is important for them to understand that passing along the message of A.A. is key to your own recovery, and actually they may be helping you more than you are helping them. How does telling a newcomer that they are helping you change the way they receive your message?
10. The chapter says make it clear that they are under no obligation to you and you should not be offended if they want to call it off. How does removing all pressure and obligation from the conversation create space for the newcomer to make their own decision?
11. The text says the more hopeless they feel, the better, because they will be more likely to follow your suggestions. How has your own experience of hopelessness made you more willing to accept help you once would have refused?
12. The chapter says be sure to talk about the spiritual aspect. When you first heard about the spiritual component of A.A., what made the difference between you shutting down and you staying open?
13. The text says explain how important it is that they place the well-being of other people ahead of their own. How do you explain selflessness to someone whose entire life has been driven by self-centeredness?
14. The chapter says if your talk has been sane, quiet, and full of human understanding, you may have made a friend. What does a sane, quiet, and understanding conversation about alcoholism look like compared to the desperate interventions most families attempt?

- 15.** The text says you should not be offended if they want to call it off. How do you protect your own ego when someone you are trying to help says no?

If the problem drinker resists A.A.

- 1.** The text says your new friend may give reasons why they don't need to complete all of the program, and they may rebel at the thought of doing a thorough inventory. How do you respond to someone who wants the solution but only on their own terms?
- 2.** The chapter says don't argue with them and tell them you once felt the same way. How does admitting you shared their resistance disarm a defensive person more effectively than arguing would?
- 3.** The text says give them a chance to think it over and if you do stay, let them steer the conversation. What is the value of letting the newcomer control the direction of the conversation instead of controlling it yourself?
- 4.** The chapter says you will be most successful with other alcoholics if you don't act pushy or judgmental. Where have you been pushy or judgmental with someone you were trying to help, and what was the result?
- 5.** The text says never talk down to an alcoholic from any moral or spiritual perspective—just lay out the kit of spiritual tools for them to look at and show them how the tools worked for you. What is the difference between laying out the tools and insisting someone pick them up?
- 6.** The chapter says if the person wants you to lend them money or act like a nurse during drinking sprees, you might even stop helping them and wait until they change their own mind. How do you distinguish between genuine willingness and someone who just wants you to make their drinking more comfortable?
- 7.** The text says if they are truly interested, ask them to read this book before your next meeting and then they must decide on their own. Why is it essential that the desire to connect with a Higher Power must come from within the newcomer rather than from your persuasion?
- 8.** The chapter says if the individual thinks they can stop drinking in some other way or prefers some other spiritual approach, encourage them to do what they think is best. How does this openness to other paths reflect the principles of A.A.?
- 9.** The text says don't be discouraged if your new friend doesn't join A.A. right away and find another alcoholic and try again. How do you handle the disappointment when someone you invested time in chooses not to follow the program?
- 10.** The chapter says it's a waste of time to keep chasing someone who cannot or will not work with you, because to spend too much time on one person means denying some other alcoholic the chance to live. How do you let go of someone who is not ready without feeling like you failed them?
- 11.** The text says one member failed completely with his first six problem drinkers and often says that if he had continued to work on them, he wouldn't have been able to help others who wanted to recover. What does this teach you about where to invest your energy?
- 12.** The chapter says if you leave such a person alone, they may soon realize they cannot recover by themselves. How has stepping back from someone actually moved them closer to asking for help?
- 13.** The text says they should not be pushed or prodded by you, their family, or their friends. What is the hardest part about watching someone you care about refuse the solution that saved your life?
- 14.** The chapter says offer them friendship and fellowship and tell them that if they want to get well you will do anything to help. How do you keep the door open for someone who has walked away without chasing them through it?

- 15.** The text says A.A. does not believe there is one right path to faith and we just have an approach that worked for us. How does holding your program loosely—without insisting it is the only way—make you more effective as a messenger?

The second conversation

- 1.** The text says your problem drinker has read the book and says they're ready to do all Twelve Steps. How do you gauge whether someone's eagerness is genuine willingness or just enthusiasm that will fade?
- 2.** The chapter says having had the experience yourself, you can give them lots of practical advice, but let them know you are ready to listen if they want to tell their story. What is the balance between giving advice and creating space for someone to find their own way?
- 3.** The text says your new friend may have financial problems and you might help them get a job or offer a little money, but you shouldn't put your own finances at risk. Where is the line between generous help and enabling?
- 4.** The chapter says you may want to let them into your home for a few days but be sure your family is comfortable and don't let them stay for too long. What criteria do you use to decide how much of your personal life to share with a newcomer?
- 5.** The text says be certain they are not taking advantage of you by asking for money, employment, or shelter, because if you let that happen you will be letting them act dishonestly. How do you spot the difference between someone who genuinely needs help and someone who is working you?
- 6.** The chapter says you may be helping their destruction rather than their recovery. Share a time when your help actually made it easier for someone to avoid doing the hard work.
- 7.** The text says helping others is the foundation of your recovery, and a kind act once in a while isn't enough—you have to be unselfish and helpful every day. How does daily helpfulness differ from occasional charity?
- 8.** The chapter describes losing sleep, sharing money, trips to police stations and hospitals, and a drunk smashing furniture in your home. What has Twelfth Step work actually cost you in terms of time, comfort, or convenience?
- 9.** The text says if you have tried to work with an alcoholic who doesn't join the program, keep in touch with their family and offer them your way of life. Why is it important to help the family even when the alcoholic refuses to get sober?
- 10.** The chapter says alcoholics who are able and willing to get well don't usually want a lot of charity, and those who beg for money and shelter before giving up alcohol are on the wrong track. How does this principle protect both you and the newcomer from a dishonest relationship?
- 11.** The text says it is not the act of giving that is in question but when and how to give, and that often makes the difference between failure and success. How has the timing of your help mattered as much as the help itself?
- 12.** The chapter says as soon as we think of our work as charity, everything changes—they will start to rely on us instead of connecting with their Higher Power. How do you help someone without creating dependency?
- 13.** The text says we rarely let people live in our homes for long because this would not be good for them and can be very difficult for our families. How do you protect your own household while still being available to those in crisis?
- 14.** The chapter says burn the idea into the mind of every such person that they can get well without anyone else's money or charity—the only condition is that they trust in God and clean house. What does this statement teach you about what an alcoholic truly needs versus what they say they need?

- 15.** The text says job or no job, spouse or no spouse, we just don't stop drinking when we rely on other people more than we rely on our own faith. How does this truth apply to your own recovery?

Marriage, spouse, and partner issues

- 1.** The text says many newcomers struggle with divorce, separation, or troubled relationships, and after making amends they can start following A.A.'s principles at home. How has applying program principles in your home changed the atmosphere there?
- 2.** The chapter says the newcomer must avoid arguing and blaming others even if their family is the cause of some of their problems. How difficult is it for you to focus on your own behavior when you believe your partner is also at fault?
- 3.** The text says if the newcomer uses A.A.'s principles at home for just a few months, they will see positive change. What positive change have you seen—or hope to see—in your family since you started working the program?
- 4.** The chapter says little by little, family members start to see their own defects and admit them. How has your recovery created space for other family members to look at their own behavior?
- 5.** The text says if a newcomer is going through divorce or separation, don't rush them to patch things up. Why is it important to let a relationship heal at its own pace rather than forcing reconciliation?
- 6.** The chapter says some alcoholics claim they cannot recover unless they get their family back, and this just isn't true. How has depending on a person rather than your Higher Power put your sobriety at risk?
- 7.** The text says recovery is not dependent on people but on your relationship with God, and we have seen people get well whose families have never come back. How does this statement change the way you think about your own recovery if your family situation is unresolved?
- 8.** The chapter says both you and your friend must walk along the path of spiritual progress, and remarkable things will happen when you don't give up. What remarkable thing has happened in your life since you committed to spiritual growth?
- 9.** The text says the things that happened when we put ourselves in God's hands were better than anything we could have planned. Share a time when letting go of your plan for a relationship led to a better outcome than you expected.
- 10.** The chapter says when working with a newcomer and their family, don't participate in their arguments because you may ruin your chance of being helpful. How does staying neutral between a newcomer and their family protect your ability to help?
- 11.** The text says make sure the family understands the alcoholic is very sick and should be treated like a sick person. How has your family's understanding of alcoholism as an illness changed the way they treat you?
- 12.** The chapter says point out that the newcomer's character defects can't disappear overnight and show the family that their loved one is entering a period of growth. What does the family need to understand about the pace of change in early recovery?
- 13.** The text says the story of how you and your spouse worked out your difficulties will be more helpful than any amount of criticism. How has sharing your own relationship struggles helped another couple in the program?
- 14.** The chapter says clearly the old ways weren't working, and both partners need to find new ways to act with each other. What old way of relating to your partner have you had to abandon in recovery?

- 15.** The text says let the alcoholic continue their program day by day, and if the time comes to repair a marriage both spouses will know. How are you practicing patience with your own relationship while trusting that the program will produce results?

Living in the world as an alcoholic

- 1.** The text says once we have accepted A.A.'s principles, we can do all kinds of things alcoholics are not supposed to do—people say we can't go where liquor is served or have it in our homes. How has your relationship with environments where alcohol is present changed since you got sober?
- 2.** The chapter says an alcoholic who cannot deal with situations involving alcohol every day still has an alcoholic mind and hasn't truly found their faith. How solid is your spiritual foundation when you are in a room where people are drinking?
- 3.** The text says any method of fighting alcoholism that protects the alcoholic from temptation will fail, because if the alcoholic tries to protect themselves it may work for a while but they usually end up on the biggest spree ever. How have your own attempts to avoid all contact with alcohol eventually backfired?
- 4.** The chapter says our rule is not to avoid places where there is drinking if we have a real reason for being there. How do you honestly evaluate your motives before going to a place where alcohol is present?
- 5.** The text says ask yourself: do I have any good social, business, or personal reason for going, or am I hoping to get some secondhand pleasure from watching other people drink? What does an honest answer to this question look like for you?
- 6.** The chapter says make sure you are on solid spiritual ground before you consider going and think of what you can bring to the situation rather than what you will get out of it. How do you prepare spiritually before entering an environment where drinking is happening?
- 7.** The text says if you feel shaky or unsure, work with another alcoholic instead of putting yourself at risk. What is your personal warning system that tells you it is not safe to be around alcohol today?
- 8.** The chapter says don't allow yourself to be grouchy or sullen in places where people are drinking, and don't sigh about the good old days. How do you handle the internal pull of nostalgia for your drinking days when you are around people enjoying alcohol?
- 9.** The text says while you were drinking you were withdrawing from life little by little, and now you are returning to the social life of the world—don't start to withdraw again just because your friends drink. How has your social life changed since getting sober, and are you engaging with the world or hiding from it?
- 10.** The chapter says your job now is to be as helpful as possible to others, and you can visit the most dirty, dangerous spot on earth if you go there to be helpful. What does it mean that motive determines safety—that going somewhere to help is different from going somewhere to be near alcohol?
- 11.** The text says many recovering alcoholics keep liquor in our homes to help newcomers through a severe hangover. How does your household handle the presence or absence of alcohol?
- 12.** The chapter says we are careful never to become intolerant about drinking in general because that attitude is not helpful to anyone. Where have you been tempted to judge other people's drinking, and how did you pull yourself back?
- 13.** The text says there isn't a drinker alive who likes to be told anything about alcohol by someone who hates it. How does approaching the world with tolerance rather than bitterness make you a more effective messenger?

- 14.** The chapter says we have stopped fighting anybody or anything, and we don't even fight alcohol—we just don't need it. What does it feel like when the fight is over and you simply don't need alcohol anymore?
- 15.** The text says someday we hope A.A. will help the public understand the seriousness of alcoholism, but we will never reach that goal with an attitude of bitterness. How are you representing recovery to the non-alcoholic world through the way you live your life?

Chapter 7 Closing Prompts

- 1.** Which section of this chapter challenged your understanding of what it means to help another alcoholic?
- 2.** How has reading about working with others changed the way you think about your own responsibility to carry the message?
- 3.** The chapter says working with other alcoholics works when everything else fails. Describe a time when being of service saved your sobriety when nothing else could.
- 4.** What is the hardest thing about watching someone refuse the help that you know could save their life?
- 5.** How has your approach to newcomers changed since you began working the Twelfth Step?
- 6.** The chapter describes situations involving money, shelter, and family arguments. What boundary have you had to set while helping another alcoholic?
- 7.** How has the principle of attraction rather than promotion shown up in your own Twelfth Step work?
- 8.** The chapter says if your talk has been sane, quiet, and full of human understanding, you may have made a friend. Describe a Twelfth Step conversation that felt like making a real friend.
- 9.** How has working with others helped you understand your own story more deeply than working on yourself alone ever could?
- 10.** The chapter says we have stopped fighting anybody or anything, even alcohol. How close are you to that place of peace?
- 11.** What part of this chapter would you share with a family member who is struggling with a loved one's drinking?
- 12.** How has your tolerance of other people's drinking—or their refusal to stop—grown since you entered the program?
- 13.** The chapter says recovery is not dependent on people but on your relationship with God. How has this truth been tested in your own life?
- 14.** What is the most important lesson about service that you are taking from this chapter?
- 15.** What is one specific action you will take this week to carry the message to someone who needs it?

Principles in This Chapter

- 1. Service:** The chapter says working with other alcoholics is the most effective way to keep from drinking. How were you of service to another person this week, and how did it affect your own sobriety?
- 2. Humility:** The text says never talk down to an alcoholic from any moral or spiritual perspective. How are you practicing humility when you share your experience with someone who is still suffering?
- 3. Patience:** The chapter says don't be discouraged if your new friend doesn't join A.A. right away and find another alcoholic and try again. How are you practicing patience with someone who is not yet ready?
- 4. Tolerance:** The text says we are careful never to become intolerant about drinking in general. How are you practicing tolerance toward people who drink normally without projecting your own disease onto them?
- 5. Honesty:** The chapter says tell the newcomer enough about your drinking to encourage them to talk about theirs. How honest are you willing to be about your own story when it serves another person's recovery?
- 6. Faith:** The text says recovery is not dependent on people but on your relationship with God. How is your faith sustaining your recovery independently of whether other people cooperate?
- 7. Selflessness:** The chapter says helping others is the foundation of your recovery and you have to be unselfish every day. Where are you still being selfish in your service work?
- 8. Courage:** The text says you can visit the most dirty, dangerous spot on earth if you go there to be helpful. What act of courage has your Twelfth Step work required from you?
- 9. Wisdom:** The chapter says it is not the act of giving that is in question but when and how to give. How are you developing wisdom about when to help and when to step back?
- 10. Generosity:** The text says you may lose many nights' sleep and share your money and your home. What has your generosity cost you, and how has that cost been repaid in ways you didn't expect?
- 11. Responsibility:** The chapter says to spend too much time on one person means denying another alcoholic the chance to live. How are you balancing your responsibility to help with the limits of your time and energy?
- 12. Acceptance:** The text says A.A. does not believe there is one right path to faith. How are you practicing acceptance of paths to recovery that are different from your own?
- 13. Compassion:** The chapter says think about standing in their shoes before you begin your conversation. How has compassion for another alcoholic's situation changed the way you carry the message?
- 14. Boundaries:** The text says be certain they are not taking advantage of you. How are you setting healthy boundaries in your service work without closing your heart?
- 15. Hope:** The chapter says we have stopped fighting and we just don't need alcohol anymore. How does the hope you carry into a conversation with a newcomer come from the peace you have found in your own recovery?

Putting It Into Practice

- 1.** Identify one person in your life or community who may be struggling with alcohol. This week, find a way to make yourself available to them without being pushy.
- 2.** Practice telling your story in three parts—what it was like, what happened, and what it is like now—in under ten minutes. Ask your sponsor to listen and give feedback.
- 3.** The next time you are at a meeting, look for the newest person in the room. Introduce yourself and ask them how they are doing.
- 4.** Review your own experience with the Twelfth Step. If you have not yet carried the message to another alcoholic, ask your sponsor to take you on a Twelfth Step call this month.
- 5.** Write down three situations where you have been around alcohol since getting sober. For each one, honestly assess your motive for being there and whether your spiritual foundation was solid.
- 6.** Identify one boundary you need to set in your service work—a limit on money, time, or emotional energy. Communicate it clearly to the person you are helping.
- 7.** Reach out to the family of an alcoholic you know who is still drinking. Offer them information about Al-Anon or simply let them know you understand what they are going through.
- 8.** Practice the principle of attraction this week by living your recovery visibly. Let someone notice your changed behavior without you having to explain it.
- 9.** If someone you have been helping refuses the program, write them a brief note telling them the door is always open. Then find another alcoholic who is ready.
- 10.** Before your next Twelfth Step conversation, spend ten minutes in prayer asking your Higher Power to speak through you and to remove any desire to lecture or control.
- 11.** Attend a meeting in an unfamiliar part of your community this week. Notice who is there and consider how you might be useful in a new setting.
- 12.** Review your daily life for areas where you are still withdrawing from the world because of your alcoholism. Choose one area to re-engage with this week.
- 13.** Ask a member of your group who has been sober longer than you to describe the most important lesson they learned from working with newcomers. Apply that lesson this week.
- 14.** If you are tempted to go somewhere alcohol is present this week, honestly answer the question the chapter asks: Do I have a good reason for being there, or am I hoping for secondhand pleasure?
- 15.** Make a commitment to do one act of Twelfth Step service this week that costs you something—time, comfort, or convenience—and notice how it affects your own recovery.

Chapter 8: To Partners

11 Sections • 165 Questions

To Partners

- 1.** The chapter says every person who drinks involves other people in their drinking. Who in your life has been drawn into the chaos of the drinking?
- 2.** The text says partners often fear the next drinking spree. Share a time when this fear dictated your behavior in the home.
- 3.** The chapter says parents see their child wasting away because of alcoholism. How has watching a loved one lose their health affected your own identity?
- 4.** The text says the choices of alcoholics affect everyone around them. What is the hardest consequence you have had to face because of someone else's drinking?
- 5.** The chapter says the Fellowship includes both people whose problem is solved and those who have not found a solution. Where do you stand between these two groups?
- 6.** The text says analyzing mistakes is part of this journey. Identify a behavior of yours that you now see was driven by the disease rather than by your own character.
- 7.** The chapter says no situation is too difficult to fix and no unhappiness is too great to overcome. Share about a part of your life that once felt completely hopeless.
- 8.** The text says we have traveled a rocky road. Describe the most difficult part of the path you have walked so far as a partner.
- 9.** The chapter says hurt pride and self-pity are unpleasant companions. How does self-pity show up in your internal dialogue when you are at your worst?
- 10.** The text says misunderstanding and fear are common experiences for partners. Describe a situation where fear stopped you from speaking the truth about the drinking.
- 11.** The chapter says some of us have been driven to maudlin sympathy or bitter resentment. How have you handled your own resentment this week?
- 12.** The text says some partners veered from extreme to extreme. Share how you have swung between being too helpful and too critical of the alcoholic.
- 13.** The chapter says loyalty can lead to all sorts of predicaments. How has your loyalty prevented you from taking necessary action for your own sanity?
- 14.** The text says unselfishness and self-sacrifice can be a trap. Describe a time your sacrifice was actually an attempt to control someone else's behavior.
- 15.** The chapter says telling lies to protect a reputation is a heavy burden. Share the internal cost of a specific lie you told to cover for your partner.

Unhappy homes

- 1.** The text says many nights our homes have become battlegrounds. Share a specific behavior you used during a battle to try and gain control of the situation.
- 2.** The chapter says in the morning we kiss and make up and the cycle continues. How did this pattern of reconciliation prevent you from finding a real solution?
- 3.** The text says friends often advise leaving the relationship. What fear brought you back after you had decided to leave with finality?
- 4.** The chapter says alcoholics often swear they are through drinking forever. Describe the impact of a broken oath on your ability to trust anyone's promises.
- 5.** The text says we believed them when no one else could or would. Share a time your faith in their promise led directly to a fresh outburst of drinking.
- 6.** The chapter says social engagements are difficult when you never know how or when the alcoholic will appear. How has this unpredictability limited your own life and friendships?
- 7.** The text says we came to live mostly alone even while sharing a home. Describe the loneliness you feel even in the presence of your partner.
- 8.** The chapter says sneaking drinks at a party can spoil the occasion for everyone. How did you react when a social event was ruined by alcohol?
- 9.** The text says sometimes their self-pity when sober makes them harder to handle than when they are drinking. Share a time their mood was more difficult than their drinking itself.
- 10.** The chapter says positions are in jeopardy and the checking account melts like snow. Describe a financial decision you made out of panic because of the drinking.
- 11.** The text says heartbreaking discoveries of affairs are common in alcoholic homes. How did you handle the pain of betrayal while also trying to heal from the alcoholism?
- 12.** The chapter says being called a joykiller or a nag is part of the survival mechanism partners develop. In what ways have you adopted these roles, and what did they cost you?
- 13.** The text says small children are often told the parent is sick rather than drunk. How do you balance being honest with your kids while protecting the alcoholic parent?
- 14.** The chapter says pandemonium in the home can lead to smashed dishes or kicked doors. How did you maintain your own peace during a physical crisis in the household?
- 15.** The text says getting tight yourself is a desperate move. What was the outcome of your attempt to drink with your partner or match their behavior?

Trying every option

- 1.** The text says seeking medical advice is a logical step for a desperate partner. Share what you hoped the doctor would do and what actually happened.
- 2.** The chapter says remorse and depression can settle like a dark cloud over the household. How has your partner's self-loathing affected your own mood and mental health?
- 3.** The text says health resorts and jails are part of many alcoholic stories. Describe how a stay in an institution changed your perspective on the disease.
- 4.** The chapter says death was often near for many alcoholics and their families. How did facing that reality change your willingness to try a spiritual path?
- 5.** The text says mistakes are often made out of ignorance about alcoholism. Share something you did that you now see was a misunderstanding of how the disease works.
- 6.** The chapter says seeing the problem as an illness changes everything. What was the turning point when you stopped seeing drinking as a moral choice and started seeing it as a sickness?
- 7.** The text says some people try moving to a new place to solve the problem. Why did changing your surroundings fail to produce a change in the home?
- 8.** The chapter says taking extra jobs to support the family is common when the alcoholic can't work. How did financial pressure impact your relationship with your Higher Power?
- 9.** The text describes the terror of watching someone scream in confusion during withdrawal. How did you maintain your own sanity during a medical or emotional crisis?
- 10.** The chapter says patience and good temper are first principles for dealing with an alcoholic. Identify a situation this week where you lacked both and describe the result.
- 11.** The text says friendly talks can be ruined by criticism of the alcoholic's behavior. Share an experience where your tone of voice stopped a productive conversation from happening.
- 12.** The chapter says leaving temporarily without rancor is difficult but sometimes necessary. How did you manage your internal anger during a period of separation?
- 13.** The text says setting your heart on reforming your partner is a habit most partners share. Where are you still trying to change their personality today instead of focusing on your own?
- 14.** The chapter says calamities can sometimes turn into blessings. Share a recent problem that forced your family to rely on a Higher Power instead of your own control.
- 15.** The text says powerlessness is the first step for partners as well as alcoholics. Describe a moment when you truly realized you could not fix the situation on your own.

Playing the blame game

- 1.** The text says partners can be unthinking or cruel in their reactions to the alcoholic's behavior. Describe your behavioral response the last time you felt mistreated by the drinking.
- 2.** The chapter says sweet intervals of promises to change can be a trap that keeps both people stuck. How did those hopeful moments keep you locked in a cycle of blame?
- 3.** The text says smashing love to pieces is painful for everyone involved. How have you used your own pain to justify your defects of character?
- 4.** The chapter says a giant wall can seem to surround the drinker, cutting them off from everyone. How have you tried to scale that wall through control or manipulation?
- 5.** The text says questioning their judgment and willpower only fuels resentment. How does focusing on their failures stop you from looking at your own?
- 6.** The chapter says seeing someone as sick rather than bad changes the nature of our anger. Share how this shift in perspective has affected your home life recently.
- 7.** The text says treating an alcoholic like a pneumonia patient is a high standard of compassion. What does that level of compassion look like in your house on a practical level?
- 8.** The chapter says anger is a natural reaction to the chaos of alcoholism. How do you pause to remember your partner is ill when they are being unreasonable?
- 9.** The text says some people truly do have bad intentions and you must protect yourself. Describe a hard boundary you had to set to protect yourself or your children.
- 10.** The chapter says using alcoholism as a weapon during an argument is tempting. Share a time you resisted this urge and describe the outcome.
- 11.** The text says no one should have their life ruined by another person's disease. How are you taking responsibility for your own joy and wellbeing today?
- 12.** The chapter says sickness can make someone act unloving even when they don't mean to. Share a time you realized a lack of affection was a symptom of the disease rather than a rejection of you.
- 13.** The text says live and let live is the rule for partners. In what area of your partner's life are you still trying to run the show?
- 14.** The chapter says pausing before responding to criticism is a spiritual tool. What did a recent pause prevent you from saying that would have made things worse?
- 15.** The text says capitalizing on mistakes leads to growth for both partners. What relationship error are you currently using as a lesson for the future instead of a weapon?

Four types of problems

- 1.** The text describes type one drinkers who think drinking is necessary for business or social success. How do you handle the frustration of a partner who stays in denial about the nature of their drinking?
- 2.** The chapter describes type two drinkers who want to want to stop but haven't crossed the line to action. Share how you have supported that desire without becoming a warden or a jailer.
- 3.** The text describes type three drinkers who cannot keep a job because of their alcoholism. How are you managing your fear of financial ruin during this time?
- 4.** The chapter describes type four situations involving violence or insanity. What difficult action have you had to take for the safety of your family?
- 5.** The text says spectacular recoveries happen even for the most lost cases. How does this promise help you stay patient during the darkest times?
- 6.** The chapter says cheerfully seeing someone through a drinking spree is a high standard. What does spiritual cheerfulness look like to you when everything around you is falling apart?
- 7.** The text says remorse after a binge is a sign of a real alcoholic rather than a casual drinker. How do you distinguish between a heavy drinker and one who is truly sick?
- 8.** The chapter says drinking on the way home from the hospital is a sign of hopelessness. How do you find strength when the situation looks completely impossible?
- 9.** The text says God's power goes deep into places willpower cannot reach. Share a change you have seen in your home that willpower alone could not have produced.
- 10.** The chapter says preparing to start life anew is sometimes necessary regardless of the alcoholic's choices. How are you building your own life independent of whether they get sober?
- 11.** The text says showing confidence in their power to stop is helpful but must be balanced with realism. How do you maintain confidence in the possibility of recovery while being honest about the illness?
- 12.** The chapter says avoid urging someone to follow the program. Describe a time your silence was more influential than your preaching.
- 13.** The text says Easy Does It is a helpful motto for partners. How are you applying it to your conversations about recovery this week?
- 14.** The chapter says letting someone decide for themselves is essential even when the waiting is unbearable. What was the internal cost of waiting for them to choose help on their own?
- 15.** The text says reliance on a Higher Power is the solution for partners as well as alcoholics. Which specific problem are you currently handing over to God instead of trying to manage yourself?

Talking about alcoholism with your partner

- 1.** The text says waiting for the subject of drinking to be brought up naturally takes discipline. Describe the last time you successfully waited for the right moment instead of forcing the conversation.
- 2.** The chapter says presenting the book as an opportunity for health rather than a judgment changes the reaction. How did you change your language to avoid sounding like a judge when you raised the topic?
- 3.** The text says putting yourself in their place changes your tone completely. How does seeing the illness through their eyes reduce your criticism of their behavior?
- 4.** The chapter says saying you are worried rather than angry can change the entire reaction. Describe a conversation where this shift in language actually worked.
- 5.** The text says drinkers like to help other drinkers, which is one reason A.A. works. How have you encouraged your partner's service work without managing it or controlling the details?
- 6.** The chapter says leaving a lukewarm partner alone is the suggested approach when they are not enthusiastic. Share a time your interference actually delayed their progress toward recovery.
- 7.** The text says faith is required when there is no outward change to point to. How are you practicing faith that the seed of recovery is growing even when you cannot see it?
- 8.** The chapter says dropping the subject when there is no interest takes courage. How did you handle the anxiety that followed when you stopped pushing?
- 9.** The text says understanding that the writers of this book have been through it themselves is helpful. How has reading the Big Book improved your communication with your partner about drinking?
- 10.** The chapter says cooperating with enthusiasm without policing their schedule is a difficult balance. Where are you still tempted to check up on them or monitor their meetings?
- 11.** The text says reminding them of recovery after a relapse causes anger rather than motivation. How do you handle your impulse to lecture during or after a slip?
- 12.** The chapter says outsiders are often more effective messengers than family members. How did you handle your ego when a stranger succeeded in reaching your partner where you could not?
- 13.** The text says spiritual cheerfulness during a drinking spree is one of the hardest things a partner can practice. What specific actions help you stay steady during those times?
- 14.** The chapter says handling shifting moods requires a solid spiritual foundation. Share how you stay grounded when your partner swings between enthusiasm for recovery and complete disinterest.
- 15.** The text says making yourself helpful without being a wet blanket is the goal. What specific act of service did you perform today that supported recovery without dampening anyone's spirit?

Finding your own spirituality

- 1.** The text says we often think we are nicer than the drinker. Share a time you realized your own character needed an overhaul as much as theirs did.
- 2.** The chapter says virtue alone is not enough to save a home from the damage of alcoholism. Describe the moment you realized you also needed a Higher Power, not just good behavior.
- 3.** The text says putting principles to work in every area of life is the goal. How are you applying honesty in your workplace or daily routine today?
- 4.** The chapter says lack of fear and worry is a wonderful thing that comes from spiritual connection. Share a specific worry that your Higher Power has removed from your life.
- 5.** The text says a connection to a Higher Power provides a new attitude toward your partner. How does your faith change the way you look at the alcoholic in your life?
- 6.** The chapter says supporting their spiritual path while cultivating your own requires balance. How are you avoiding being a spiritual judge of their progress?
- 7.** The text says mistakes made on a spiritual plane are lessons, not failures. Share a time you were holier than thou and how you corrected it.
- 8.** The chapter says new growth in character is like a sprouting seed. What new quality are you noticing in yourself this month that was not there before?
- 9.** The text says faith and sincerity will be put to the test by domestic crises. Describe a crisis where you chose prayer over panic.
- 10.** The chapter says viewing struggles as part of your education changes your entire perspective. Share a burden that you now see as a lesson rather than a punishment.
- 11.** The text says letting go of the picture of an ideal partner is necessary for peace. How are you accepting the real person in front of you instead of the one you imagined?
- 12.** The chapter says love and loyalty cannot cure the illness of alcoholism. How has accepting this realization helped you count your blessings instead of tallying your losses?
- 13.** The text says a radically changed attitude comes from God rather than from willpower. Describe a shift in your thinking that felt like a gift rather than something you manufactured.
- 14.** The chapter says prayer and meditation help avoid heated discussions. How has your morning routine changed the way your evenings unfold?
- 15.** The text says a better way of life will emerge for partners who work this program. What specific hope for your future are you holding onto right now?

Difficult feelings arise in the recovery process

- 1.** The text says resentment is a deadly force in the home even after sobriety begins. Identify a new resentment that has appeared since your partner got sober.
- 2.** The chapter says sober partners can sometimes act like sick children. How do you manage your reaction when the recovering alcoholic is being unreasonable about something small?
- 3.** The text says thunderclouds of anger can gather from tiny specks of irritation. Share a trivial issue that you allowed to become a major fight.
- 4.** The chapter says jealousy over time spent with other alcoholics is a common problem for partners. How do you balance your need for connection with their need for service and meetings?
- 5.** The text says a house filled with strangers from the program requires hospitality you may not feel. How are you practicing tolerance for the new people who have entered your life through recovery?
- 6.** The chapter says joining in their efforts makes life fuller for both partners. Share how working with other families in the program has helped your own recovery as a partner.
- 7.** The text says excess enthusiasm for the program will eventually tone down. How are you practicing patience with their current obsession with meetings, service, and recovery talk?
- 8.** The chapter says relapses can happen and are spiritual tests for everyone in the household. Share how you avoided blaming yourself or them after a slip.
- 9.** The text says fear and intolerance from the partner can lessen the alcoholic's chance of recovery. In what area are you still trying to guide or manage their appointments, meetings, or program work?
- 10.** The chapter says making them feel absolutely free to come and go is vital to their recovery. How do you handle your anxiety when they face temptation outside the home?
- 11.** The text says outcomes are in God's hands, not yours. How does accepting this fact help you let go of the need to control their sobriety?
- 12.** The chapter says being a judge or a lecturer causes damage to the relationship. Describe a time you made amends to the alcoholic for being too critical of their progress.
- 13.** The text says learning things the hard way provides supreme value that cannot be gained any other way. Share a painful lesson that you are now genuinely grateful for.
- 14.** The chapter says morbid reflection on the past can be a trap for partners. How are you shutting the door on old guilt and shame from the drinking years?
- 15.** The text says unexpected blessings are part of the recovery journey for families. Share a gift you have received in recovery that you never asked for and didn't expect.

Chapter 8 Closing Prompts

- 1.** Reflecting on the tornado that alcoholism brought through your home, what wreckage in your heart is still being cleared away?
- 2.** The chapter says normalcy is the goal of readjustment. How are you practicing being a partner rather than a hero or a victim?
- 3.** The text says all problems will not be solved at once. Which recurring issue are you currently facing with tolerance rather than frustration?
- 4.** The chapter says spiritual milestones come in many forms. Share a personal victory that has nothing to do with alcohol.
- 5.** The text says domestic crises are tests of sincerity. Describe a time you stayed calm while everyone else in the household was in a panic.
- 6.** The chapter says giving up the lead in the family show is a relief. How has your physical or emotional health improved since you stopped being the director?
- 7.** The text says material well-being follows spiritual progress. How are you prioritizing your character over your bank account?
- 8.** The chapter says serenity is possible in the middle of a storm. Share an experience of peace you had during a genuinely difficult day.
- 9.** The text says reconstruction takes seasons of hard work. What part of your home life are you actively rebuilding with love right now?
- 10.** The chapter says a substitute for the old social life is found in the fellowship. How has your circle of friends changed for the better since entering the program?
- 11.** The text says honoring their need to serve others is an act of love. Share a time you supported their service work at your own inconvenience.
- 12.** The chapter says joy comes from no longer fighting anyone or anything. Describe what neutrality or peace feels like in your relationship today.
- 13.** The text says tempering expectations is part of patience. How are you avoiding being disappointed by their personality defects?
- 14.** The chapter says future hopes should be grounded in God's hands. Share a dream for your family that you have surrendered to your Higher Power.
- 15.** The text says being a bright spot in the community is the goal. What specific action will you take today to help someone else?

Principles in This Chapter

- 1. Tolerance:** Share a time you tolerated a mood or habit in the alcoholic that used to trigger an argument, and describe what you did differently.
- 2. Patience:** Reconstruction of a family takes time that cannot be rushed. Share how you are practicing patience with a lingering financial or emotional issue.
- 3. Understanding:** How has understanding the physical allergy and mental obsession of alcoholism removed your judgment of their lack of willpower?
- 4. Love:** Love and tolerance is our code. Share how you are practicing love toward a difficult family member today.
- 5. Honesty:** Share a truth you told your partner this week that was uncomfortable but necessary for your own integrity.
- 6. Flexibility:** Describe a plan that changed recently and how your flexibility prevented a fight or a resentment.
- 7. Responsibility:** We are responsible for our own happiness regardless of what the alcoholic does. Share how you are taking ownership of your mood today.
- 8. Humility:** Share a time you asked for help from another partner in the fellowship when you were struggling rather than pretending everything was fine.
- 9. Forgiveness:** Share a past injury inflicted by the alcoholic that you have truly released through the process of spiritual deflation.
- 10. Unselfishness:** Giving rather than getting is the guiding principle. How did you put someone else's needs first today without expecting anything in return?
- 11. Faith:** Describe a moment of doubt where your faith in your Higher Power kept you from reacting impulsively to the alcoholic's behavior.
- 12. Hope:** Hearing stories of spectacular recoveries renews us. Share a story you heard this week that gave you hope for your own family.
- 13. Courage:** Share a difficult boundary you set with courage and love recently, and describe what it cost you and what it protected.
- 14. Service:** Helping other families mines the riches of our own painful past. Share how you were useful to another partner or family member this week.
- 15. Integrity:** Living these principles at home makes us better people in the world. How has your character at work or in your community changed because of what you practice at home?

Putting It Into Practice

- 1.** Clean house with the family this week. What specific wrong will you admit to a family member, and when will you do it?
- 2.** Commit to a morning meditation this week. Choose a time and place to sit in the quiet, and write down the prayer or intention you will bring.
- 3.** Yield here and there. Identify one domestic disagreement where you will compromise this week to promote harmony in the home.
- 4.** Develop a new channel of activity that is yours alone. What new interest or hobby will you start this month that has nothing to do with the alcoholic's recovery?
- 5.** Praise their progress today. Write down three things you will thank your partner for doing right, and tell them before the day is over.
- 6.** Practice a polite way to redirect a nosy person who asks about your partner's drinking. Rehearse the words so you are ready when it happens.
- 7.** Create a gratitude list for your home life tonight. Share it with your children or your partner at dinner.
- 8.** Identify one service commitment your partner has and support it this week without complaint, even if it inconveniences you.
- 9.** Practice the Easy Does It motto during a stressful moment at home this week. Notice what happens when you slow down instead of escalating.
- 10.** Make an appointment to address a health problem you have been neglecting because of the chaos of alcoholism. Your body matters too.
- 11.** Reach out to one other partner in the fellowship today to offer encouragement. A phone call or a text is enough.
- 12.** Apply one spiritual principle to a money issue this week. Choose honesty, patience, or faith and put it into practice with a specific financial decision.
- 13.** Schedule a family activity this week that involves no talk of recovery, alcoholism, or the program. Just be together.
- 14.** Do one act of anonymous service for a family still struggling with active addiction. Don't tell anyone you did it.
- 15.** Write down a worry on a piece of paper tonight. Read it once, fold it up, and let it go as an act of surrender to your Higher Power.

Chapter 9: The Family Afterward

10 Sections • 150 Questions

The Family Afterward

- 1.** The chapter says some partners of alcoholics have offered advice about how to treat a loved one who has stopped drinking, and the first rule is not to wrap them in cotton wool. Share a time you overprotected the recovering person and how it affected their growth.
- 2.** The text says all family members should meet on common ground and act with tolerance, understanding, and love. Where in your family is a power struggle still happening that needs to be resolved?
- 3.** The chapter says deflation is a process for everyone in the family, not just the alcoholic. Describe a fixed idea you have about how your family should treat you that may need to be challenged.
- 4.** The text says each person wants to play the lead in the family show. Share a specific instance where you tried to arrange the family to suit your own needs rather than the group's.
- 5.** The chapter asks if the family show is being run for your own satisfaction. How does your need for control create discord in the home?
- 6.** The text says alcoholism makes any partner or child neurotic to some extent. Identify a behavior of your own that needs emotional healing, separate from the alcoholic's recovery.
- 7.** The chapter says the entire family is ill to some extent. Share how you are taking responsibility for your own recovery path, independent of the alcoholic's progress.
- 8.** The text says not all days will be fair weather in early sobriety. Describe a stormy day in your home and how you maintained your serenity through it.
- 9.** The chapter says footsore and straggling members are normal in any family recovering from alcoholism. How do you practice patience when someone in the house is falling behind or struggling?
- 10.** The text says alluring shortcuts can lead us astray. What is an easier, softer way you have tried to take in your family life that didn't work?
- 11.** The chapter says obstacles can be converted to good use. Share a recent conflict in your home that actually led to a better understanding between family members.
- 12.** The text says families long for the return of happiness and security. How are you building internal security that doesn't depend on money or the alcoholic's behavior?
- 13.** The chapter says today is often measured against other years, and this comparison creates disappointment. Share how letting go of the past has improved your experience of the present.
- 14.** The text says demanding an instant return to the good old days is common. In what area of your family life are you being impatient with the speed of recovery?
- 15.** The chapter says God does not owe us a recompense on a long overdue account. How are you letting go of the feeling that you are owed something for your suffering?

Some common family reactions

- 1.** The text says the family feels more and more confident about the alcoholic's recovery until spectres from the past appear. Share a shameful memory that haunted you this week and how you handled it.
- 2.** The chapter says burying skeletons in a dark closet is a common impulse, but future happiness cannot be based on forgetfulness. How has bringing a secret into the light helped your family begin to heal?
- 3.** The text says experience is the thing of supreme value and your dark past is the key to life for others. How are you using your painful past to help other people rather than hiding from it?
- 4.** The chapter says each family that has experienced relief owes something to the families still suffering. Share an old error from your family's past that you have now converted into an asset for someone else.
- 5.** The text says your dark past is the key to life for others. Describe a time your honest story averted misery for another family or another person.
- 6.** The chapter says digging up past misdeeds can be a blight on the family's recovery. Share a time you used an old mistake as fuel during an argument instead of letting it rest.
- 7.** The text says miracles of reconciliation are at hand for families who practice spiritual principles. Describe a relationship in your family that has been healed through your work in recovery.
- 8.** The chapter says provocations can lead to unearthing old affairs and grievances. How are you protecting your new victory over hurt pride when old wounds get reopened?
- 9.** The text says past occurrences should not be discussed without a useful and constructive purpose. How do you determine when to speak about the past and when to be silent?
- 10.** The chapter says we keep few skeletons in our fellowship because everyone knows about each other's troubles. How does knowing other families share similar struggles help you feel less alone?
- 11.** The text says scandalous gossip is rare among A.A. families. Share how you temper your talk about other people's situations with love and tolerance rather than judgment.
- 12.** The chapter says relating intimate experiences requires the approval of the people involved. How are you respecting the privacy of your family members when sharing your story?
- 13.** The text says a person may laugh at themselves and affect others favorably. Share a story from your family's past that used to feel tragic but that you can now find humor in.
- 14.** The chapter says careless and inconsiderate remarks raise the devil in a recovering household. Describe a time you held your tongue to protect someone's feelings when you wanted to lash out.
- 15.** The text says outgrowing sensitivity takes a long time for everyone in the family. How are you managing your own reactions to the criticism of others?

Secrets and stressful times

- 1.** The text says alcoholics run to extremes, and at first the recovering person may throw themselves into work or service with intense passion. Share how your partner's new obsession with recovery or work has affected you personally.
- 2.** The chapter says the family must adjust to the recovering person's frantic attempt to get back on their feet. How are you adjusting your own life to their busy and sometimes overwhelming schedule?
- 3.** The text says the recovering person may be tired at night and preoccupied by day, leaving the family feeling neglected. Share how you handle the boredom or loneliness of a sober life at home.
- 4.** The chapter says complaining of inattention is a sign of entitlement that partners must examine. Describe a time you felt neglected and how you turned to your Higher Power instead of resentment.
- 5.** The text says resentment grows when there is no communication between partners. Share how you broke a silence in a kind way recently rather than letting it fester.
- 6.** The chapter says both father and the family can be mistaken in their expectations of each other. Share a time you admitted you were wrong about what you expected from the recovering person.
- 7.** The text says arguing will only make things worse during this delicate time. Identify a domestic issue where you chose peace over being right, and describe what it cost you.
- 8.** The chapter says be thankful they are sober and part of life again. Write down three things you genuinely admire about their current effort at recovery.
- 9.** The text says drinking did damage that takes time to repair in every area of life. How are you practicing patience with lingering legal, financial, or emotional problems?
- 10.** The chapter says tolerate their periods of crankiness or depression because these are part of early recovery. How do you stay serene when the mood in the house is low and heavy?
- 11.** The text says the alcoholic is mostly to blame for what happened at home. How has their honest admission of guilt helped you find the ability to forgive them?
- 12.** The chapter says avoid getting obsessed with money during this period. How are you keeping your focus on spiritual progress when the financial stress feels overwhelming?
- 13.** The text says material well-being follows spiritual progress. Share a time you put God first and saw the money situation improve, even slightly.
- 14.** The chapter says developing new channels of activity for yourself is essential. What are you doing right now to make your own life interesting and fulfilling, independent of the alcoholic?
- 15.** The text says stop demanding they stay home to make up for the past. How are you encouraging their service to others even when it takes them away from the household?

Avoiding resentment

- 1.** The text says family life has suffered more than anything else because of alcoholism. What specific action are you taking this week to fix the home environment?
- 2.** The chapter says fix things at home before making progress elsewhere. Share how you are prioritizing family harmony over other ambitions right now.
- 3.** The text says giving rather than getting is the guiding principle for the recovering family. Describe an act of selfless service you performed for your spouse or family member this week.
- 4.** The chapter says the recovering alcoholic may become a religious enthusiast. How are you handling the morning, noon, and night talk about spirituality without losing your patience?
- 5.** The text says avoid being jealous of God or of the time your partner spends on spiritual matters. Share how you are finding your own relationship with a Higher Power rather than resenting theirs.
- 6.** The chapter says their spiritual growth may be lopsided at first, heavy on enthusiasm and light on balance. How can you gently encourage a balance between their service work and their family responsibilities?
- 7.** The text says joy at our release from alcoholism knows no bounds. Share a moment of pure bliss your family has experienced since sobriety began.
- 8.** The chapter says riches must be given away to be kept. Share how your family is helping another family in need right now.
- 9.** The text says spiritual intoxication will pass with time. How are you practicing patience during this phase of their journey without dampening their enthusiasm?
- 10.** The chapter says a spiritual life that doesn't include the family is not perfect. How are you inviting the recovering person back into the home circle rather than letting them live entirely in the program?
- 11.** The text says be patient as they see they are taking beliefs too far. Share a time you waited for them to find their own balance rather than pointing out their excess.
- 12.** The chapter says understanding and sympathy help them grow. How are you showing support for their new way of living, even when it looks different from what you expected?
- 13.** The text says refocus on your own defects when you feel judgmental of theirs. What character flaw of your own did you work on today instead of cataloging theirs?
- 14.** The chapter says they say God will take care of everything, but practical responsibilities still exist. How do you balance their faith with the practical realities of running a household?
- 15.** The text asks are you still thinking they are losing their mind? Share how you are learning to trust the process of their change, even when their behavior seems extreme.

The risk of continued family criticism

- 1.** The text says criticism from the family can drive the recovering person further into themselves. Share a time your disapproval caused a visible barrier to rise between you.
- 2.** The chapter says they may act like a superior person with God on their side. How do you remain humble in the face of their spiritual pride?
- 3.** The text says let them have their head even if you disagree with their choices. Share a time you stepped back and allowed them to make their own decision, even though you thought it was wrong.
- 4.** The chapter says let them focus on helping others as much as they want. How does their service work give you more freedom in your own life?
- 5.** The text says sobriety is the most important thing in the household. How do you prioritize their staying sober over your own convenience or preferences?
- 6.** The chapter says their behavior may be worrying or annoying at times. Describe a specific habit of theirs that you are currently tolerating because the alternative is worse.
- 7.** The text says anything is better than a return to drinking. How does holding this perspective change your level of complaint about their imperfect recovery?
- 8.** The chapter says keep your head in the clouds but feet on the earth. Share a practical family duty you performed this week with a spiritual attitude rather than resentment.
- 9.** The text says be practically useful in the home. What is one way you are contributing to the household work today that demonstrates your own recovery?
- 10.** The chapter says a sane spiritual program is the best help you can offer. Describe your own daily spiritual routine and how it supports the family.
- 11.** The text says the partner who ran the family during the drinking years may struggle to share leadership. Share the difficulty of giving back some control to the person who was once unreliable.
- 12.** The chapter says clashes of roles mean trouble for everyone. Describe a friendly agreement you reached with the recovering person about household authority or responsibilities.
- 13.** The text says stop acting like you hold a mortgage on them because of what they put you through. How are you releasing them from the debt of the past?
- 14.** The chapter says equity in the relationship must be rebuilt from the ground up. What specific action are you taking to earn their trust, and what action are they taking to earn yours?
- 15.** The text says new acquaintances who know nothing of alcoholism are helpful for the family. Share a social activity you have done as a family recently with people outside the program.

Staying flexible

- 1.** The text says bodies burned by alcohol do not recover overnight. Share how you are being patient with the recovering person's physical health and energy level.
- 2.** The chapter says spiritual living is a powerful health restorative. Describe a physical change you have observed in your partner since they got sober.
- 3.** The text says cooperate with fine doctors and psychiatrists. How are you using professional help to support your family's health alongside the spiritual program?
- 4.** The chapter says re-establishing relations with children is hard and takes time. Share a specific moment of connection between the recovering parent and a child that gave you hope.
- 5.** The text says hardness and cynicism in children takes time to heal. How are you encouraging your kids to forgive and trust again without forcing it?
- 6.** The chapter says morning meditation and daily discussion are suggested for the whole family. Describe your family's attempt to pray, meditate, or talk together and how it is going.
- 7.** The text says seeing is believing for most families. How are your actions proving your recovery more than your words ever could?
- 8.** The chapter says don't nag about small commodities like coffee or cigarettes. Share a time your nagging about a minor issue backfired and created unnecessary conflict.
- 9.** The text says prioritize serious problems over small ones. How are you choosing your battles in the home today rather than fighting over everything?
- 10.** The chapter says changes in physical intimacy are common during recovery. Share how you have navigated this sensitive area with honesty and patience.
- 11.** The text says some couples are less interested in physical intimacy for a time. How are you managing this phase without taking it personally or creating resentment?
- 12.** The chapter says children may find it hard to forget what happened during the drinking years. What spiritual tool are you using to help them release their anger or fear?
- 13.** The text says rapid progress follows a genuine reunion of hearts. Describe a time your family felt truly united, even if it was brief.
- 14.** The chapter says the alcoholic must become spiritual to survive. How does their necessity for faith inspire your own spiritual development?
- 15.** The text says practice the mottoes to stay flexible. Which motto—Easy Does It, First Things First, or Live and Let Live—are you using most often right now, and how is it working?

Finding joy in recovery

- 1.** The text says we absolutely insist on enjoying life. Share a fun experience your family has had since sobriety began.
- 2.** The chapter says newcomers should see joy in the program or they won't want it. How are you demonstrating happiness and recovery to people who are watching your family?
- 3.** The text says cynicism is not helpful for usefulness to others. Share a time you caught yourself being negative about recovery and how you shifted your attitude.
- 4.** The chapter says cheerfulness and laughter are essential to a recovering household. Share a story from your past that used to feel tragic but that your family can now laugh about together.
- 5.** The text says avoid the deliberate manufacture of misery. Describe a dramatic habit from your drinking days that you have given up in sobriety.
- 6.** The chapter says problems are opportunities to show God's power in our lives. Share a current challenge that you are using as a lesson rather than a reason to despair.
- 7.** The text says God wants us to be happy, joyous, and free. How are you pursuing joy as a spiritual obligation rather than waiting for it to arrive on its own?
- 8.** The chapter says we are not a glum lot. Describe the humor that has returned to your family dinner table or your daily routine.
- 9.** The text says let each family member play together or separately. How are you balancing your own hobbies and interests with time spent together as a family?
- 10.** The chapter says simple pleasures bring great joy and cost nothing. Share a small moment of happiness from your day that had nothing to do with money or achievement.
- 11.** The text says no longer living in a vale of tears is a relief for the whole family. What is the brightest part of your day now compared to the darkest part of your day during active alcoholism?
- 12.** The chapter says we made our own misery in the past. How does taking responsibility for your own mood and attitude make you feel more free today?
- 13.** The text says merriment with outsiders is possible for the recovering family. Share a social experience where you felt comfortable and genuinely happy as a sober person or as the partner of one.
- 14.** The chapter says recovering alcoholics can offer first aid to other families in crisis. Share the joy you felt helping a family that is still sinking.
- 15.** The text says life is worth living. What act of joy will you perform today to demonstrate this truth to yourself and to others?

Chapter 9 Closing Prompts

- 1.** Reflecting on the tornado of the past, what wreckage are you most relieved to have cleared away?
- 2.** Which common family reaction like jealousy, entitlement, or the desire to control is your biggest hurdle today?
- 3.** How has giving up the lead in the family show changed your stress levels and your physical health?
- 4.** Share a spiritual milestone your family has reached together that you never thought was possible.
- 5.** The text says sickness of the entire family is a reality. Share a defect you caught from the years of living with alcoholism that is now beginning to heal.
- 6.** Describe the new version of the recovering person in your home and the quality of theirs you admire most.
- 7.** How has your attitude toward money transformed since entering recovery as a family?
- 8.** How do you protect your serenity when your partner is having a difficult or cranky day?
- 9.** Share a lesson you learned from a failure in your family's readjustment process that you could not have learned any other way.
- 10.** The text says reconstruction takes seasons of hard work. What part of the family house are you working on rebuilding this month?
- 11.** How has the fellowship given you a substitute for the social life you lost to alcohol?
- 12.** How are you honoring your partner's need to help others without feeling like you come in second?
- 13.** Describe the peace that comes from no longer fighting anyone or anything in your home.
- 14.** Share a blessing you have received in recovery that was completely unexpected.
- 15.** What is the next right action for your family as you move forward into the future together?

Principles in This Chapter

- 1. Tolerance:** Share a time you tolerated a habit or mood in a family member that used to trigger a fit of anger, and describe what you did differently.
- 2. Patience:** Reconstruction of a family takes time. Share how you are practicing patience with a money issue or an emotional wound that has not yet healed.
- 3. Understanding:** How has understanding the physical allergy and mental obsession of alcoholism removed your judgment of the recovering person's character?
- 4. Love:** Love and tolerance is our code. Share how you are practicing love toward a difficult relative today, even when it is not easy.
- 5. Honesty:** Share a truth you told your family this week that was uncomfortable but necessary for your integrity and theirs.
- 6. Flexibility:** Describe a plan that was ruined recently and how your flexibility prevented a family feud or a resentment.
- 7. Responsibility:** We are responsible for our own happiness. Share how you are taking ownership of your mood and your life today rather than blaming the alcoholic.
- 8. Humility:** Share a time you asked for help from a family member or a friend in the fellowship when you were struggling rather than pretending everything was fine.
- 9. Forgiveness:** Share a past hurt inflicted during the drinking years that you have truly released through the spiritual process of deflation.
- 10. Unselfishness:** Giving rather than getting is the rule for recovering families. How did you put the family's needs first today without keeping score?
- 11. Faith:** Describe a moment of doubt where your faith in God kept you from reacting impulsively to a family situation.
- 12. Hope:** Hearing stories of spectacular recoveries renews us. Share a story you heard this week that gave you hope for your own family.
- 13. Courage:** Share a difficult conversation you had with a family member this week that required courage instead of avoidance.
- 14. Service:** Helping other families mines the riches of our past. Share how you were useful to another family or another person in the fellowship this week.
- 15. Integrity:** Living these principles at home makes us better people in the world. How has the way you behave at home changed the way you are perceived at work or in your community?

Putting It Into Practice

- 1.** Clean house with the family this week. What specific action will you take to admit a wrong to a family member?
- 2.** Commit to a morning meditation this week. Choose a time and place to sit in the quiet with your family or on your own.
- 3.** Yield here and there. Identify one domestic issue where you will compromise this week to promote harmony.
- 4.** Develop a new channel of activity. What new hobby or interest will you start this month to build your own life?
- 5.** Praise their progress. Write down three things you will thank your partner for doing right this week and tell them.
- 6.** Practice a polite way to tell nosy people to ask your partner directly about their status instead of answering for them.
- 7.** Create a gratitude list for your family and share it at dinner tonight.
- 8.** Identify one service commitment the recovering person has and support it this week without complaint.
- 9.** Practice the Easy Does It motto during a stressful domestic moment this week and notice what happens when you slow down.
- 10.** Make an appointment to address a health issue you have been neglecting during the chaos of alcoholism. Take care of yourself.
- 11.** Reach out to one other partner or family member in the fellowship today to offer support or encouragement.
- 12.** Identify one spiritual principle and apply it to your work or volunteer life this week as a concrete experiment.
- 13.** Schedule a family fun night this week that involves no talk of alcoholism, recovery, or the program. Just be together.
- 14.** Do one act of service for a family still struggling with active addiction. Make it anonymous if possible.
- 15.** Write down a worry on paper tonight. Read it once, fold it up, and place it in God's hands as an act of surrender.

Chapter 10: To Employers

9 Sections • 135 Questions

To Employers

- 1.** The chapter opens with a manager describing three exceptional men he lost to alcoholism because he didn't understand the disease. Share about a colleague or employee you watched deteriorate because of drinking before anyone knew how to help.
- 2.** The text says the author describes three talented men who ended their own lives. How has witnessing the terminal nature of alcoholism changed your professional perspective on how you treat employees who drink?
- 3.** The chapter says downfall in business costs thousands of dollars in lost training and talent. What financial impact have you observed in your own workplace because of a drinking problem?
- 4.** The text says better understanding all around is the proposed solution for the business world. Where do you see a lack of understanding about alcoholism currently causing waste in your organization?
- 5.** The chapter says modern employers often feel a moral responsibility for their workers' well-being. How are you balancing this responsibility with the practical needs of running your business?
- 6.** The text says alcoholics may seem like fools of the first magnitude to those in charge. When have you allowed your frustration with an employee to cloud your judgment about their potential?
- 7.** The chapter says talented employees are sometimes kept on far beyond a reasonable period because of personal attachment. Describe a time your personal connection to a drinker prevented you from taking necessary action.
- 8.** The text says the author admits he became an alcoholic himself. How has your own experience with alcohol—whether as a drinker or as a witness—shaped the way you manage people?
- 9.** The chapter says managers often fire the very people they could help. Share a time you realized your policy was actually hindering someone's chance at recovery rather than supporting it.
- 10.** The text says exceptional organizers and brilliant thinkers are frequently the ones most affected by alcoholism. Why do you think high-performers are often able to hide their illness for so long?
- 11.** The chapter says firing a drinker without offering a solution can lead to tragic outcomes. What steps are you now taking to ensure that termination includes a path toward help?
- 12.** The text says the business community loses massive amounts of money because of a lack of understanding about alcoholism. Identify a specific department or project that has suffered from this kind of ignorance.
- 13.** The chapter says understanding alcoholism as an illness is a relatively new concept in business. What resistance do you still feel toward treating drinking like any other medical condition?
- 14.** The text says a caring person stepped in to save the author's life when no one else would. Who in your professional circle is currently in a position to be that caring influence for someone struggling?
- 15.** The chapter says waste goes on unabated when we ignore the reality of the disease. What is one specific area of your company's culture that needs to change to stop this waste?

Alcoholic employees frustrate their managers

- 1.** The text says managers often see alcoholics as weak or stupid rather than sick. Share a time you felt a colleague was simply lacking discipline when they were actually ill.
- 2.** The chapter says the board of directors often gives a last chance that ends in failure. Why do you think threats of firing rarely work as a long-term solution for an alcoholic employee?
- 3.** The text describes a bank executive who was fine one day and fired the next. Describe the sudden shift you have seen in an employee's performance when their drinking intensified.
- 4.** The chapter says managers may believe a three-month leave of absence is enough to solve the problem. How has relying on short-term fixes failed your organization in the past?
- 5.** The text says the author wanted to throw up his hands in discouragement when he couldn't help a friend understand. Where are you currently facing a wall of misunderstanding in your leadership team about alcoholism?
- 6.** The chapter says following the patterns of the disease is inevitable for an untreated alcoholic. How are you using knowledge of these patterns to predict and prevent workplace crises?
- 7.** The text says lack of knowledge about how to salvage sick employees is a major professional hurdle. What specific information do you still need to feel confident in helping an alcoholic staff member?
- 8.** The chapter says willpower and guts are often cited as the cure for drinking. Why is it dangerous to assume an employee can just make themselves stop without help?
- 9.** The text says it took being fired for the manager in the story to finally accept help himself. Describe a situation where you had to let someone hit bottom before they were willing to change.
- 10.** The chapter says many managers cannot believe that a successful executive is battling a serious illness. How does an employee's high status in your company make it harder to address their drinking?
- 11.** The text says professional success often masks the symptoms of alcoholism for years. What are the early warning signs you are now trained to look for in your staff?
- 12.** The chapter says frustration arises when we expect a sick person to act like a healthy one. How are you managing your own expectations of an employee currently in early recovery?
- 13.** The text says the business fabric is damaged by the loss of trained executives to addiction. What is the long-term cost to your industry when talented leaders are pushed out rather than helped?
- 14.** The chapter says salvaging an employee is described as a profitable move for a business. Share a time you invested in a person's recovery and saw a return in their loyalty and productivity.
- 15.** The text says better understanding all around creates a healthier workplace. What is one way you can educate your peers about the reality of alcoholism in the workplace?

Managers may have strong opinions

- 1.** The text says personal drinking habits can create strong prejudices against alcoholics. How does your own use of alcohol influence your judgment of those who cannot control theirs?
- 2.** The chapter says moderate drinkers sometimes get more annoyed with alcoholics than people who don't drink at all. When have you felt frustrated that anyone could have a problem with something you handle easily?
- 3.** The text says being able to shake off a hangover and go to work is a luxury of the non-alcoholic. Why is it unfair to measure an alcoholic's performance by your own physical resilience?
- 4.** The chapter says discarding the feeling that you are dealing with stubbornness is a difficult leadership task. Where in your heart are you still holding onto the idea that drinking is just a bad habit rather than an illness?
- 5.** The text says crooked thinking is a direct result of alcohol's action on the brain, and the alcoholic's behavior is driven by physical and mental changes. How has understanding the biology of the disease changed your reaction to an employee's lies or excuses?
- 6.** The chapter says the alcoholic's brain makes them irrational during and after a spree. How does this medical reality help you stay calm when a worker acts in a bizarre or disrespectful way?
- 7.** The text says concealing scrapes and messy mistakes is part of the disease pattern. Share a time you discovered an employee was hiding a serious error driven by their drinking.
- 8.** The chapter says revulsion and shame are what an alcoholic feels after a spree. How can you use an employee's own guilt as a starting point for a conversation about help rather than punishment?
- 9.** The text says normal drinkers cannot understand the chaos an alcoholic feels inside. Describe the mental gap between you and a struggling worker and how you are trying to bridge it.
- 10.** The chapter says some employees will try to take advantage of a manager's kindness. How are you setting firm boundaries while still maintaining a genuinely helpful attitude?
- 11.** The text says discharging a person who does not want to stop drinking is sometimes a blessing for everyone involved. Why is it vital to be honest about whether an employee is actually willing to take the necessary steps?
- 12.** The chapter says willpower is never enough for the true alcoholic. How has this realization changed the way you write employee performance reviews or evaluate underperformance?
- 13.** The text says high-performers who are likable often get away with more than others. In what ways have you been inconsistent in how you handle drinking problems among different staff members?
- 14.** The chapter says humanitarian reasons and business logic both support helping employees recover. Which of these motivations drives your current approach to addiction in the workplace?
- 15.** The text says forgiving past absurdities is necessary for a fresh start. What old grievance against a colleague are you now willing to let go of in the spirit of the program?

How to talk with an alcoholic employee

- 1.** The text says firmness about the drinking must be combined with an appreciation for the person's abilities. How do you plan to deliver this balanced message in your next conversation with a struggling employee?
- 2.** The chapter says assuring an employee that you do not intend to lecture or judge is a powerful way to open the conversation. How can you adjust your tone to ensure they feel safe enough to be honest?
- 3.** The text says admitting you misunderstood the problem in the past can build trust. Share how you would apologize for a previous harsh reaction to an employee's drinking.
- 4.** The chapter says asking if a fatal illness makes them want to get well is a serious question that needs to be asked directly. Why is it important to probe whether the employee actually wants to quit forever, not just avoid consequences?
- 5.** The text says probing for self-deception helps determine if the worker is serious about recovery. How do you distinguish between a genuine desire to change and a promise made under pressure?
- 6.** The chapter says mentioning the Big Book is a matter for your discretion. How will you decide if a specific employee is ready to hear about the spiritual side of recovery?
- 7.** The text says firing someone after the next drinking episode should be an explicit agreement made in advance. Why is it important to have clear, stated consequences for a relapse rather than vague threats?
- 8.** The chapter says medical treatment is often necessary for a person just finishing a spree. What resources does your company currently offer for the physical detox process?
- 9.** The text says deducting the cost of treatment from pay helps the employee feel responsible for their own recovery. How does financial accountability support a person's dignity?
- 10.** The chapter says a change of heart is more important than physical treatment alone. How will you encourage an employee to seek a deeper transformation of their thinking and attitude?
- 11.** The text says placing recovery above everything else is a requirement for success. What workplace adjustments are you willing to make to support an employee's attendance at meetings or treatment?
- 12.** The chapter says confidence in their ability to recover can be a life-saving gift from a manager. How are you demonstrating your belief in an employee's potential for a total turnaround?
- 13.** The text says keeping the employee's alcoholism strictly confidential is a matter of professional integrity. How are you ensuring that their recovery status remains private within the organization?
- 14.** The chapter says having a long chat upon their return from treatment helps set the stage for success. What is the first question you want to ask a worker who is coming back to the office sober?
- 15.** The text says results matter more than the specific methods used to get sober. How are you keeping your focus on the goal of a sober, productive employee rather than judging the path they take to get there?

Ways to help

- 1.** The text says reading the Big Book while acutely depressed can bring a person to their senses. How can you facilitate an employee's access to recovery literature during their lowest moments?
- 2.** The chapter says allowing the worker to decide for themselves is a cornerstone of the process. How are you resisting the urge to manage their recovery for them?
- 3.** The text says betting on a changed attitude and this book is a leadership risk worth taking. Share the fears you have about an employee failing after you have invested in their help.
- 4.** The chapter says personal contact with recovered alcoholics is the most effective way to help. How can you connect a struggling worker with a member of the Fellowship in your community?
- 5.** The text says a fast start is possible when a manager is willing to listen without being upset. How are you preparing yourself to hear shocking or uncomfortable truths from an employee about their drinking?
- 6.** The chapter says recovering alcoholics must be rigorously honest about past wrongs, including workplace dishonesty. How will you react if a worker admits to padding an expense account or stealing?
- 7.** The text says starting fresh means charging off past mistakes like a bad account. What specific professional error are you now ready to forgive and forget?
- 8.** The chapter says office politics can be used to pull a recovering person down. How are you protecting a recovering employee from malicious jokes or gossip about their past?
- 9.** The text says billboarding information about a hospital stay ruins a person's chance at recovery in the workplace. What specific protocols do you have in place to protect medical privacy?
- 10.** The chapter says defending a person from unfair criticism is a key duty of a supportive manager. Describe a time you stood up for a worker who was being judged for their recovery.
- 11.** The text says energetic people in recovery often work too hard to make up for lost time. How will you help an employee find a balance between work and the rest and play they need?
- 12.** The chapter says service work for other alcoholics is necessary to maintain sobriety. How much latitude are you willing to give a worker to do A.A. tasks during business hours?
- 13.** The text says overdoing work can lead to burnout or relapse. How are you monitoring the stress levels of staff members who are in early sobriety?
- 14.** The chapter says a recovered employee can produce as much as five normal workers. How does this potential increase in productivity justify the extra attention and patience you are giving?
- 15.** The text says helping someone straighten out their life brings genuine enjoyment to a manager. Share a moment of professional satisfaction you felt when a colleague succeeded in their recovery.

The importance of trust and honesty

- 1.** The text says recovered employees can be uniquely helpful with other workers who are giving you trouble. How are you leveraging the experience of sober staff members to improve your company culture?
- 2.** The chapter says a person on a radically different basis of life will not take advantage of your trust. Describe the shift you have seen in an employee's integrity after they found the program.
- 3.** The text says long experience with excuses can make a manager permanently suspicious. How are you practicing faith in an employee's word even when your instinct is to doubt them?
- 4.** The chapter says honest employees will tell you the truth even if it means losing their job. Why is this level of transparency more valuable to you than a worker who hides their slips?
- 5.** The text says avoid the urge to run a person's life or shield them from temptation during work travel. How are you trusting the employee to handle business situations involving alcohol without your supervision?
- 6.** The chapter says deciding whether to give a person another chance after a stumble is a heavy choice. What criteria will you use to determine if an employee is genuinely doing their utmost?
- 7.** The text says your obligation to help is discharged once you have provided the opportunity. How do you find peace in the decision to let an employee go when they refuse the solution?
- 8.** The chapter says providing managers with the Big Book can prevent them from being misled by empty promises. How are you educating your junior leadership about the reality of the alcoholic mind?
- 9.** The text says covering for a friend who drinks puts your own position at risk. Share a time you realized your loyalty to a coworker was actually enabling their destruction.
- 10.** The chapter says telling a worker they must resign if they will not stop is a fair and square position. How does this clarity benefit both the company and the individual?
- 11.** The text says no further reason for covering up exists once the solution has been offered. How has this book given your management team the courage to be direct and honest?
- 12.** The chapter says rehabilitating good men and women is a primary goal of this approach. Describe a person in your organization whose talent you are determined to save from alcoholism.
- 13.** The text says alcoholism is a serious leak in any company's resources. Where in your budget or operations do you see the most significant damage from untreated drinking?
- 14.** The chapter says managing casual heavy drinkers is different from managing true alcoholics. How are you teaching your staff to distinguish between the two types of employees?
- 15.** The text says a worker saved from a living death becomes a fiercely loyal asset. What specific act of loyalty have you received from a person you helped through recovery?

Chapter 10 Closing Prompts

- 1.** Reflecting on the colleagues lost to alcoholism in your past, what is the most important lesson you would tell your younger self about leadership?
- 2.** Which section of this chapter challenged your professional assumptions about alcoholism the most?
- 3.** How has your view of an employer's moral responsibility toward employees evolved after reading this text?
- 4.** In what ways has your own relationship with alcohol affected your ability to manage others fairly?
- 5.** Describe the most difficult conversation you expect to have with an employee regarding their drinking.
- 6.** What is the greatest fear you have about implementing these suggestions in your workplace?
- 7.** How will you measure the success of your efforts to help alcoholic employees in your organization?
- 8.** Share a moment of pride you felt when your company chose a person's health over their immediate productivity.
- 9.** What character flaw in your own management style is currently a barrier to helping your staff get well?
- 10.** How are you practicing the principle of anonymity and confidentiality within your professional circles?
- 11.** Describe the difference between a heavy drinker and a true alcoholic in terms of their impact on your business.
- 12.** What specific change in your company's policy would most effectively support the recovery process?
- 13.** How has this chapter changed your definition of what makes an employee truly loyal?
- 14.** Share a hope you have for the future of your workplace culture regarding alcoholism and recovery.
- 15.** What is the next right action you will take to address a potential drinking problem in your department?

Principles in This Chapter

- 1. Tolerance:** Share a time you practiced patience with an employee's erratic behavior while they were seeking help for their drinking.
- 2. Understanding:** How has seeing alcoholism as a brain disease changed your reaction to workplace dishonesty or underperformance?
- 3. Forgiveness:** Describe an instance where you charged off a worker's past mistakes and allowed them to start fresh.
- 4. Integrity:** How are you maintaining the confidentiality of a staff member's recovery journey in a professional setting?
- 5. Firmness:** Share a time you held an employee accountable for their sobriety while still being compassionate about their illness.
- 6. Responsibility:** How are you encouraging your employees to take full ownership of their treatment and its costs?
- 7. Trust:** Describe the effort it takes to stop being suspicious of a worker who has lied to you in the past because of their drinking.
- 8. Humility:** Share a time you admitted to a subordinate that you had misunderstood their situation or judged them unfairly.
- 9. Loyalty:** How has supporting an employee through a recovery crisis built a deeper bond between them and the company?
- 10. Fairness:** In what way are you ensuring that all employees with drinking problems receive the same level of consideration and help?
- 11. Cooperation:** How are you working with medical professionals to ensure the best outcome for your recovering staff?
- 12. Discernment:** Share how you distinguish between an employee who genuinely wants to stop drinking and one who is just making promises to keep their job.
- 13. Courage:** Describe the difficulty of telling a talented person they must resign if they continue to drink.
- 14. Service:** How is your organization contributing to the wider community by salvaging alcoholic lives rather than discarding them?
- 15. Hope:** Share a story of a spectacular workplace recovery that changed your mind about what is possible for a person with this disease.

Putting It Into Practice

- 1.** Audit your workplace culture this week. Identify one aspect of your environment that might be enabling a drinker or making it harder for someone to seek help.
- 2.** Prepare your message. Write out the specific points you would use to talk to an employee about their drinking without judging them.
- 3.** Review your company's confidentiality protocols regarding employee health information today. Are they strong enough to protect someone in recovery?
- 4.** Calculate the potential financial cost of alcoholism in your specific department over the last year. Put a number on what the disease has cost your business.
- 5.** Buy a copy of the Big Book and keep it in your office as a resource for future conversations with employees who need help.
- 6.** Reach out to a local A.A. group to find a contact person who can serve as a workplace referral when an employee is ready for help.
- 7.** Practice the Easy Does It motto the next time you feel frustrated with an employee's slow progress in recovery.
- 8.** Schedule a conversation with a worker who has recently returned from treatment. Ask how they are doing and what support they need.
- 9.** List three assumptions you have about alcoholics and challenge each one with facts from this chapter and from your own experience.
- 10.** Communicate clearly to your staff that while you support recovery, drinking on the job is a hard line that will not be crossed.
- 11.** Suggest a team-building activity this month that does not involve any alcohol.
- 12.** Ask a recovered staff member if they would be willing to serve as a mentor for someone currently struggling with drinking.
- 13.** If a worker stumbles and drinks again, sit down with them to determine if they are still truly willing to recover before making a decision about their employment.
- 14.** Share a success story from this chapter at your next management meeting to encourage a more helpful and informed policy.
- 15.** Identify one employee's recovery process that you are currently trying to micro-manage and make a conscious decision to step back and trust the process.

Chapter 11: A Vision for You

9 Sections • 135 Questions

A Vision for You

- 1.** The chapter says for most normal people drinking means fun, friendship, and carefree enjoyment, but alcoholics in the final days of heavy drinking don't feel this way at all. Share what the loss of those early pleasures feels like as drinking stops working.
- 2.** The text says any pleasure we used to take in drinking is gone, and good times are just memories. Describe the moment you realized you were a denizen of a mad realm where joyful drinking was no longer possible.
- 3.** The chapter says we are convinced that a miracle might happen and we might suddenly have control, and that is one reason we keep trying and failing. When did you first notice that your drinking had become a heartbreaking obsession with recapturing something that no longer existed?
- 4.** The text names the Four Horsemen of Alcoholism as Terror, Bewilderment, Frustration, and Despair. Which of these is most present in your life when you consider picking up a drink?
- 5.** The chapter says as people became more disappointed with us, we spent more time alone and withdrew from society. How has your world shrunk as a result of your alcoholism?
- 6.** The text says some of us visited dirty and dangerous places as we searched for people who would understand and accept us. Describe a place you went or a situation you entered just to feel understood or accepted as a drinker.
- 7.** The chapter says when we woke up after drinking until we couldn't remember anything, we had to face the Four Horsemen. Share the feeling of an awful awakening after a spree when terror and despair were waiting for you.
- 8.** The text says a serious drinker who is dry will say they don't miss it and feel better, but we know they are just whistling in the darkness. Have you ever lied to yourself or others about how much you missed alcohol while trying to stay dry?
- 9.** The chapter describes the jumping-off place as where you cannot imagine life either with or without alcohol. How close have you been to that point?
- 10.** The text says a person who reaches the jumping-off place will wish to end their life. What kept you from giving up entirely during your darkest hour?
- 11.** The chapter says there is a replacement for alcohol and it will give you more than liquor ever could—the Fellowship. What are you most afraid of losing when you stop drinking, and what do you hope the Fellowship will give you instead?
- 12.** The text says the most satisfying years of your existence are said to lie ahead of you. What is one thing you hope to find in recovery that alcohol never gave you?
- 13.** The chapter says you are going to meet new friends in your own community, and near you alcoholics are dying helplessly like people on a sinking ship. How are you reaching out to those near you who are still suffering?
- 14.** The text says you will feel connected to these new friends deeply and permanently because you will escape from disaster together. Describe a connection you have made in A.A. that feels stronger than your old drinking friendships.
- 15.** The chapter says you will learn the full meaning of love your neighbor as you love yourself. What specific act of generosity have you performed this week to help another person survive?

We have found a solution

- 1.** The text says our own recovery proves that the age of miracles is now. Share a change in your life that feels truly miraculous today.
- 2.** The chapter says defeated drinkers seize upon this book like a sinking ship's crew grabs for a raft. How did you feel when you first realized there was a way out of your situation?
- 3.** The text says families adopting this way of life create a ripple effect. How has your recovery influenced the choices and behavior of the people living under your roof?
- 4.** The chapter says a glimpse into your future is provided by the growth of the Fellowship. What does the prospect of a long-term sober life look like to you now?
- 5.** The text tells the story of a businessman on a bad business trip who found himself in a strange city feeling bitter and discouraged. Describe a high-stress professional or personal situation where you chose the program over a drink.
- 6.** The chapter says the businessman found himself in a hotel lobby staring at an attractive bar at the other end. What stopped you from walking through the wrong door the last time you were on thin ice?
- 7.** The text says the businessman asked himself if he could handle just a few drinks with ginger ale, and then remembered his responsibilities and the people who would die if he didn't know how to get well. Who are the people you are choosing to stay sober for this week?
- 8.** The chapter says insanity returns when we think we can handle just a few drinks. How are you reminding yourself of the danger of that first drink today?
- 9.** The text says the businessman thought about the church directory and the bar door as two different paths. What is the specific action you take when you feel yourself moving toward the wrong door?
- 10.** The chapter says others will die if you do not know how to get well. How does the weight of this responsibility affect your commitment to the steps and to your own recovery?
- 11.** The text says finding a solution together is the tremendously important fact for all of us. How does the shared experience of the Fellowship make you feel less alone in your battle?
- 12.** The chapter says we are average Americans from all backgrounds who normally would not mix. Describe a person in the program you have befriended whom you would have ignored or avoided before recovery.
- 13.** The text says escape from disaster is the powerful cement that binds us together. What is the shared peril that you discuss most often with your fellows in the program?
- 14.** The chapter says we have found a way out on which we can absolutely agree. How are you practicing brotherly and harmonious action in your home group?
- 15.** The text says if you wish for recovery more than anything and are willing to learn from our experiences, we are sure it will come. How willing are you today compared to when you first opened this book?

How Alcoholics Anonymous has grown

- 1.** The text says a New York businessman and an Akron doctor started this journey, and the simplicity of their first meeting is the foundation of everything that followed. How does the simplicity of one alcoholic talking to another inspire your own service work?
- 2.** The chapter says it took three years to sober up a handful of people, showing the slow start of the movement. How are you practicing patience with your own rate of growth in recovery?
- 3.** The text says failure and time are part of the history of A.A.'s success. Share a personal failure in recovery that eventually led to a breakthrough or a deeper understanding.
- 4.** The chapter says transmitting a message without it being distorted is a major challenge. How are you ensuring that your story stays anchored to the truth of the Big Book rather than drifting into your own opinions?
- 5.** The text says providence and mercy have thrown a new light into our dark caves. Describe the darkness you were living in before you found this program.
- 6.** The chapter says the light of recovery must be reflected to reach the millions who still don't know about A.A. What is one way you are reflecting that light in your neighborhood or community?
- 7.** The text says handing off the message to those who can carry it further is our duty. Who have you shared your experience with this month?
- 8.** The chapter says elation and ecstasy seize those who see the program finally succeeding in another person's life. Describe a moment of pure joy you felt when witnessing someone else's breakthrough in recovery.
- 9.** The text says providential timing often brings the right people together at the right moment. Share an experience where you met exactly who you needed at exactly the right time.
- 10.** The chapter says dark worlds are brightened by the presence of a solution. What is the brightest part of your day now that the fog of alcohol has lifted?
- 11.** The text says not all drunks in the world can come to one place, so the message must be carried outward. How are you bringing the program to people who cannot get to a meeting on their own?
- 12.** The chapter says distorted and garbled messages are dangerous for the alcoholic who receives them. How are you using the Plain Language Big Book to keep the message clear and accessible?
- 13.** The text says a couple of dozen sober people was the beginning of a miracle that now spans the globe. How do you see yourself as part of this ongoing history?
- 14.** The chapter says mercy is found in the providence that allows us to recover. What is the most merciful thing that has happened to you in sobriety?
- 15.** The text says small numbers can represent a huge shift when those people are carrying a message of life and death. How do you value the single individual's recovery in the face of a worldwide problem?

Finding more fellows

- 1.** The text says staying spiritually active is the only way to remain sober. What is your daily plan to keep your spiritual fire burning?
- 2.** The chapter describes the boldness of early A.A. members calling head nurses to find prospects in hospitals. How are you being bold in your search for people to help?
- 3.** The text says a real winner is sometimes a person who has just been strapped down in a hospital bed. Why is it important to never give up on the most difficult and seemingly hopeless cases?
- 4.** The chapter says being a nobody in your own eyes is a symptom of the destruction alcoholism causes. How has the program helped you regain your sense of being somebody who matters?
- 5.** The text says the description of a hopeless goner is familiar to many of us. How do you respond to someone who says they are beyond fixing or too far gone?
- 6.** The chapter says laughing together at the image of our past behaviors is a sign of health and recovery. Share a tragic part of your own story that you can now find humor in.
- 7.** The text says acute poisoning warps the mind and deteriorates the body. How are you cooperating with your own healing process today, physically and spiritually?
- 8.** The chapter says praying on hangover mornings and swearing off was a common cycle before recovery. How is your current prayer life different from the desperate bargains you used to make with God?
- 9.** The text says God ought to be able to do anything is a turning point in belief for many alcoholics. What is the impossible thing you are asking your Higher Power to help you with right now?
- 10.** The chapter says walking from the hospital a free man is a powerful image of recovery. What does freedom from alcohol feel like in your daily routine?
- 11.** The text says political campaigns, restaurant visits, and other social events are tests of a new sober life. How are you remaining grounded when you are in environments where drinking is common?
- 12.** The chapter says finding God and finding yourself are often the same event. Describe the person you discovered you were once you got sober and cleared away the wreckage.
- 13.** The text says returning to a faith that was left behind is part of the journey for some members. How has your childhood religion or early spiritual experience been transformed by your A.A. experience?
- 14.** The chapter says three alcoholics believing they must give away what they found is the root of the entire community. How are you contributing to the survival of your own group?
- 15.** The text says a narrow margin of defeat in life can turn into a spiritual victory. Share a loss you experienced that actually brought you closer to your Higher Power.

The fourth member, and beyond

- 1.** The text says a reckless young man whose parents couldn't tell if he wanted to stop drinking agreed to go to the hospital and said the spiritual stuff makes sense. Who in your life is currently resisting the spiritual solution you have found?
- 2.** The chapter says the young man's parents were deeply religious and shocked by his rejection of their values. How are you practicing tolerance for those who do not share your beliefs about God or recovery?
- 3.** The text says after a little while the young man said I guess the old folks were right after all. What piece of traditional wisdom or parental advice are you now ready to accept that you once rejected?
- 4.** The chapter says these men knew they needed to help other alcoholics to remain sober, but what mattered more was the happiness they found in talking with others. Describe a conversation in recovery that made you feel better than a drink ever could.
- 5.** The text says they shared their homes, their small savings, and gladly spent their free time with fellow sufferers. What are you willing to sacrifice to help another alcoholic today?
- 6.** The chapter says they experienced a few upsetting failures with alcoholics who could not follow suggestions. How are you managing your ego and your disappointment when someone you are helping slips or walks away?
- 7.** The text says they tried to bring the person's family into a spiritual way of living when the alcoholic wouldn't cooperate. How is your partner or family benefiting from the spiritual principles you are practicing?
- 8.** The chapter describes little gatherings of people all feeling happy and relieved as the heartbeat of A.A. Describe the last time you felt this kind of relief and happiness in a group of recovering people.
- 9.** The text says formal meetings provided a time and place where new people could bring their problems. How are you making your home group more welcoming and useful to the newcomer?
- 10.** The chapter describes a couple who turned their entire home into a center for A.A. work. What is one way you can make your home a more spiritual environment for the people who enter it?
- 11.** The text says many worried partners visited that house to find loving and understanding companionship. How are you being a better companion to your own spouse or partner today?
- 12.** The chapter describes a woman stepping into a house full of recovering people and feeling safe at last. What was the first thing you did or felt when you truly experienced the safety of the Fellowship?
- 13.** The text says members laughed at their own bad luck and understood hers. Share a recent mishap or hardship that you were able to laugh about rather than get angry or bitter about.
- 14.** The chapter says the house became too small for all its visitors, which is a sign of growth. How are you helping your local Fellowship expand its reach to people who need it?
- 15.** The text says they had seen a better way to live and done it by connecting with their Higher Power. What does the better way to live look like for you in concrete, daily terms?

The Fellowship today

- 1.** The text says social differences, arguments, and jealousies all get left at the door of the Fellowship. Where are you still allowing ego or status to interfere with your recovery?
- 2.** The chapter says in the Fellowship we have all ridden on the same shipwrecked boat, only to be saved and repaired by God. How does this shared history help you forgive a difficult member of your group?
- 3.** The text says no one has sunk too low to be welcomed by us, as long as they honestly want to recover. Who are you currently making peace with in your family or in your A.A. community?
- 4.** The chapter says the things that matter so much to some people no longer matter to us. What material goal or worldly ambition have you given up in favor of a spiritual one?
- 5.** The text says we are incredibly grateful to the doctors who believe in our work and refer patients to the program. How has a professional's support or belief in A.A. helped you or someone you know?
- 6.** The chapter says an uncanny understanding exists between those who have suffered together. How has this shared language of recovery helped you win the trust of a stranger?
- 7.** The text says some of us travel to visit local A.A. groups while away from home, lending a hand and avoiding temptation. Share an experience of finding a meeting or a home group feeling far from your own town.
- 8.** The chapter says you may be thinking you are jittery and alone and couldn't do what these people have done. What source of power are you tapping into when your own strength fails?
- 9.** The text says doing what we have done only requires willingness, patience, and hard work. Which of these three is currently your biggest challenge?
- 10.** The chapter says creating the Fellowship you want to be part of is your own responsibility. What specific action are you taking to build the recovery community you want to live in?
- 11.** The text says God will determine the outcome of your journey. How are you practicing reliance on God when you feel lonely or uncertain in your recovery?
- 12.** The chapter says asking God every morning what you can do for the person who is still sick is our daily duty. What was your answer to that question this morning?
- 13.** The text says obviously you cannot give something you haven't got. What are you doing today to strengthen your own relationship with your Higher Power so you have something real to offer others?
- 14.** The chapter says great events will come to pass for you and for countless others. What is the most exciting possibility you see for your future today?
- 15.** The text says abandon yourself to God, admit your faults, and clear away the wreckage of your past. What is the final barrier you are ready to let go of to be truly free?

Chapter 11 Closing Prompts

- 1.** Reflecting on the Four Horsemen, which one was the hardest for you to outrun, and which one still shows up occasionally?
- 2.** How has your vision for your life changed since you first picked up this book?
- 3.** Describe the substitute you have found for alcohol and why it is more satisfying than drinking ever was.
- 4.** Which story of growth in the Fellowship inspires you the most right now?
- 5.** How are you practicing the principle of love your neighbor as yourself in your workplace, your home, or your community?
- 6.** What is the biggest obstacle you face in staying spiritually active every single day?
- 7.** Share a moment when you felt the presence and power of your Higher Power in a meeting or in a quiet moment alone.
- 8.** How has your definition of a lifelong friend changed since you entered recovery?
- 9.** Describe the feeling of no longer needing to whistle in the dark to convince yourself that sobriety is working.
- 10.** What is the most miraculous change you have seen in another person's life because of this program?
- 11.** How are you ensuring that your relationship with God remains your real reliance rather than depending on people, money, or circumstances?
- 12.** What part of your home life or your inner life is still under construction?
- 13.** Share a hope you carry for the millions of alcoholics who still don't know about the solution described in this book.
- 14.** How has the Fellowship helped you rediscover the joy and imagination that alcohol stole from you?
- 15.** What is the next right action for your journey on the Broad Highway of recovery?

Principles in This Chapter

- 1. Faith:** Share a time you relied on your Higher Power when you were far from home, far from comfort, and genuinely afraid.
- 2. Hope:** How has hearing the story of a far-gone alcoholic who recovered renewed your own commitment to the program?
- 3. Love:** Describe an act of service where you put another person's survival ahead of your own convenience or comfort.
- 4. Fellowship:** How does being bound by new and wonderful ties to other recovering people help you avoid the jumping-off place?
- 5. Generosity:** Share a time you gave of yourself—your time, your money, your attention—to help another person rediscover life.
- 6. Responsibility:** How are you honoring your duty to carry this message to others who are still dying from alcoholism?
- 7. Humility:** Share what it felt like to admit you were powerless and needed a solution that came from God rather than from yourself.
- 8. Patience:** Reconstruction of a life takes years, not weeks. Share how you are being patient with the slow growth of your recovery and your community.
- 9. Courage:** Describe a situation where you chose to stay sober despite being surrounded by people who were drinking.
- 10. Integrity:** How are you ensuring that the message you carry to others is not distorted or garbled by your own ego or opinions?
- 11. Willingness:** What is one labor you are performing this week to duplicate the success of the pioneers who started this Fellowship?
- 12. Service:** Share the joy you felt witnessing a miracle in someone else's recovery that you helped make possible.
- 13. Tolerance:** How are you welcoming people into your group regardless of their social background, their beliefs, or their appearance?
- 14. Harmony:** Describe how your group settles differences and disagreements through the spirit of love and understanding rather than argument.
- 15. Vision:** What is the satisfying future you are now able to imagine for yourself that you could never have imagined while drinking?

Putting It Into Practice

- 1.** Seek the newcomer this week. Contact a local hospital, doctor, or treatment center today to ask if there is an alcoholic who needs a visit.
- 2.** Ask God every morning this week what you can do for the person who is still sick. Write down whatever answer comes to you and act on it.
- 3.** Spend fifteen minutes today in quiet prayer to strengthen your conscious contact with your Higher Power.
- 4.** Lend your copy of this book to someone who is currently dry but not happy. Tell them what it did for you.
- 5.** Write down three things you want to see happen in your Fellowship this year. Share them with a trusted member and start working toward one.
- 6.** The next time you are in a social situation where alcohol is present, explain to a friend why you are not drinking. Practice saying it out loud with confidence.
- 7.** Identify one task from the early history of A.A.—visiting a hospital, opening your home, making a phone call—that you will perform this week.
- 8.** Do one anonymous act of kindness for a neighbor or stranger who is struggling. Don't tell anyone you did it.
- 9.** Re-read a chapter of the Plain Language Big Book this week to refresh your understanding of the core message before sharing it with someone else.
- 10.** Reach out to a fellow member you haven't spoken to in a while. Check on their journey and offer your support.
- 11.** Offer to drive a newcomer to a meeting or a doctor's appointment this week. Show up and be useful.
- 12.** Throughout this week, ask yourself what you can bring to every situation rather than what you can get from it.
- 13.** Identify one plan you are trying to force into existence by your own willpower. Turn it over to God today and let it unfold.
- 14.** Complete a mini-inventory tonight. Admit any new wrongs to a trusted friend or your sponsor before you go to sleep.
- 15.** Make a commitment to attend one extra meeting this week specifically for the purpose of welcoming the newcomer who walks through the door.